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KENYATTA UNIVERSITY

INSTITUTE OF OPEN LEARNING

ARE 200: COMPARATIVE RELIGION

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Introductory notes

The term comparative designates the task of discovering data and comparing them without any biases at all. It assumes that there are common elements that cut across most of the religions of the world. It is such elements therefore, that this course seeks to discover and compare with an open mind. In this view Comparative Religion could be defined as the scientific and, thus impartial study of the various religions of the world with a view to discovering the resemblances and differences within the religious ideas, beliefs, and practices.

The comparative approach to the study of religion seeks to create not only more understanding on culture, humanity and society but also an appreciation of the diversity of religious world view. It should be noted that the task of this course is not to defend any religious faith, but to understand religion by examining the themes that cut across the world religions. The module begins with theories and functions of religion followed by discussion on each of the world religions. The module finally closes with a comparative study of all the main themes or dimensions of religion.

The Module is divided into three main parts. Part I examines the definitions, theories and functions of religion as well as the historical background of religion and the ancient religions. Part II examines the major religions of the world, while part III compares the themes or dimensions that are common to world religions.

Part I and III of this Module were written by Dr. C. Kavivya, while Dr. J. Gitome produced part II. Both lecturers, who are members of staff in the Department of Religious Studies, Kenyatta University, have taught the unit, Comparative Religion, for many years at university level.

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PART ONE: INTRODUCTION TO COMPARATIVE RELIGION

Part one of this Module covers general definitions, theories and functions of religion and goes on to give a brief historical and cultural background of religion. The section also examines ancient religions e.g. Egyptian, Greek, Roman and African Religion with a view to establish how they might have influenced each other as well as the modern religions.

LESSON 1: DEFINITION AND THEORIES OF RELIGION

1.1 Introduction

Religion is not only the oldest discipline but also a very complex subject or phenomenon of study, which is indeed difficult to capture comprehensively in one statement. To understand religion, therefore it is imperative to investigate how the external and the internal meaning of religion are fused. Various scholars have put forward different definitions with a view to capturing the essence, nature, purpose or function of religion. Lesson 1 seeks to examine such definition and then go on to examine theories that have been advanced on religion.

1.2 Objectives

By the end of this lesson the learner should be able to:

- Define religion in their own words.
- Bring out the major theories of religion.

1.3 Content

1.3.1 Definition of Religion

The word **religion** is derived from a Latin word **religio**, which means awe or fear in the presence of a supernatural being or God. It is a universal phenomenon that seeks to address deep inescapable human needs/wants.

Durkheim defines religion as a unified set of beliefs and practices related to the sacred things. These beliefs and practices unify the members into a community of believers.

According to Fredrick Streng, religious concern exposes the most profound meaning of existence. He defines religion as a means of ultimate transformation. He argues that believers must act according to certain rules/ regulations, which are usually prescribed by their religion.

E. B. Taylor defines religion as the belief in spiritual beings. He regards it as an experience of the mystical and spiritual powers.

Paul Tillich regards religion as the ultimate concern. To him religion is indeed vital for humanity. But to Ritt Codrington, religion has to do with ancestor worship, magical practices and **mana**.

Note :

Mana is a kind of supernatural force or power that exists everywhere and could influence humanity for good or bad. Mana is transmissible from one natural object to another e.g. from a tree to a person or from a person to a bird.

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Generally speaking, therefore, religion has to do with the belief in and worship of the divine or the supernatural power or reality. It has beliefs, code of ethics, rituals and practices and involves the individual and the society. It has sacred places, persons and things. It determines what is sacred and what is profane or what is acceptable and what is to be regarded as evil and thus rejected. It is an emotional experience mixed with fear, awe, reverence, admiration and love towards the supernatural beings. It could be said to be the sum total of the ideas, beliefs and practices of the individual, group or the society towards the supernatural existence.

1.3.2 Theories of Religion

The first systematic efforts to study religion as a phenomenon originated in the 19th century with scholars such as William Roberts, James Frazer, Edward E. B. Taylor, and Andrew Lang among others. Most of these were influenced by the biological evolutionary theory of Charles Darwin, the origin of species. These and other early anthropologists attempted apply cultural evolution theories to study the origin and development of religion.

According to E.B. Taylor religious beliefs arose from man's need to explain the impossible such as sleep, dreams, hallucinations, life, death etc. This need realized the origin of religion to give meaning to such realities. He argues that all primitive (preliterate) societies had **animistic** forms of religion. Societies later evolved from animism to **polytheism** then to **monotheism**, the highest level of religious beliefs and practices.

Note:

Animism comes from the Latin word **anima** which is translated to mean the soul or spirit. Animism is derived from the belief that all natural things such as animals, birds, insects, plants, fish, stones etc have souls or spirits, and that these spirits migrate from one nature to another.

According to James Frazer, religion is an appeal to supernatural beings for solutions to the problems that cannot be satisfactorily solved by magic, a form of primitive science. Magic according to him is an attempt to understand the natural forces while religion is an attempt to understand supernatural forces. For Frazer knowledge of the supernatural reality began when men experienced certain extraordinary emotions and conceived extraordinary ideas for which they could not account in ordinary forms of experience. These forces were designated as actions of a powerful spirit or deity. Frazer argues that after religion was founded, it assumed two forms, animism or worship of nature and worship of ancestors.

Bronislow Malinowski observes that primitive societies were aware of the difference between religion and Magic. According to him religion creates values and processes ultimate ends. Magic on the other hand has practical utilitarian purpose and is understood to be only a means to an end. To him, magic is the spontaneous activity in human situation of stress when recourse to all naturalistic laws had failed.

Durkheim says that the earliest forms of religion was **totemism**, the belief that there is some magic affinity between a society and a certain plant or an animal, which is treated with awe and reverence. The totem has a special relationship with the group of people which identifies itself with the object. Totem is not merely an idea but a symbol for sacred where by the individual becomes one with the sacred. The totemic clan could not exist without the totem,

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which united the members. He sees totemic beliefs, therefore, as the most primitive forms of religion that developed into ancestral worship.

Note:

Totemic societies have special affinity or strong attachment to certain things especially animals, birds or plants, which in most cases are revered to the point of being worshiped. The survival of the totemic clan, thus, depends largely on the totem.

Wilhelm Schmidt and Mercea Eliade concur that most the early or pre literate societies had the notion of a high God or supreme being whom they worshiped. However the Supreme being did not play a central role in their religious life. To Eliade religious symbols emerged from the human need to live comfortably in the paradigmatic world.

1.4 Question

Using your own words put down six definitions of religion.

1.5 Activity

Interview people from your community or in your place of work about what they know regarding the origin of their respective religions.

1.6 Summary

The discussion in lesson I reveals clearly the complexity surrounding the origin and development religion. We found religion to be as old as the human race and that as societies evolved so did religious beliefs and practices. We found that religion due to its complexity would be difficult to define in a single sentence. Scholars of religion, have therefore come up with a several definitions to capture the essence of religion. The lesson below examines the functions of religion.

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1.7 Definition of key words

Religion: The term is derived from a Latin word *religio* meaning to treat with care, fear, awe, love and respect.

Animism: This comes from a Latin word *anima*, meaning soul or spirit. Animism is, thus the attribution of a living soul to inanimate objects or nature.

Mana: A force or indwelling supernatural power distinct from either persons or spirits, which is believed to act of itself.

Totemism: Comes from the Ameridian (American – Indian) word *totem*, which means relative. A totem is a natural object, especially an animal or a plant adopted by a community, tribe or family as its sacred ancestor.

Monotheism: The belief in and worship of one God.

Polytheism: The belief in and worship of many gods.

1.8 Further Reading

1. Lessa, W.A. and Vogt, E.Z. 1958. *Readers in Comparative Religion: An Anthropological Approach*. New York, Harper and Row.
2. Smart, N.1989. *The World's Religions: Old and Modern Transformation*. Cambridge University Press.
3. Hamilton, M. 2001. *The Sociology of Religion: Theoretical and Comparative Perspectives* (2nd Edition), London, Routledge.

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LESSON 2: FUNCTIONS OF RELIGION

Religion has many functions both to the individual as well as to the society as discussed below.

2.1 Introduction

In the previous section we have examined the definitions and theories of religion. We found that religion is as old as the human race and that both evolved hand in hand. We found that religion has to do with the worship of God or gods. Lesson 2 seeks to examine the functions of religion.

2.2 Objectives

By the end of this lesson the learner should be able to

- Show the functions of religion
- Demonstrate how religion responds or has failed to respond to certain human needs.

2.3 Content

2.3.1 Regulation of human behaviour

According to Durkheim, religion seeks to regulate human relations with spiritual beings, thus the study of religion cannot take place outside the social environment. To him religion is the creation of the pressure of social obligations that are related to the supernatural realm. He argues that religious forces are human forces that add a new dimension to natural perception. These religious forces manifest themselves in social interaction and collective life.

Sigmund Freud regards religion as the product of man's helplessness and fear of the conscience. To him religion is a regulator of life which expresses unfulfilled goals and provides a means for avoiding the guilt of not attaining these goals. For Freud, religion is the social control over the individual inner self or energy of the psyche.

2.3.2 Social mobilizer or a unifying factor

Fredrick Streng identifies religion as the formation of conceptual, ritual and societal symbols, whereby a community/ society identifies itself in relation to a transcendent or supernatural order of reality. To him religion is a strong social mobilizer and integrator of a group of people.

Religion unifies and integrates individuals into a social group. It provides an integrating force through which a person can identify himself / herself with others. Religious symbols integrate the routine everyday life of the individual and at the same time create the basic structures and symbols whereby one finds meaning in life.

2.3.3 Sigh for the oppressed

Religion is part of the natural mechanism whereby human beings identify themselves, integrate their experiences and find release from tension and frustrations. **Rites of passage, rituals** and sacrifices in preliterate societies emphasized education and integrative functions of religion.

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To Karl Marx religion could be seen as a kind of opium for the people since it gives sigh to the oppressed and heart to the heartless. But religion is also a source of social, economic and political liberation to the oppressed.

2.3.4 Personality development

Religion plays a significant role in the self organization of the personality. In this view religion becomes a form of both personal and social behaviour. It leads to personality development, social growth, self and emotional control as well as social behaviour. And as such it forms the human person, making them different from animals.

2.3.5 Form of defense and security

Religion is a form of defense against irrational forces. It gives people something to hold to in times of personal /social crisis. It gives life a sense of meaning in the face of biological physical, social psychological and any other form of threat including death. Thus, religion is a kind of force which gives stability and reinforcement to the person and the society in the face of disaster, by providing or promising more significant rewards e.g. eternal peace/heaven, nirvana etc.

2.3.6 Cultural order and habit

Religion could be seen as a cultural habit. It is also a system of ideas and emotional responses through which the society interprets and validates it self. Religion preserves the integrity of society through rites and rituals. It provides general conceptions about the order of existence. These become assumptions on which the patterns of culture are built e.g. creation myths.

Anthropologists view religion as a product of human imagination that functions to establish patterns of cultural self awareness and communication and the means to establish equilibrium within society after a crisis such as war or death of a leader.

2. 4 Question

Does your religion help you in any way to meet your daily needs? If yes, how and if no why?

2.5 Activity

Visit a church, mosque, temple or any other place of worship. Interview more than five worshipers on the functions of their religion

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2.6 Summary

We found in this section that religion is a universal phenomenon, which is hard to capture in a single definition. It has to do with the belief in and worship of the divine or the supernatural power or powers. It determines what is sacred and what is profane. It is an emotional experience that has elements of love fear, awe, respect and admiration. Religion has many functions some of which includes the regulation of human behaviour, personality development as well as a unifying factor. It mainly seeks to answer deep inescapable human needs that other disciplines have been unable to address adequately.

2.7 Definition of key words

Rites of passage: these are significant actions and rituals that mark the process of moving from one status in life or community to another.

Ritual: a religious ceremony performed according to a set pattern of words, movements and symbols, e.g. worship, festivals, rites of passage and other religious actions.

2.8 Further Reading

Lessa, W.A. and Vogt, E.Z. 1958. *Readers in Comparative Religion: An Anthropological Approach*. New York, Harper and Row.

Smart, N.1989. *The World's Religions: Old and Modern Transformation*. Cambridge University Press.

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LESSON 3: HISTORICAL AND CULTURAL BACKGROUND OF RELIGION

3.1 Introduction

In lesson 1 we defined religion as a universal phenomenon that developed together with the evolution of societies. We found that religion has many functions and as such societies can hardly function properly without religion. Lesson 2 will give a brief historical background of religion with a view to establish their similarities and differences.

3.2 Objective

- By the end of this lesson students should be able to show the origin and spread of the major religions of the world.

3.3: Content

3.3.1 Origin and Spread of Religions

i) Egypt and Middle East

Historians of religion have not been able to construct an intellectually acceptable theory to explain satisfactorily the origin of religion. However there is evidence that religious practices were practiced in the prehistoric times especially in the Middle East, where early civilization is traced back to about 4000 BCE. With the beginning of early civilization in Egypt and Mesopotamia cities developed and so did temples and religious cults. This is to say that religion grew hand in hand with human civilization. Writing which was invented in Egypt provided a creative means of expressing man's religious heritage.

Egypt and Mesopotamia became centers of civilization, which later spread further east in the Indus Valley, N. W. India, and China, developing religious cultures. It is no accident, therefore, that most of the world religions are said to have originated in Middle-east as we shall see later.

Sometimes around the 6th century BC in the Middle East a monotheistic faith called **Zoroastrianism**, was founded by **Zoroaster**. The only other true monotheistic religion at that time was **Hebrew**, the religion of the Semitic people who occupied the area between Egypt and Mesopotamia. From Hebrew, also known as **Judaism**, sprung up yet another monotheistic religion, **Christianity**, which by the 4th century AD has spread to Europe, N. Africa and Middle East. By then it was the official religion of the Romans.

ii) Palestine and India

In ancient Palestine there developed a monotheistic faith through the Hebrew tradition called Judaism, which later became the foundation upon which Christianity and **Islam** were founded. This was also the period when the Hindu Scriptures, the **Upanishads**, were composed in India. During the same period religious teachers developed in India, e.g. **Buddha** and **Mahavira**, whose teachings later developed into **Buddhism** and **Jainism** respectively. Buddhism has been and continues to be among the most influential religions in India and other parts of Asia unlike Jainism, which has mainly remained a religion of the Indian sub-continent. By the 11th century AD, Buddhist missionaries were already in Europe, America, and other parts of the world spreading the religion.

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iii) China and Japan

Other religious teachers who came to influence religion and life in Asia were **Confucius** and **Lao-Tse**. **Confucianism**, which was founded by **Confucius** has remained a powerful religion in Chinese cultures. Lao-Tse founded **Taoism**, which later influenced Buddhism in China, developing a new sect of Buddhism called **Zen Buddhism**. Taoism became a dominant religion in China by the 2nd century AD. The other religions that were influential in China by that time were Confucianism and Buddhism. In Japan the indigenous faith, **Shintoism**, survived in spite of the intrusion of Confucianism, Taoism and Buddhism.

iv) Arabia, Africa and Europe

In the 7th Century AD the teaching of **Mohammed** began to spread beyond his Arabian homeland and in about 50 years Islam became the dominant religion in N. Africa, Middle East and Central Asia, and by the 15th century Islam had penetrated into Europe where Christianity had dominated.

It should be noted that most of the religions mentioned above slowly by slowly started to eat out the indigenous cultural religions almost wiping them out. One of the victims of such influence was African Religion, which was condemned almost to death because it was seen as a form of ancestral worship, magic and witchcraft. Nonetheless most of the ancient religions and cultures, as we shall see, continued to influence modern religions to some extent up to the present.

Note

Many religions of the world had their origin in Middle East, especially the region around Mesopotamia, which, together with Egypt is associated with early civilization.

3.5 Summary

In lesson 2 we have examined the origin and spread of religions. It is clear that the earliest religions and civilizations, which grew hand in hand, were found in Africa, especially Egypt and in the Arabian Desert. And as societies evolved so did religion, spreading all over the world where human societies existed. Nowhere in the world has there been a non-religious society and that is why religion is seen as a common phenomenon.

3.6 Question

Find out the founders, the places of origin and the cultural background of Hinduism, Buddhism, Zoroastrianism, Taoism, Shintoism, Sikhism, Jainism, Confucianism, Judaism, Christianity, Islam.

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3.7 Activity

Visit any place of worship e.g. church, mosque, temple etc to interview religious leaders on the historical background of their respective religions in that particular location or area.

3.8 Further Reading

Ling, T. 1968. *A History of Religion East and West*. London; Macmillan.

Beaver, R.P. et.al. 1982. *The World Religions*. Icknield Way, Lion Publishing.

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LESSON 4: EGYPTIAN RELIGION AND CULTURE

4.1 Introduction

In the previous lesson we examined the historical and cultural background of religion. We found that indeed religion and early civilization grew hand in hand. It is for this reason that the earliest religions are associated with the Egyptian, the Hindu and the Mesopotamian civilizations. Lesson 3 will examine the religious culture of the Egyptians with a view to establishing how it could have influenced what is now referred to as the major religions of the world.

4.2 Objectives

By the end of this Lesson the learner should:

- Demonstrate sufficient knowledge on the Egyptian religion and culture.
- Be able to show how the Egyptian religion could have influenced modern religions.

3.3 Content

3. 3.1 Divinity

The Egyptian culture and religion, which are among the oldest in human history were rich and complex. Egypt, which dependent largely on the Nile River, was ruled by the pharaohs who were said to be divine. The sun and the moon were worshiped and so were certain animals. Many of the Egyptian gods had animal heads. The oldest and also the most important Egyptian **deity** was the **Sun-god**, believed to be the god of creation. The sun-god was symbolized by sun rays.

Osiris was another important god. This was the god of life, vegetation, judgment and civilization. Osiris was in the form of a sacred bull, which would be killed secretly by the priests and a younger one chosen. There was also the moon- god, believed to be the god of wisdom, science and reconciliation. Another important god was the god of the Nile river, who was the god of water and fertility. One god could take many forms e.g. Osiris took the form of a bull, a pillar, a dead pharaoh etc. He was the source of life, and fertility of animals, plants and human beings.

Egypt had many **myths** but the most important one was the **triad** of **Osiris, Isis and Horus**, which came to influence other religions including Christianity. According to the myth, Osiris, the giver of life and culture, was killed by his brother **Set**. But Isis brought him back magically. Horus, the son of Isis later defeated Set in vengeance. Later Osiris became judge and Lord in the underworld and through him believers could be brought back to life after death.

Note:

The myth about Osiris has parallels with the Christian myth of Trinity and redemption as we shall see later.

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3.3.2 Rituals

The Egyptian religion had many rituals to appease their gods. During such rituals water and incense were used for cleansing. Animals were sacrificed and presented before the gods, who were dressed with robes and jewels and were also anointed with oil. Temples were both places of worship and also dwelling places for gods. Only the priests and their servants were allowed in the innermost chamber of the temple in which the gods lived. Priesthood was a prestigious and wealthy vocation. The work of the priests and their servants were to sustain the world order by revitalizing the gods with food and hymns daily.

The Egyptian religion had a mortuary cult and a belief in immortality, an indication of the belief in life after death. The **mummification** ritual in which the dead body would be extracted the brain and the intestines, then applied with preservatives was an important aspect of the Egyptian religion. The corpse would later be wrapped, then covered with amulets and placed in a mummy case. The mummy case was taken to the tomb in a procession. The Egyptian religion had not only countless gods but also many temples and great mortuary pyramids. The belief in immortality was common. However good life in the present /material world was also cherished/admired.

3.3.3 Socio-political Life

Ancient Egypt was a prosperous and fortunate society. The government was strong and stable and remained so for a long time. Remember it was in Egypt that the Israelites could go for food. It is also here that the founder of Christianity took refuge. The land was out of way of major enemies. By the use of the Nile River, the Egyptians had enough food for themselves and their neighbours. The temples were not only the dwelling places for gods but were also centers of cultural tradition and education. Slavery was useful in the construction of temples and pyramids.

4.4 Question

What were the roles or duties given to the Egyptian gods?

4.5 Activity

Interview member of your community on beliefs and practices regarding death and after life. Compare the responses with the Egyptian immortality beliefs and practices.

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4.6 Summary

In this lesson we have found that the early Egyptians had a very rich religion with many gods. They had gods of the solar system, vegetation, animals, fertility and so on, all of which sustained the Egyptian culture and civilization. The Egyptians believed in immortality, that is why they had a very rich mortuary cult and great mortuary pyramids. They had a powerful political system. The society largely depended on the River Nile for water and food.

4.7: Key words

Myths: Sacred stories that seek to explain the origin, nature and development of religions. They are the story side of religion.

Deity: From the Latin word, Deus meaning God in the divine nature.

Triad: A group of three gods who share nature and or activities.

Mummification: The preparation and preservation of a dead body by the Egyptians.

4.8: Further Reading

Ling, T. 1968. *A History of Religion East and West*. London; Macmillan.

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LESSON 5: THE RELIGION OF MESOPOTAMIA

5.1 Introduction

In the previous Lesson we looked at the Egyptian religion and culture and we found that the Egyptian Civilization came to influence modern culture and religion. This lesson will examine the religion of Mesopotamia with a view to establishing not only how it developed but also how it could have influenced the development of other religions that later sprung up in the same region.

5.2 Objectives

By the end of this Lesson learners should:

- Present background information on the religion of Mesopotamia.
- Be able to show how the religion of Mesopotamia could have influenced other religions, especially Hebrew.

5.3 Content

5.3.1 Culture and Civilization

The ancient civilization of the valley between the rivers, Tigris and Euphrates, usually referred to as Mesopotamia, (modern Iraq) is comparable to that of ancient Egypt. Both were agrarian culture in dry areas, watered by rivers. The rivers were associated with divinities who would bless with harvest and punish at certain times through floods. Both Egypt and Mesopotamia embraced rich polytheistic cultures. However, unlike Egypt, Mesopotamia was much more exposed to war. The ancient Mesopotamia, just like the Egyptians, were creative although the culture of the Mesopotamians was not as stable as that of the Egyptians.

The Mesopotamians were of three races i.e. the Sumerians, who lived in the lower part of Mesopotamian basin, between 4000-2000BC, the Semitic people who were related to the Hebrews and the Arabs and the Persians. The Sumerians were the earliest people (4000-2000 BCE) of Mesopotamia. It is unknown how they came about and with whom they were related. Their language is not similar to any other.

The Semitic people were related to the Hebrews and the Arabs. These two races suppressed the Sumerians, finally absorbing them and their culture around 2050 BCE, and for the next 1500 years the valley was ruled by two closely related but rival Semitic people, the Babylonians and the Assyrians who used written sign called cuneiform. The ancient Assyrians and the Babylonians came to an end with the conquest of Syria in 538 BCE. The Assyrians and the Babylonians borrowed much of their culture from the Sumerians, whose religious rites were used throughout the Babylonian- Assyrian period.

5.3.2 Religious Practices

The Mesopotamian religion was dominated by the worship of several deities and the practice of magic and divination. It also emphasized on the rites and beliefs concerning kinship. Each city had a temple dedicated to its patron deity. For example **Ur** had the moon-god called **Sin**. Babylon served a god named **Marduk** while Nineveh worshiped the goddess of love called **Ishtar**.

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Note:

Abram and his relatives moved from Ur to Haran where they lived until he was called by God to move to the promised land Canaan (c.f. Genesis 11: 31- 12:5). Ninevah and Babylon are mentioned in the Bible (c.f. Genesis 10:6-12).

The king was the servant of the gods and so was the whole community. The priests ministered to the gods daily. They washed, dressed and fed them. They purified the shrines/temples with water and incense. Food was also offered. Many temples had **sacred prostitutes**. Union with them by male worshippers was considered a sort of sacrament that aroused fertility i.e. procreative power. Therefore, sacred prostitutes, who were mostly girls from religious families, were greatly honoured. And as such the practice of temple prostitution was seen as a divine offering of oneself. It was associated with the gods and goddesses of love and fertility.

Note:

Sacred prostitution was common to polytheistic religions. The practice ensured fertility and procreation in the community. Such prostitutes usually lived in the temples and that is why they were believed to be sacred.

5.3.3 Deities

Although each city had a deity, some high gods were recognized almost everywhere. These were in sets of three, similar to the **Egyptian triad** and the **Christian Trinity**. The supreme triad consisted of **Anu, Enlil** and **Ea**. Anu was the king of gods, rather remote and not friendly to mankind, the husband to **Ishtar** who was the goddess of love. Enlil was the god of storm and floods and hence was not friendly to humanity. It was also him who fixed the destiny of all species at the time of creation. Ea was well disposed to humans, hence friendly. He would reverse the destructive work of Enlil. The other triad included the moon-god (**Sin**), the sun-god (**Shamash**) and Ishtar the most loved and worshiped of all the goddesses (wife of Anu).

Note:

Rituals about some of the gods and goddesses mentioned above are recorded in the Old Testament (c.f. 8:14). Temple prostitution is also mentioned in the Bible (Hosea 4:11- 19).

4.3.4 Myths

The Babylonians had a myth similar to that of the OT about Noah, where a man named **Utnapishtum** and his wife were the only survivors of a universal flood. The two were rewarded with immortality by the gods. The story goes that : long ago the gods Enlil planned to destroy humankind by flood. But Ea a god friendly to mankind warned Utnapishtum secretly. The man was instructed to build a ship in a hill in which he, his family and

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specimens of all animals could be preserved. When the waters receded the ship settled on

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mount Nisir and after seven days Utnapishtum sent out some birds, some of which did not return. The man then opened the ship and offered sacrifices to the deities.

The Babylonian religion had another myth about a snake that stole a precious herb from man. This herb enabled the snake to peel off the skin and hence become younger while man became old and eventually died. The Babylonians were this worldly people. They had no clear belief in a future life. The gods were their source of power here and now.

5.4 Questions

1. Compare the both the Babylonian and the OT creation myths.
2. Compare the Babylonian myth about the flood with that of Noah in the OT.

5.5 Activity

Interview members of your religion or ethnic group on their views on prostitution. Compare the views with what we have discussed in this lesson on prostitution.

5.6 Summary

We have found that the religio-cultural background of Mesopotamia similar to that of Egypt, these came to influence the foundation of modern civilization. We learned that the Mesopotamians were of three races, the Sumerians, the Semitics and the Persians. Mesopotamia was later ruled by the Assyrians and the Babylonians. We found that the Babylonian myths were similar to those found in the Old Testament.

5.7 Definition of key words

Trinity: The Christian doctrine that in the Godhead there are three persons: God the Father, God the Son and God the Holy Spirit and that these three form one true God, whose substance is undivided.

5.8 Further reading

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LESSON 6: THE GREEK RELIGION

6.1 Introduction

In the previous lesson we examined the religion and culture of Mesopotamia, both of which came to influence the Jewish religion among others. This Lesson will examine the philosophy, culture and religion of ancient Greece with a view to establish how it could have influenced other religions especially Christianity.

6.2 Objectives

By the end of this Lesson the learner should:

- Describe the Greek philosophy, Culture and Religion.
- Be able to show how the Greek Religion could have influenced modern religions especially Christianity.

6.3 Content

6.3.1 Philosophy

The Greek speaking Indo-European race, who were related to the **Aryan** race of India dates back to about 2000 BCE. Their settlement realized important cities such as Athens and Sparta as well as the Greek religion and philosophy. Greek gods included **Zeus** and **Dionysus**, **Apollo**, **Hermes** etc. Socrates, Plato and Aristotle, all of who lived in the 4th century BCE, were among the early Greek philosophers who came to influence modern philosophy.

Socrates, who lived between 469-399 BCE, developed the concept of an inner spirit which guided the individual. He was accused of **atheism** because of rejecting the worship of gods and later poisoned himself to death. Worshipping was the responsibility of all. This could explain why the Romans persecuted the Christians for refusing to worship the Roman gods.

One of the Socrates disciples, Plato, believed that the **Spirit** or consciousness is prior to matter, and that matter is given form by ideas. Plato argued that the divine and the transcendent realities can be perceived by expanding awareness. His view on the immortality of the soul came to influence the Jewish, Christian and Moslem thought/ philosophy.

Aristotle was more focused than both Socrates and Plato. He observed that nature worked backwards an argument which he used to explain the existence of God. He developed the argument of the un-moved mover, who created and sustains the universe. He too influenced the Jewish, Christian and Islamic philosophy.

6.3.2 Hellenistic Culture

The rule of Alexander the great (356 – 323 BCE), realized one of the greatest Greek empire, culture and civilization. The empire extended as far as Egypt, Indus Valley (India) and other parts of Middle and near East (India and China). The Greek, Egyptian and Babylonian cultures combined to produce the **Hellenistic** culture, whose period is dated between 323-32 BCE, after which the Romans took over. But the Hellenistic thought and religion continued under the Roman rule until the time of Christianity.

6.3.3 Religion

The Greek religion, like that of Egypt and Babylon was polytheistic. The religion had many

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gods of the sky, war, agriculture etc. Zeus was the god of wisdom, healing, music, harmony etc, while Hermes was the unexpected god, the one who guided souls to the underworld, the

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god of death, sleep, dreams and travelers. Greek gods were worshiped with sacrifices of animals and food. Greece had no powerful priest-hood as did both Egypt and Babylon.

The Greeks had religious festivals during certain times of the year e.g. harvest. The head of the family was the priest, hence he would offer sacrifice on behalf of the family members.

Life after death was of little significance to the Greeks. But the followers of the cult called **Orphic** (from the god Orphes, son of Appolo) believed in some kind of reincarnation through purification of the soul. The body was considered a kind of a tomb in which the divine spirit was trapped. This came to influence the religion of the Hellenistic and Roman periods and later Christianity.

6.4 Question

Find out how the Greek religion and philosophy could have influenced Christianity.

6.5 Activity

Attend a religious service to observe elements of:

- a) African culture
- b) Western culture

6.6 Summary

We have learned in Lesson 6 that modern philosophy has its background in the Greek philosophers such as Socrates, Plato and Aristotle. The Egyptian, the Greek and the Babylonian cultures produced Hellenistic culture and religion, which gave way to the Roman culture. Both the Hellenistic and the Roman cultures and religious beliefs came to shape or influence Christianity.

6.7 Definition of key words

Atheism: Disbelief in the existence of God or gods

Hellenism: The culture, religion and philosophy of the Jews in the Greek speaking world, particularly around the Mediterranean, after Alexander the Great.

Appendix 6.8 Further reading

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LESSON 7: THE ROMAN RELIGION

7.1 Introduction

In the previous Lesson we examined the Religion of the Greeks during which we found that the Greek religion was largely influenced by philosophy, which later was to influence Christian and Islamic philosophies. This lesson will introduce us to the religion of the Romans, which incidentally had a lot of influence on Christianity.

7.2 Objectives

By the end of this Lesson the learner should be able to:

- Describe the Roman religion.
- Show how the Roman religion could have influenced other religions especially Christianity.

7.3 Content

7.3.1 Roman Gods and Spirits

The Roman gods possessed little personality and were mysterious and feared. The religion had many spirits called **Manes**. They had good spirits of the family, and bad spirits called **Lemures**, meaning angry ghosts. Each house-hold had its spirit and so was the community. The most important of these were **Jupiter**, **Mars** and **Quirinus**. Jupiter was also called **Zeus**. Mars was the god of forest and mountains i.e. nature. Little is known about Quirinus. Other Roman gods included **Vesta**, Venus, Saturn, **Naptune**, **Janus** etc.

Note:

Some of the names mentioned above were borrowed by Science. Christianity also used some of them e.g. Quirinus (see Luke 2:2).

The priests guided both worship and sacrifice in the Roman religion. The high priest usually prepared the alter but sacrifices were offered by priests who were below him. The Romans practiced divination in which the future would be foretold by fortune-tellers.

It should be noted that the religion of the Romans was largely influenced by the Greek mythology and philosophy. The religion was also affected by the Hellenistic ideas from the Near East, particularly India.

7.3.2 Cults

The Roman religion had many mysteries, some of which were from the Egyptian, Greek and the Persian religions. This influence realized many religious **cults**. The most popular cult / movement was that of **Magna mater** or Great mother. This cult produced great frenzy among the devotees, particularly the eunuch priests, who slashed themselves for the sake of devotion to the great mother.

The cult of Isis called **Isaism** was a well organized movement. It had shaven headed celibate priests who had morning and evening devotions in the temples. The members believed that the soul is imprisoned in the body. The cult members had initiations and annual holy seasons

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of wailing for the loss of Osiris, then ending the season with the joy of Isis who returned to

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life each year. The Isaic liturgies were lovely in which Isis the mother of the stars would be honoured with torches, incense music and flutes.

7.3.3 Mithraism

Mithraism from Mithra, a Persian god connected with Zoroastrianism was one of the most popular cults. Mithras appears in the Vedas (Hindu scriptures) as the worrier god of heavenly light. Mithraism was the ancient religion of Persia but when the Persian empire collapsed Mithraism was invaded by the Roman Religion (Allen, 1951). However, the 2nd century AD realized considerable expansion of Mithrism to the Roman empire, becoming the religion of the soldiers and the educated classes, almost achieving supremacy equal to that of Christianity.

Mithraism believed that this life is not the end, but the gate- way to some future eternal life. They believed that at last the dead shall rise from the grave at Mithra's call. There will be judgment where the good will enter heaven while the wicked will be put into the realms of darkness. Mithraic worship was performed in caves, natural or artificial places called Mithraeums. The first day of the week was the day of worship called Mithraic Sunday and Decembers 25th was Mithras birthday. At the close of the 4th century AD, Mithraism and other pagan cults were suppressed by Christianity. But the cult had influenced Christianity almost permanently, e.g. the birth day of Christ is celebrated on December 25th, which is also Mithra's birth day.

In the Mithraic legend, god, Mithra, who was born in a cave and whom shepherds were the first to adore, performed miracles. He could slay a sacred bull by whose blood the earth was re-vitalized. At last Mithra ascended to heaven and there he dwells among the immortals yet ready to help the followers. Mithraic legend presents god plunging a dagger sword into the side of a bull while a scorpion bites the animal and a serpent drinks the blood.

To become a Mithric one had to undergo certain rituals in stages. The forehead was marked with water, which is similar to Christian baptism. Bread and water or wine, were taken by the participants. Honey was placed on the tongue and the hands of the initiates. Sacrifices and prayers were offered. The initiatives were then baptized in the blood of a lamb or bull. They would stand under the animal naked in order that the blood of the sacrificed animal could spill over their bodies and wash them.

7.3.4 Gnosticism

The Romans were also influenced by the Greek philosophy, **Gnosticism**. Gnosticism, which influenced the Romans and later Christianity was a product of the Egyptian Greeks. The Gnostics believed in a transcendent God, the creator of the world. They believed that the soul, a kind of spark imprisoned in the body, could be saved by Gnosis, a kind of saving wisdom or knowledge. The Gnostics rejected the Old Testament God but accepted Jesus Christ as the saviour who brought true gnosis/truth or saving knowledge. To them the Old Testament God was a failure because he had created a fallen world.

7.3.5 Manicheism

Another movement that came to influence Christianity was **Manicheism** whose origin is associated with Zoroastrianism. The founder, a native of Mesopotamia, who lived between 216-277CE, Mani claimed to have had wisdom from an angel from heaven. He was

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persecuted together with his followers by the Roman Emperor, Bahram I, for the faith. Mani taught that there were two forces in the world i.e. a holy spiritual force and the destructive

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force of darkness. The father of greatness, the eternal, lives in the realms of light while **Satan**, the evil one lives in darkness. However light was invaded by darkness and in the process of setting light free from darkness the sun, the moon, the stars and the earth were formed. But the earth remained in darkness with only a little light.

Adam and Eve lived in darkness but Eve was worse. Hence she became seductive and bore Cain and Abel by Satan/sin. Hence humanity was ruled by sin, particularly sexual sin. Messengers were then sent from the realm of light to rescue mankind. These included; Noah, Abraham, Zoroaster, Buddha, Jesus and finally Mani.

Manichaeism taught that after death, the sparks of light are set free from the body to join the realm of light and in the end the world will be burned down by the light and evil will be finally destroyed. Manichaeism was ascetic. The elect, both monks and nuns lived as vegetarians, refrained from sexual pleasures and were to own nothing. They were to live on offering.

Note:

The celibate life recommended to the religious people by some Christian churches to day, especially the Roman Catholic Church, was borrowed from Manichaeism.

The lay followers of Manichaeism were free to marry and to have jobs but they were to avoid killing, idolatry, sorcery and fornication among other evil deeds. St Augustine one of the early church fathers belonged to this sect. Manichaeism was persecuted by the early church but survived until the 10th century AD, having influenced Christianity to a large extent.

7.4 Question

Establish the beliefs and practices which Christianity borrowed from the Roman religion especially Mithraism, Gnosticism and Manichaeism.

7.5 Activity

Visit either a church or a mosque to interview religious leaders and the laity on elements of African religion and culture which have been borrowed or could be borrowed by modern religions.

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7.6 Summary

We have learned that the Roman Religion was polytheistic and that it was largely influenced by the Greek mythology and philosophy. The religion had many mysteries and cults, which came to influence Christianity e.g. Mithraism. The roman philosophy especially Gnosticism and Manichaeism also influenced Christianity.

7.7 Definitions

Gnosticism: The doctrine that knowledge, Gnosis, is the way to salvation of the human soul, which is usually enslaved by the human flesh.

Manichaeism: An oriental dualistic religion founded by Mani, a Persian teacher who lived around AD 216-276) and who taught strict ascetic life in order to release the divine spark or soul which is trapped in every person by Satan.

Mithraism: A religion of the ancient world, whose members worshiped Mithra, a deity who appears in the early Vedas and which between the 2nd and the 4th centuries AD flourished in the Roman Empire.

Manes: The spirit of the dead, which are malicious and hence feared.

Magna mater: A cult associated with a great mother who lived in the wilderness. This cult produced great frenzy among the devotees, who took to ascetic life for the sake of devotion to the great mother.

Cult: A form of religious belief, ritual observance or devotional duty, which is secretive.

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LESSON 8: AFRICAN TRADITIONAL RELIGION

8.1: Introduction

In the previous lesson we found that, the Roman religion, which was to influence Christianity to some extent, was largely influenced by the Greek the Egyptian and the Persian Religions. In this lesson we are going to examine the beliefs and practices of African religion with a view to finding out its future.

8.2: Objectives

By the end of this Lesson the learner should be able to:

- Analyze the beliefs and practices of African religion culture.
- Establish the extent to which African Traditional Religion has continued to influence other religions in Africa especially Christianity.

8.3: Content

8.3.1 African Civilization

Archeological evidence shows that the earliest men and women lived in Eastern Africa, particularly in Ethiopia, Kenya and Tanzania. Other early settlements were found in Egypt and Sudan. As communities were established, art and craft, music and religious practices were developed. These formed African cultural heritage. It should be noted that African culture is not homogenous. People from different parts of Africa have different cultural practices although some similarities do exist.

A lot of the early African cultural heritage is unknown due to lack of proper records. Most of what is known about African culture is what has survived through oral traditions, some of which was later put down by anthropologists and scholars of African culture and religion.

Africa had the earliest kingdoms and civilizations than any other continent. Such civilizations were for example found in Egypt, East, Central and in West Africa. The Egyptian civilization was the mother of all. The remains of the civilization e.g. the great pyramids are still evident today. It is in North Africa that writing was invented. It is also here that mortification and descent burial of the dead may have possibly began. Modern philosophy is also associated with North Africa, especially the Alexandrian School.

Civilization in west Africa saw the growth of small scale traditional industries which led to the manufacturing of goods particularly in gold and bronze. It should be noted that by the time the European powers entered Africa in the 19th century, many African peoples had strong political kingdoms. They also had religious beliefs and practices that were part and parcel of their life/cultural heritage. These regulated all aspects of life .

8.3.2 The Nature and Sources of African Religion

African religion is part of African culture. Thus it is found in all aspects/areas of human life. It shaped people's social life economic activities and their political organizations. African religion dates back to many thousands of years. It is the product of the thinking and experiences of men and women of the former generations (Mbiti, 1992). Such men and women had ideas, beliefs, practices, rituals, ceremonies, myths and sayings which had religious significance. They also had laws, norms and customs that safeguarded life. They had

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religious specialists such as diviners, prophets, seers, healers, elders, etc. These were the custodian of African religion and philosophy.

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African religion was found in all peoples of Africa. As a way of life people were born and grew up, died and continued to live religiously in form of spirits. Thus Africa religion influenced all aspects of human life including death. People did not know how to live without religion. It was simply the way of life and death. African religion developed together with other aspects of African culture. The religion did not start at some point. It had no founder and no preacher. It is part of the cultural heritage/environment of the people who practice it. It is difficult for people to abandon it even when they have been converted. Consequently, the religion continues to influence them, sometimes without their awareness or consciousness.

Worship in African religion was not an individuals affair but rather communal. Everybody was involved in it in one way or another. According to Mbiti religion arose and took shape as man searched for answers to natural, social, political, economic and other human needs. The religion is found in rituals and festivals, sacred places, things, objects, in music, art, dance, symbols, myth, stories, proverbs, riddles, wise sayings, names, customs, beliefs and practices etc. It is by these that African religion was passed on from generation to generation and continues to influence people behaviour.

8.3.4 The Future of African Religion

African religion though in most cases is said to be in the past tense, it is still a living faith in many parts of Africa and continues to influence people's lives as there are many ways in which the religion is practiced to day. Rites of passage such a birth, initiation, marriage, death and burial rites are still practiced in many cultures of Africa. Traditional religious specialists, especially diviners and herbalists are still found in many African communities. The practice of witchcraft, divination, sorcery, oaths and curses could also be found among some Africans most of whom are partly converted to Christianity or Islam.

Note:

Today Islam occupies about a third of the African continent, particularly northern, western and eastern Africa, while Christianity occupies the other two thirds of African continent. But African religion continues to influence the converts to some extent.

8.4 Question

Giving examples from any African communities show how African Religion has continued to influence either Christians or Moslems in Africa.

8.5 Activity

Participate in social functions e.g. naming, marriage, fundraising, burial etc to observe and identify elements of African religion and culture.

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8.6 Summary

We noted that African religion is among the ancient religions. The cultural and religious beliefs were passed orally through traditions due to lack of proper records. The religion shaped peoples social life, economic activities and political organizations. People were born, grew and died in African religion. The religion was transmitted through sacred things, objects, people, rites, rituals and festivals. African religion is not in the past tense, it is indeed a living faith that has continued to influence converttees with or without their knowledge and intention.

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PART TWO

LESSON 9 HINDUISM

9.1 Introduction

In our previous lecture we learnt about theories of religion and cosmic religions. In this part, we shall concentrate on religions in the Far East or oriental countries and from the near east. You will note similar characteristics related to the history and development of these religions, their concept of God and rituals. We shall begin with Hinduism.

The term Hindu is derived from the word *sindhu*, a name given by the Persians to the land watered by the River Indus. Hinduism originates from India and it's the main religion followed by the majority of people in India. Of all the worlds great religions, Hinduism is the most difficult to define. It grew gradually over a period of 5000 years absorbing and assimilating all religions and cultural beliefs of India. It has many scriptures which are authoritative but none which is exclusively so. Hinduism is more like a tree that has grown gradually than like a building that has been erected at a definite period of time. Hinduism is not a founded Religion. It has no creeds as a rule and is accepted only by the group, which has produced them. Its holy scriptures is of immense size and staggering diversity. It's neither doctrinal nor organizational.

9.2 Objectives

By the end of this lecture the learner should be able to:

- Understand Hinduism and its origin.
- Explain the source of its traditions.
- Understand it's sacred scriptures

9.3 Content

a) Historical Background of Hinduism

Hinduism is one of the oldest religions whose roots can be traced to 2500B.C. The Indus valley civilization, is believed to have flourished around 2,500 and 1,500 B.C. Civilization of the Indus valley and Southern India are comparable to those around the Nile, Tigris and Euphrates rivers.

The history of the Indus valley plays a significant role in the development of Hinduism .The 1920's archeological findings revealed that there was a highly complex urbanization, which had, large building containing bath house, this indicated that there was a practice of faithful performing rituals in the tank or pool of a Hindu temple The presence of a bath- house suggest ritual bathing.

Further excavations also revealed numerous female figurines made of baked clay and cut stone. They suggested the possible existence of a fertility cult, as one would expect in a highly sedentary agricultural society. The scholars also accept that those figurines represent the great mother goddess who is still worshipped in today's modern India. Therefore these figurines represent the historical antecedents of the worship of the mother in the pre-Vedic religion.

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Note

The prime aspect of pre-Vedic religion –fertility is also further reflected by the findings of numerous cone-shaped objects, which represent male sexual organ *lingas* and the ring shaped stone represent the female organs *Yoni*. The *Lingas* therefore symbolizes generative power and the *yonis* a fertility cult of the mother or mother goddess.

The fact that fertility continued to be an imported element in Hindu religion indicated that Aryans as well as the inhabitants of the Indus valley considered sexual powers sacred. By 1500B.C, the Aryans meaning Noble folk“ invaded the Indus valley and destroyed the Harappa and Mohenjo-daro culture these were some of the cultures within the Indus valley before the coming of Aryans.

All the features found in the Indus valley clearly depicts the fact that this valley was the bedrock and foundation of Hindu religion. This religion has therefore enriched itself over the centuries as a result of encountering and intermingling with various cultures offshoots of Hinduism, Jainism, Buddhism and Sikhism

Note:

Hinduism emanated from the Indus valley. A lot of its practices are borrowed from the history and culture of the Aryans of the Indus valley. It dates back to 2,500-1500BC.

b) Sacred Writings of Hinduism

The Hindu scriptures can be divided into three categories: Vedas, epics and Puranas.

Vedas

The word veda, literally means wisdom or knowledge. It's the term applied to the oldest of the Hindu scriptures originally transmitted orally and then subsequently preserved in written form. The Veda carries some conception, which suggests an extremely well developed moral consciousness.

It's very significant at the early stage of understanding Hinduism that we have a unifying conception like that of law and the order of nature. It tends to be associated with one's supreme God. Morality is an expression of divine law, the sinner is one who is out of harmony with the higher spiritual environment, which encompasses and controls the world.

The Vedas contain 128 oldest religious hymns arranged in a manner that they are chanting sacrifices *mantras*, prayers and ritual texts composed over a period of one thousand years beginning about 1400B.C. The term Vedas refers to the entire collection of these books, also known as the Samhitas, which include the Rig –Veda, the Sama –Veda, the Yajur –Veda and the Atharva-Veda. Each of these texts consists of three parts

- Mantras –hymns of praise to the gods
- The Brahmanas –a guide of practicing ritual rights
- The Upanishads – most important part that deal with teaching on religious truth or doctrine. The Rig-Veda is a collection of hymns, originally composed in Sanskrit, praises the Hindu deities including; Indra, Soma, Varuna and Mitra

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The Yajur Veda consists of a collection of mantra borrowed from the rig –Veda applied to the specific ritual situation carried out by the executive priest and assistants. The Sama –Veda in the same manner borrows mantras from the rig-Veda. These hymns are chanted.

The Athava Veda consists of magical spells and actions carried out by the priest.

c) Ethics

Some of the ethics includes the Upanishads, the ethic of love and obedience and the mahabarata.

The Upanishads

These are a collection of speculative treatises composed during the period of 800 to 600 B.C. The word Upanishad conveys the idea of sacred teaching. It refers to the mystical ideas about man and the universe, specifically the eternal Brahman, which is the self or soul. The Upanishads reportedly had influence upon Gautama Buddha, the founder of Buddhism as basic similarities between the Upanishads and the teaching of Mahayana Buddhism

The ethic of love and obedience

This was later adopted by atheistic schools of thought and it has its roots in the Rig Veda. The Vedic Hindu had a clear recognition of order and law. These laws were said to have been put up by god meanwhile put up by god under obligations to obey these laws. If one performed the morals and sacrifices and the ceremonial duties in the scripture he would achieve his goals of eternal happiness in heaven. They were supposed to please the gods in heaven since they guarded the law. They pleased their gods through magic and sacrifices. The concept of tapas meaning heat comes in the Rig Veda. It is held that through the tapas the primal being began to create more Tapas. This applies especially to the heat or flavour of devotion.

Brahmanas

In Arthava Veda, Brahmanas is the association of Tapas, which formed the ascetic strain in Hindu ethics, and perhaps the care of Hath Yoga. Brahamana" is a prose commentary explaining the symbolic significance of the rites.

The Mahabharata

It's the second epic an immerse story of the death of Aryan clans. It consists of 1,000,000 verses and was composed over an 800-year period beginning about 400 years B.C. It contained within this work a great classic the Bhagavad-Gita or the "song of the blessed lord".

Bhagavad Gita

The Gita is part of the Mahabarata. It is an indigenous effort to bring the best of all these creeds together. It's largely responsible for the catholicity universality.

The Gita takes up various creeds gods that were already competing with each other and transforms them into aspects of a more inward religion. If sacrifices were to be offered they must be of spirit but not of the material object. A life of self-control or disinterested action is a sacrifice. It is not only the most sacred book of the Hindus but also the best known and most read of all Indian works in the entire world. It consists of a dialogue between Krishna and the warrior Arjuna, who is about to fight his cousins. This poem has inspired millions of Hindus who have identified Arjuna's dilemma with their own situation. The poem offers hope through the way of devotion to all people no matter what their caste or sex.

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e) The Epics

The epic include Ramayana, and the puranas

Ramayana

The Ramayana is one of the two major epic tales of India. The authority is ascribed to the sage –poet valmaki. The work consists of 2400 couplets based upon the life or Rama a righteous king who was supposedly an incarnation of the god Vishnu

The Puranas

They include legends of gods, goddesses, demons, ancestors, myths and legends in which the heroes display all the desirable virtues. It has made a significant contribution to the formation of Hindu moral cords.

9.4 Question

Define the three categories of the Hindu scripture.

9.5 Activity

Discuss with a colleague the origin and foundation of Hinduism religion showing your understanding of the Hindu tradition of chanting in worship and sacrifices.

9.6 Summary

In this lecture, we have studied the origin of the Hindu religion and it's scriptures. The Hindu religion began from the Indus valley as early as 2,500 B.C. It grew and spread form a tradition emanating from the Hindus valley. We note that the religion has authoritative scriptures but non-is exclusively so. These are of immense size and staggering diversity.

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LESSON 10: HINDU TEACHING (DOCTRINES)

10.1 : Introduction

In the last lecture we discussed the first religion from the Far East showing its origin traditional background and its scriptures. In this lecture we shall discuss the Hindu teaching showing their understanding of human nature, the transmigration of souls and a final liberation of the soul from the cycle of rebirths. We shall conclude with the teaching of salvation according to Hindus.

10.2 Objective

- ✂ Describe the four ends of life according to Hinduism.
- ✂ Understand the Hindu caste system.
- ✂ Describe salvation according to Hindu understanding.

10.3 Content

a) The Background of Hindu Teaching and Polytheism.

Original gods

i) Indra- understood as the king of all the gods. He was one of the original god venerated in ancient Hinduism. At one time, he was the god of the power, the sky or the heaven.

ii) Agni- The god of fire. In this personification we find the roots of the pre-Aryan nature worship or animistic concepts.

iii) Varuna is the sky god. (Supreme being) He is regarded as the god of righteousness and completes the picture portrayed in the early beginning of Hinduism

iv) Hindu triad (trimurti) in developed hindu religion one finds the many Gods presided over by a triad of gods commonly referred to as the trimurti. They include;

- **Brahma**- Creator god- Sitting on open lotus flower. He forms the central part of a circle connected by some sort of umbilical cord to the navel of the second god of the triad, Vishnu. It is believed that he ascended from the earth with a red , a yellow and a white flower.
- **Vishnu**- Preserver- He grew into the second part of the triad as a preserver. He's pictured together with lakshmi- female goddess reclining on a bed consisting of the coils of a seven headed snake.
- **Siva** –destroyer- pre Aryan in origin. This god was assimilated into the trimurti , due to his popularity and prevalence amongst many of the Indus river valley dwellers. He is also known as *Yogeshwara*- god of Yoga. Hindus believe that he sits up the Himalayas Mountain at the fountain head of Ganges River and regard him as the source of the Ganges. That is why a sprout of water is seen as shooting from the top of his hair and this is identified as the goddess *Gangamai*, visible in form of a snake.

Hindus believe in very many gods but they are mainly from the triad family and the female goddesses. Who are incarnated as follows. Vishnu's incarnation is Rama and Rama's

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incarnation is Krishna. Siva's incarnation is soobramanar and muruga and his son is Ganesha, the elephant god.

b) The Female Goddesses

The most well known is Kali who asks blood sacrifice. One of the most important one is Lakshmi, god of good luck or prosperity. She is seen as the light of the house. She is worshipped in every Hindu home by lighting the Brass lamp. Other female goddesses are Sarasavati, the goddess of learning and music. Muthumari and Durga are other female gods whose major function is in hindhu household.

The Hindu teaching are given according to the revelation by Brahman This refers to the supreme reality, who is without cause, effect or anything inside or outside as defined by Edward Rice. Hindus believe in very many gods but the most supreme is Brahman. Under him are two different beings *Vishnu* the form of the preserva god and *shiva* the destroyer god of the universe.

c) Hindu philosophy

Teaches that there are four stages leading to liberation from all evil and recycling of birth, these are,

- Dharma
- Karma
- Samsara
- Moksa

Dharma – Is all that activity that a man/woman is to live fittingly is required to contribute to the fixed order of things or to the norm of the universe, which is good, shouldn't be altered. It emphasizes on order.

Adharva– is exact opposite centrally to the established order. The acts performed exist once following their latent potential.

Karma

It literally means action and has a reference to a persons actions and the course one there off. In Hinduism one's present state of existence is determined by the performance in previous lifetimes. The law of karma is the law of moral consequences. As one performs righteous acts, he/she moves towards liberation from the cycle of successive births and deaths begins. It underlines all Hindu behavior, Religious activity and thought. It can be called the law and cause effect. According to the Hindu thought all our life is controlled by this law. It's actually the law of works. You do good works and get pleasure. You get Moksa – liberation from recycle births.

Samara

It refers to the transmigration or rebirths. It's the passing through a succession of lives based upon direct reward or penalty of ones karma. This continuous chain consists of suffering from the results of acts of ignorance or sin in the past lives during each successive rebirths the soul which the Hindu consider to be eternal moves from one body to be eternal. It moves from one body to another and carries with it the karma from its previous existence. The Hindu belief that, Having completed his/her karma – god approves them to the upper ladder and one gets

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freedom and one gets a release from the everlasting cycle of births.

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Moksa

Moksa is the Hindu term for liberation of the soul from the wheel of Karma. For the Hindu, the chief aim of existence is to be freed from samsara (the building life cycle) and the wheel of karma with its endless cycle of births, deaths. When one achieves this liberation, he enters a state that can be attained through death or while one is still living Basically Moksa can be achieved through three paths

- (1) Jinana knowledge
- (2) Bhakti –devotional
- (3) Karma –ritual works

d) Yoga

To be yoked or union. As such there is the pathway to freedom of Moksa. In practice is a meditation technique, which is supposed to devote union with the Brahman main god in Hinduism. To become one with nothingness which is the essence of the universe according to the Hindu thinking nothingness – loses power so that the power from Brahman can come in and be united with atman

Note

All Hindus believe that they have to work hard so that they can be liberated from a series of rebirth and this is taken to be a punishment from Brahman

e) The Hindu Caste System

i) Hindu Caste System

Aryans who regarded themselves as the upper castes Brahmins introduced castes. The caste system was therefore introduced to preserve a privileged position for the Aryan masters. The Hindu castes are basically four but in practice they could probably be two thousands. There is a fifth group of outcasts called the untouchables. Gandhi fought against the caste system and called the untouchables, the people of god. Other castes in addition are as follows

ii) Brahmin

They are the highest considered to be next to god (Brahman). Its a priestly caste and considered as a noble class. According to Hindu philosophy when Brahma was undertaking the creation of man the first to appear were those from the face of Brahma. These were therefore called Brahmins. Their caste name is „Sharma“. Brahmins offer sacrifices, study and teach the vedas. They also give charity and accept gifts.

iii) Kshatrijas

This is the caste of warriors. Their duty is organizational and government (administrators). They were the second to appear when Brahma was creating and they appeared from the chest. They are supposed to give gifts, study the vedas, offer sacrifices, protect the good and destroy evil.

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iv) Vaisyas

They are farmers, craftsmen and tradesmen. It is also an affluent class. They are believed to have been the third to be created and came from the thighs of the Brahma. Their roles include engaging in cultivation, rearing cows and trade.

v) Sudras

This is the lowest caste believed to have come from Brahma's feet. They are builders/manual workers. They serve the three other castes.

The caste system is one of the unique features of the Hindu religion. It is said that Brahma the creator created man the first man who came with four different types of people.

- The *Brahmins* best and most holy people
- The *kshatriyas* rulers and warriors
- *vaisyas* –merchants and farmer
- *Shudras* –labours and servants

The above people formed the caste system. Today the caste system is still an integral part of the social order of India even though the Indian Government has outlawed it.

e) Salvation

Salvation in Hinduism can be achieved in three ways, these include

i) Salvation by way of works

Karma Marga (the way of works) is the path to salvation through religious duty. It consists of carrying out the prescribed religious ceremonial duties. The Hindu believes that by doing these things they can add favorable karma to their merit. Moreover, if they do them religiously they believe it is possible to be re-born as a Brahmin on their way towards liberation from the wheel of Karma.

ii) Jinnana: The way of knowledge

This is another way of salvation. The basic premise behind the way of knowledge is the cause of suffering based on ignorance. This mental error concerning our nature is the root of mankind's problems. The error of man's thinking is this; man sees himself as a separate and real entity. The truth of the matter Hindu says is that the only reality is Brahma and there is no other. Therefore, man, rather than being a separate entity is part of the whole Brahma. According to Hinduism, selfhood is an illusion. As long as man continues seeing himself as a separate reality he will be claimed to the wheel of birth, Man therefore must be saved from this wrong belief by proper understanding that he has no independent self. The way of knowledge does not appeal to the masses but rather to an intellectual few who are willing to go through prescribed steps.

iii) The way of devotion

Bhakti (way of devotion) is the last chronologically of the three ways of salvation. It is that devotion to a deity that may be reflected in acts of worship both public and private. This devotion based upon love for the deity, will also be carried in human relationship i.e. love of family or love of master. This devotion can lead one to ultimate salvation. The Bhagavad Gita is the work, which has devoted special attention to this way of salvation and is characterized by commitment and action.

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10.4 Question

Describe the four ways according to Hindu teaching of salvation.

10.5 Activity

Interview a Hindu from your neighborhood and find out his/her caste. Establish how he is working out his karma to enable him/her acquire moksa.

10.6 Summary

Hinduism, Supreme Being is the un-definable impersonal Brahman a philosophical absolute. The Hindu view man as a manifestation of the impersonal Brahman without having an individual self or self worth. Indeed in Hinduism there is no sin against a Holy God. Acts of wrongdoing are not against any god but are mainly a result of ignorance. These evils are overcome by following the guidelines of ones caste and way of salvation. Lastly Hinduism views the material world as transitory and of secondary importance to the realization of Brahman.

10.7 Definition of words

Atman : It refers to the soul or true self, the path of the living thing that is eternal.

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LESSON 11: JAINISM

11.1 Introduction

In our last lecture we learnt about the teachings of Hinduism and their four ways of life. In this lecture we shall discuss yet another religion from the Far East. Jainism rose in the sixth century BCE in the Northern parts of India at a time when there was disintegration of society due to inversion and subsequent subjection brought about by powerful autocratic monarchies from further north. As a result of the political changes of the sixth century B.C, there was a wide spread feeling of uprooted ness, being lost and insecure, both socially and morally. There were many un-answered questions that touched on the nature of soil, the destiny after death, why innocent people suffer on the attainment of good things in life.

11.2 Objectives

By the end of this lecture the learner should be able to:

- ❖ Understand Mahavira's philosophy.
- ❖ Describe the belief and practices of Jainism.
- ❖ Analyze the growth and development of the religion and its adherents.

11.3 Content

a) The founder

Mahavira was born in 599. He is the founder of Jainism who found the philosophy taught by Brahmanism in adequate and unacceptable, especially the human predicament through sacrificial rituals. Jainism was started so as to offer more adequate and satisfying ways of redemption. A release or liberation from Karma and from the consequent rounds of rebirth. Jainism therefore started as the first offspring of Hinduisim. It started as a reformation movement or sect but soon established itself as an independent religion based upon the teachings of its founder Mahavira.

A person who accepts Jainism is called a Jain or a jina. A jina is soul. Jainism believes in ascending and descending time cycles. According to the Jain sources, there had been twenty-four Tirthankara (Prophetic personalities), the last and the greatest of the saviour or divine beings was Mahavira. Traditions say that, Mahavira was living in heaven until time came for him to descend on earth. He entered the womb of queen vema and was born without sin and with all knowledge.

Mahavira was born from a royal family (king and queen) and from his childhood, he was brought up in luxury. He was married to a princess, however Mahavira was not contented with his princely life with all its luxury. After the death of his father Mahavira renounced the world to become an ascetic or wandering monk to seek liberation. He lived a life of self-denial, pledging to deny himself the care of his body and not to speak for twelve years.

During Mahavira 13th year as a mendicant monk practicing extreme ascetics and austerity, the experience he had been seeking came, while in the serious meditation. He achieved liberation (Moksa) and attained nirvana. He thus became the jina (the conqueror, having achieved a complete victory over the recycle of birth and the desires that bind one to this world of matter and sin. Mahavira then began his mission of teaching them the way to salvation.

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b) Basic Beliefs

There were basic beliefs and doctrines that distinguished Jainism from other religions on questions such as the universe, Karma, soul, matter and liberation of salvation. The universe is believed to be un-created and eternal. There was no speculation about the creator, beginning or end. Its history consists of long eras, each with a period of improvement followed by one of decline. The religion will die out to be restored in the next era. The karma concept in Jainism, which is translated as a deed or action and the effect of such a deed on the soul concerned. Karma is likened to soot and desire. Evil deeds make the soul sticky so that karma matter sticks on it. Injuring of life is the worst kind of action and brings to the soul the highest amount of bad karma matter. At the end of existence the soul rises or sinks to the level of carnivorous beasts or to hell. Those souls that are completely free from Karma – matter, which are thus pure souls, like finest feathers or bubbles to the summit of the universe (isatpragbhara) where they remain eternally with other liberated souls in perfect omniscience and bliss. There were disagreements based on the belief that one pre-requisite for becoming a true monk was the complete abandonment of clothing. Mahavira was completely opposed to the idea of acknowledging or worshipping a supreme being.

However Jainism later acknowledge the worship of deity. Mahavira himself became the object of worship. Although Mahavira denied that any God or gods existed to be worshiped, he liked other religious leaders was deified by his later follows.

c) Salvation in Jainism

Salvation or liberation in Jainism is attained wholly through the efforts of the individual soul; there is no supreme divine being that gives assistance to any beings. Mahavira showed the way to salvation through one's efforts in his experience of liberation, which came after long seeking with the practice of extreme ascetics and austerity. The release from the cycle of re-birth can be achieved in three folds.

Firstly is the **right faith** that is, unshaken faith, in the teaching of the faiths. Secondly the **right knowledge** that is true understanding of their principles and doctrines and thirdly the **right conduct** that is living one's life following the principles. The right conduct involves strict observance of pre-scribed rules of conduct, which are summed up in the five great vows for monks.

- ❖ The first of these is the vow to observe **Ahimsa** renouncing all killings or injury of living beings and pledging never to cause others to kill or injure, nor to consent to any killing or injuring. To observe this vow of Ahimsa means one has to walk carefully and lightly at times sweep one's path to clear it of any creatures, avoid hurting or killing any living beings. This principle has led to give jains avoiding occupations that would involve injuring or killing any living beings such as agriculture, military work or butchery work. They therefore concentrate on occupations such as banking and industry, where they are very successful.
- ❖ The second vow binds the jains never to lie even in anger, nor to cause another to neither lie nor consent to another's lying.
- ❖ The third vow binds the jains never to take, nor cause another person to take nor consent to taking of anything not given. This means a high degree of self-restraint from any form of dishonest or unlawful acquisition of anything and from any form of greed.

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- ❖ The fourth vow is the renunciation of “ all sexual pleasure “ and sexuality.
- ❖ The fifth vow is renunciation of all attachments to anything small or great, living or non-living.

The ultimate consequence of these principles and beliefs is strict vegetarianism and minimizing of the basic humanitarian needs.

Scriptures

There were twelve sacred writings of Jainism called **angas**. Jainism in summary was a religion of legalism as one attains his own salvation only through the path of rigid self-denial.

Note

Any concept of God in a personal sense is missing from Jainism as Mahavira and early Jains had rejected the idea of the existence of Supreme Being.

Mahavira himself did not advocate prayer and worship; after his death Jainism took to worshipping Mahavira himself. The followers of Jainism used the sacred writings the **angas** as the writings of faith that helped strengthen their faith. The place of worship was commonly known and referred to as the temple or (Buja)

Note

The doctrines of the Ahimsa which is central to the jains belief is impossible to practice fully since there is no way one can avoid killing millions of Micro- organisms even in a glass of water. This in turn produces bad Karma and therefore makes salvation virtually impossible.

11.4 Question

Describe the belief and practice of a Jains showing the position of a supreme being.

11.5 Activity

Compare and contrast the attainment of Moksha in Jainism with that of Hinduism. Explain which of the two explains clearly the way to be liberated from the cycle of rebirth?

11.6 Summary

In this lecture we have noted the up rise of Jainism after the teaching of Mahavira. The religion was in response to the enquiry about the recycle of birth as taught in Hinduism and a desire to come out of producing bad karma. We note that in response, Mahavira came up with four principal vows, which were established as jains practice recorded in the angas, their scripture. We particularly note the observance of Ahimsa, a rigorous rule. However our final observation is that there is no established source of authority for jains beliefs in light of the existing disputes over which of the various books to be considered authoritative.

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LESSON 12: BUDDHISM

12.1 Introduction

In our previous lecture we learnt about the teachings of Jainism. We saw that that was a period of religious questioning and social distengration. In this lecture we shall study Buddhism another religion from the Far East. Buddhism emerged in the sixth century BCE. Just like the emergence of Jainism, Buddhism came out of peoples" dissatisfaction with the ritualism offered by Brahmanism, as a way of salvation in Hinduism. Gautama founded Buddhism as an alternative way of liberation. According to mythical and legendary materials Gautama was a historical figure. We begin with an introduction of the founder Gautama Buddha and the four signs, which led him to begin the religion.

12. 2 Objectives

By the end of this lecture the learner should be able to:

- ✂ Describe the life history of Gautama Buddha
- ✂ Discuss the four fold and the eight fold path
- ✂ Note the differences between Hinduism and Buddhism

12. 3 Content

a) The Founder of Buddhism

Gautama was born in northern India near Nepal of the sakya clan .He was born by Suddhodna and queen Maya. He belonged to the ruling warrior caste: Kshatriya. He is believed to have been born miraculously by queen Maya in 563 BCE. During his birth he was received into a golden net by the gods who worshiped him. According to Mugambi, the baby underwent a quick survey of the whole world. He took seven steps across it and cried in the voice of a lion "I am the chief of the world, this is my last birth, there is no existence again". His mother died a few days later and an aunt with great love brought him up. In his youth, Prince Gautama was brought up in great luxury and pleasure. At the age of 19 he got married to a princes called Yasudhara and after 10 years he got a son called Ruhala. In his youth prince Gautama showed great wisdom. Seers had told his father, king Suddhadona that Gautama would renounce the world and become a recluse if and when he saw four signs:

- ✂ An old man
- ✂ A miserably sick man
- ✂ The dead man
- ✂ A calm religious ascetic

Note

His father guarded him against seeing the four signs by making sure that he was confined within the palace and it's beautiful gardens, and was kept happy with every possible delight made available to him. Whenever he had to go out of the palace, the streets would be cleared of everything, which showed signs of affliction

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b) The four signs

The gods sent one of their numbers to bring the four sights which represent the fate that awaits all humans. One day as the prince was riding along the street, the god appeared suddenly in the form of a very old man, extremely weak and miserably worn out with age. This meant that all human beings grow old and that even Gautama himself would grow old. The second sight was a miserably sick person, followed by a dead man carried along the streets in a brier and finally a calm ascetic in a yellow monk's robe. From the ascetic, Gautama learned how one could gain liberation from the miseries and pain of life represented in the three earlier signs he had seen.

c) The Great Renunciation

After the sight of the four signs he renounced his home, princely life and became a homeless ascetic. The leading evil spirit mara brought great temptations to hinder him from putting into effect this great decision. Gautama overcame all the temptations and one night he bade his wife and son farewell and went to the forest to start his new life as recluse.

d) The Great (Quest of Salvation) and the Enlightenment of Gautama Buddha

Gautama spent six years of intensive search for enlightenment and liberation, trying various ways available then. He tried philosophy of Brahmanism, discipline, and asceticism but all in vain. He tried the ascetic philosophy of living in caves; self-mortification, fasting but these extremes asceticism did not lead him anywhere. He backslid and continued with his struggle and search.

Gautama sat under a bodhi tree for meditation one whole day and night, and he went through the eight stages of meditation (dhyana). At the highest stage (ecstatic trance), a great light came on him. He saw his past successive reincarnation and observed the whole world as though in a mirror. He saw the nature of god and existence, past, present and future, He saw cause for all suffering pain and how it can be done away with. He was able to reach a state of Nirvana where desires have been rooted out and rebirths have therefore ceased. He became a Buddha, the enlightened one. He was able to overcome temptations on his way and decided to reach the truths to men and make many attain enlightenment and liberation.

e) Buddha's first Sermon

Buddha left the park where he had attained enlightenment and went to the holy city of Benares close by. The first five ascetics who had deserted him earlier when he gave up extreme asceticism were his first disciples. He delivered his first sermon to the ascetic in the deer park. This sermon is known as the **Deer park at Benares**. In the sermon he explained the right way of salvation on the way to attain enlightenment and liberation. He showed two extremes to be avoided; a life given to pursuit of pleasures and lust and life of extreme asceticism and mortifications.

Note

He admonished his disciples to follow the middle path i.e., which leads to perfect peace, enlightenment and Nirvana. The sermon went on to expound on the four noble truths and the eight-fold path.

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f) The Establishment of the Sangha

Sangha means a community of Buddha monks. The ascetics became converted to Gautama doctrine and believed him as Buddha the enlightened one. They formed the nucleus of Sangha, the order or community of the Buddhist monk were: -

- ☞ Yellow robe
- ☞ Shaven head
- ☞ The begging bowl
- ☞ The daily meditations
- ☞ The short creed they all had to subscribe to: -“ I take refuge in the Buddha, I take refuge in the Sangha.

The ten precepts which all pledge to observe are:

The ten Precepts

They pledge **not** to: -

1. Destroy life
2. Take anything not given.
3. Engage in any form of unchastity
4. Lie or deceive
5. Take any intoxications

They further pleaded to: -

6. Eat moderately and only before noon.

They are **not** to: -

7. Watch dancing, singing or dramatic spectacles.
8. Make use of ornaments, perfumes and garlands.
9. Use high or broad beds.
10. Accept gold or silver.

Lay people could associate to the order, pledge to obey the first precepts and do what they could, to promote the order. Thousands of people both men and women, joined as associates and that strengthened the order. An order of nuns was also established.

The Significance of Sangha

The Sangha provided ideal conditions to help the monk realize his goal of getting rid of the illusion of the self and its cravings. The only things he was allowed to possess individually were the yellow monastic robe, begging bowl, razor, and needle and water strainer. Their way of life had no private or personal possessions, a life in which the monk had to subject himself to the communal will judgment and discipline of the Sangha. The monastic life provided ideal conditions for the prescribed regulations and meditations.

Sangha is thus considered along with Buddha and the dharma as one of the essential refuges of the Buddhist monk for the attainment of Nirvana. In southern Buddha these are called the three jewels.

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12.4 Question

Discuss Buddhism showing your understanding of eternal bliss.

12.5 Activity

Buddha was the first religious monk! Do you agree? Defend your answer showing your understanding of monasticism and Gautama Buddha's contribution.

12.7 Summary

In this lecture we have discussed Buddhism the founder and how he came up with the religion. We note that Gautama Buddha was born of a royal family. He however sought to understand the four signs even though that was not his experience. Finally, he comes up with a solution of liberating people from suffering. The eternal bliss Nirvana. He understands liberation to come after denial and self sacrifice which he demonstrates in the ten precepts for the community of monks.

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LESSON 13: THE TEACHING OF BUDDHISM

13.1 Introduction

In our last lecture we learnt about Buddhism, the founder and his experience from birth to the point of starting monastic lifestyle. In this lesson we shall discuss the teachings and the two types of Buddhism.

13.2 Objectives

By the end of this lesson the learner should be able to

- ✂ Understand the teachings of Buddha
- ✂ Discuss and show the difference between Thervada and Mahayana Buddhism
- ✂ Understand the spread and growth of Buddhism.

13.3 Content

a) The Teaching of Buddha

From the time of his great- renunciation Buddha set out with determination in search of enlightenment. His sole interest was to find a way to gain insight into the human predicament and how people could obtain liberation from it. Buddha expanded his teaching immediately after his enlightened experience, in his first sermon. The teachings are summarized up in what he called **the four Noble truths** and **eight fold path**.

The four Noble Truths

- i. The noble truth of suffering (Dukkha)
- ii. The noble truth of the cause of suffering
- iii. The cessation of suffering
- iv. The noble truth of the path that leads to the cessation of suffering.

Note

This path is declared as the Noble eight-fold path, which is constituted by ; right belief, aspiration, speech, conduct, right means of livelihood, right endeavor, mindfulness and right meditation. The right essentials of the eight-fold path can be grouped into three sections: wisdom, morality and meditation.

c) Buddha's reinterpretation of basic ideas current in his time

Karma this is a psychological force rising from desire and wrong attitudes and leading to a birth of a new life- entry.

Non-existence of the soul and the impermanence of all things. For Buddha Impermanence (**anatta**) is one of the three marks of existence. The is absence of a permanent self (anatta) and the third mark of all existence is suffering (**dukkha**).

Anicca means every existing thing including, a human being as an impermanent grouping together of various states of being. The human is a union of five such states of being (**skandhas**) - the body, the feeling conceptual knowledge resulting from sense-

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perception, the subconscious, including instinct and reason or faculty of value judgment. The karma force leads to rebirth.

d) Nirvana

The term Nirvana is derived from the Sanskrit root *va* meaning *blow*. Nirvana then can be translated literally as extinguishing or blowing out of a candle. It is the ultimate goal of the Buddhist religious life. It is a state of supreme spiritual insight, perfect body and mind control and peace, the experience of enlightenment and ultimate release as Buddha attained it. Nirvana is like the blowing out of a candle in that the former life- entity ceases and there is no more re-birth.

e) Buddhist Scriptures

The Council that met after Buddha's death ruled, three rules for monastic discipline, Buddha's sermon and the manual of Buddhist metaphysics and psychology. The three were known as the three baskets of the canon. Metaphysic means beyond physical. A century later a second council met to decide the best interpretation for the rule of discipleship. This brought about a split between the minority and the monastery rebels. The 3rd council by emperor Asoka tried to recall the original purity of faith

To revise the teaching

To confirm the canon

By that time Buddhism had split into two schools

- 1 North – Mahayana
- 2 South - Thervada

f) Thervada

The main therevada scripture are in three collections, and are given the name *Tripitaka* that means the three baskets (collections) they are written in *Pali* language. It is called the 3 basket of the law. For quite some time, the scriptures were preserved and transmitted orally. The compilation was completed by 247 BCE. The pali text represented the sacred literature of the Thervada monks. In the baskets of the law there are six main 227 rules binding all Buddhist monks. The three baskets that make up the Theravada or the Pali canon are as follows;

(a) The **Vinaya Pitika** the baskets monstatic rules ,,

(b) The **Sutta Pitika** (Basket of teachings) This continues records of Buddha's

(C) The **Abhidhaimma Pitika** –The basket of higher doctrine or the metaphysical basket

The **Dhammapada** is also an impartment scripture. It is the way of virtue or the Buddha's teaching. It is a short book of 423 verses. It contains many useful teachings on practical morality and self-discipline, the four noble truths and the Noble eight –fold path

g) Mayana Text

They are written in Sanskrit oriental language

- (i) **Amida Sutra**: is a Chinese version of the small **sukhavativyuha sutra**.
- (ii) **A mitayurdhyana**- This one is a set of meditation of amitabla – Epic
- (iii) **Mahuavaracana- Sun diety**. It is the fundamental scripture of the sanskrit Buddhism.
- (iv) **Mulamadhyamika Sastra**: It is the treaties by Nagarjuna setting forth the teaching of **Madhiyamika**- middle part school.

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- (v) **Sudharna Pundarika:** Is the lotus of the wonderful law. Is a set of the doctrine at one visible and eternal Buddha.
- (vi) **Vijnaptimatrat asiddhi:** Is a treaties of mind consciousness.
- (vii) **Avatamsuka Sutra:** They have the school they call flower Garland and **Avatamsaka Sutra** Is the name given to the treaties.
- (viii) **Vajrachedika Sustra:** Diamond used by zen Buddhist.
- (ix) **Vima lakirtinidesa:** teachings set forth for laymen

Nearly all Buddhist base their faith on the scripture. These is one scripture that is authoritative to all Buddhist. There has been a major difference concerning which is the best.

Note

Unlike Judaism Christianity and Islam, there is no way we can take Buddhism to be a religion of the book. Buddha explored ideas until he reached the stage of enlightenment. Buddhism thrived in an illiterate society where there was no need of scriptures. For Buddhists, their aim was to follow and obey the morals established while belonging to the community Buddha.

Currently there are two types of Buddhism.

1. **Thervada Buddhism:** This is the earliest form of Buddhism. It's teaching are derived from the body of doctrine approved at an important conference soon after the founder's death. This form of Buddhism's characterized by its conservative legalistic teaching, involving a narrow path to spiritual enlightenment. It is common to see it referred to as Hinayana, a name given to it by those who feel it is too difficult a way for the mass of mankind. It survives today in Southern Asia, Ceylon Burma, Thailand, Cambodia and Laos. Also known as Southern Buddhism.
2. **Mahayana Buddhism:** Majority of Buddhists today belongs to this form of Buddhism. It is a more of a liberal branch with a broad lenient path to enlightenment. It is the "great vehicle". Mahayana thought spread and developed in central and Northern Asia and is also called Northern Buddhism. Today it is the religion of large numbers in China, Japan, Tibet, Mongolia, Korea, Vietnam and Nepal.

13. 4 Question

Describe the two types of Buddhism.

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13.5 Activity

Draw two columns and list the two types of scriptures alongside. Give brief analyses of the differences between the two.

13.6 Summary

In this lesson we have learnt about the two types of Buddhism, teachings and scriptures. We note that Thervada Buddhism is closer to original Buddhism but is more difficult a faith to maintain. The Mahayana Buddhism is more liberalized (the greater vehicle) and popular than Thervada Buddhism. Both however carry the values of the founder, the search and acquirement for enlightenment.

Appendix 8: Further Readings

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LESSON 14: SIKHISM

14.1 Introduction

In our last lecture we learnt about the teaching of Mahavira in a religion by name Jainism. This was founded as a result of the search for nirvana or eternal bliss. We note that similar concerns led to the founding of the previous religion Buddhism. In our current lecture, we shall learn about Sikhism. Sikhism is a religion with roots from both Islam and Hinduism. We shall begin by learning about its founder. First we shall discuss Kabir who paved the way and then Guru Nanak who established Sikhism.

14.2 Objective

By the end of this lecture the learner should be able to:

- ✂ Understand the founder of Sikhism
- ✂ Know the teachings of Sikhism.
- ✂ Describe the growth and spread of Sikhism.

14.3 Content

a) The Origin and Development of Sikhism

India was a place of religions, Islam came and destroyed part of Hinduism and during that time Sikhism arose. There was a man born in 1440 called Kabir, which means Greek in Arabic. In Islam Alkjabir means one of the 99 excellent words for God. He was raised in a low class family and his mother was from the Brahman family. He is said to have been a follower of a Hindu leader called Rammanand a leader of opponent caste system. He had love for all men.

Kabir said that although there is nothing in record that he was a follower of Sufi sect, he was influenced by this sect. He was a man of two religions. He was opposed to the religion of caste system, idolatry and did not accept the Koran and Vedas. Hindus excommunicated him because of rebelling against the caste system and by the Muslims for disturbing peace. He had established a religion that was neither Muslim nor Hindu. The followers were called the Kabir Pantha. He established a way for a more influential figure who would come and follow his footsteps. The person was Guru Nanak. Various sects were founded as a result of denouncing idolatry. One of the m that existed and founded by Guru Nanak was the Sikh sect.

He was born in 1470 in a predominantly Hindu village and tradition has it that at his birth time heavenly potent attended it. They saw the coming of the lord descend at his birthplace. There were loud sounds heard at his maternal home. The baby's voice was that of a man who carries with it wisdom. There were six ascetic, 9 radhs 53 birs, 64 yogings, 84 sidhs and 330 million gods. In spite of tradition, Guru Nanak is said to have come from a humble caste. He went to a humble school like his contemporaries; he learnt Hindu, Arabic and Persian Characters. A Muslim friend of his father became very close to Nanak and introduced him to the Shiite doctrine.

He also became acquainted with Hindu scriptures some saints of Mohammed and some Koran parts. He became associated with saddhus and with Sufis the Parsis and Jews and probably Christians.

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It is also said that although he was pious the things of life did not pass him, at 14 or 19 years he married. He did not have much time for his wife and at the age of 30 they separated on approval of his mother in law's advice.

He began an ascetic life and had a Muslim servant called mardhana who became the strongest and longest associate. They meditated, discussed and traveled together exhaustively for a period of 20 years. It was during this period of wondering that he met Kabir. At the age of 50 he saw a vision of god who pledged him success and offered him a cup of holy nectar.

During the experience, Guru Nanak had the sound of the true name called Sat Nam (teacher) and he learned that he would be the Guru of Sat Nam. Those who would follow would be freed from the terrible wind of migration. He had the following followers.

- | | | | |
|---|------------|---|------------------------|
| 1 | Mardhana | 2 | Lahna (Angad) |
| 3 | Sindhi Jat | 4 | Sri Chand- Nanak's Son |

He traveled with these people from village to village singing hymns and preaching to the people. He made sure that he had no form of religion. At his death he handed over the teachings to Angad but left no signs in the places he had passed through.

b) The six followers teaching

They teach that god is transcendent, omnipotent and all pervading. There is the concept of maya- illusion. Nanak was the first Guru and Angad the second. The fifth Guru was called Arjan who lived between 1563 and 1603. He began to assemble together the writings of his predecessors and put them into a work called *Adi Granth*. In addition to that he put Muslims and Hindus songs together. The *Adi Granth* became their scripture. The key part is called *Japgi* all these indicate that *Arjan* had seen the real re-approval of the faith. He had to re-justify it with Hindu and Muslim. It developed as an order parallel to Islam.

The 10th Guru (teacher) who was called Govind Singh who lived between 1666-1708 added to the *Adi Granth* and it was called *Granth Sahib*. He declared that he is going to be the last Guru to live. What became the substitute of the Guru guidance were scriptures (the *Adi Granth*). They became the eternal Guru. The kind of reverence given to the scripture is beyond that given to the Koran, Bible or the Vedas.

According to Guru Nanak men are sinful and that is the basic problem of man. Even Guru Nanak needed escape from the circle of birth and death. A sinner who chooses freely to affiliate to the things of the world, is also one who is royal to his own voice *Mammokh* rather than Guru's voice. *Mammokh* is a voice full of falsehood and sinners are known to listen to such a voice. A guru is a communicator of a divine truth, a guide and an example.

c) Ethics

- | | | | |
|----|-----------------------|----|---------------|
| a) | No tobacco | b) | No Opium |
| d) | No meat, beef or pork | e) | No intoxicant |

They argue that since Sikhism teaches monotheism, men ought to show the example by being monogamous. Guru Nanak emphasis on the equality of women. He said „,how can she be called inferior who begets king”? The Sikhs are taught to consider women as mothers,

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daughters and sisters. Further in the Sikh system they repudiate the notion of the caste system. When the Sikhs are not saints they become warriors. They bare arms for self-protection.

The six followers formed a militant group of soldiers. The five Gurus soldiers never brought arms but the 6th Itar Govind had arms, he had to kill two of his enemies as he achieved power. His son Teg Bahadur became the 9th Guru who had his name derived from the Punjab meaning sword hero. Teg Bahadur lived according to his name. He was bold and came into conflict with emperor Aurangzeb who beheaded him, cut his body into four pieces and hanged each piece on the four gates that entered the city. He had a son Gobind singh who was terrified because of what happened to his father and he hated Islam.

Note

Nanak assured the success of Sikhism by handing it over to a successor. Gobind Singh assured the continuity of Sikhism by canonizing the scriptures.

Gobind championed the lowly people of Northern. India and began to take the advantage of the decline of Aurangzeb. He now wanted to take vengeance on the Muslims; by so doing he failed in a sense of divine power in his performance of duties. He therefore assembled the six and told them that Durga Hindu (Mother goddess) was giving him super power for a new mission. She would do that on condition that he gave blood sacrifice. He made a call on anybody who wanted to be sacrificed on behalf of Durga. Five men volunteered after three attempts of request, he began calling them one by one in his tent. He had them give blood and later on called a meeting to show the five men heroicism. The five men became the five immortal running point of new Sikh nation. He instituted the initiation by *Pahl*, which is a baptism. He then gave all of them a new name Singh meaning Lion. He substituted new touchable symbols of membership as follows:

- ✂ Kukkas-unshaven hair,
- ✂ comb carried in the hair,
- ✂ the wearing of a short and steam bangle on the right wrist
- ✂ the carrying of the sword.

He introduced a communication rite, which broke off the caste system. He set up a committee called *Puachayat*, which was a management committee to rule a Khalsa community. They were identified people in their history but divided into sects later on.

d) Nirankari sect

A man known as Dyal started this. He belonged to a Sikh Hindu community and his group contained those who accepted the baptismal rite but there were those who accepted the Granth. These people were both Hindus & Sikhs, Dyal Das came to identify himself as a *Nirankari*, a person who believed in a formless creator. When he died his saddles were put on the altar side. His followers rejected the worship of Gurus. They did not disapprove of the Militant Nirankari. By 1891 they were numbering 51,000 and are not known to have grown much more.

e) Radha Soamis sect

This was started by one called Shiva-Dayal. He lived between 1818 and 1878, Radha means souls and Soami means master. Their belief is that to reach perfection, one must have a living Guru and they initiated one in 1960. A charismatic man called Charan Singh began it. The

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movement began to grow in great size. They gathered for birthday parties and other activities. They differed with the other Sikh by virtue of the fact that they rejected the Khalsa community and accepted the Adi Granth Scriptures.

f) Namadhari sect- Kukas Movement

This was founded by Balak Singh and later led by Ian Sign. It is known because of its changes in worship and personal appearance. They instituted a system of chanting hymns done extensively and a meeting called Kuks. They earned themselves the name of holy rollers. In later times Kuka movement took political overtones and controlled the British when they came to attack. The Kukas put up a fight. They were beaten and therefore retreated into remote areas of the mountain. That hardened them even more against the Muslims. At this time another new sect came up by Singh Sabha.

g) Singh Sabha sect

Singh Sabh saw his mission as that of helping the British. He saw the need for protecting himself from the preaching of the Christian missionaries and the Hindus Arya Samaj, which preached that every body was a Hindu. Sabah Singh said that they were different. He formed the organization, which was mainly concerned with literature and politics. They founded schools where the six scriptures were compulsory and published books, Magazine tracts and newspapers.

14.4 Question

Compare and contrast the influence of Hinduism and Islam upon Sikhism, which one has more weight?

14.5 Activity

Discuss the various types of warrior hood in each of them and how that compares with jihad in Islam.

14.6 Summary

In this lecture we learnt about Sikhism, a religion founded by Guru Nanak. We note that Hinduism and Islam influenced the founder. The elements in Sikhism of defense finally lead to establishment of sects.

14.7 Further Readings

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LESSON 14 : CONFUCIANISM

14.1 Introduction

In the previous lecture we learnt about Sikhism. In this lecture we shift to the religions that originated from Japan, China and the neighboring islands. We shall compare the three religions and their understandings of ritual practices. We begin with Confucianism.

It is one of the religions in China and Japan. The term Confucianism is used to name the religious and ethical ideas believed to have their origins on the teachings of Confucius and held by the Chinese people for the last 25 centuries. It permeates much of Chinese culture and is more of a way of life than religion. It emphasizes on the ethical and moral aspects of man and has an almost total neglect of the supernatural; the life after death issue. It is one of the three ways that teach *Tao* accepted by Chinese people. The other two religions are – Taoism and Shintoism. At times it is difficult to tell who is Shinto or Tao or Confucianism because there is a possibility of being a follower of all.

14.2 Objectives

By the end of this lecture the learner should be able to;

- ✂ Understand the founder of Confucianism
- ✂ Discuss the teachings of Confucianism.
- ✂ Describe the contribution, growth and spread of Confucianism.

14.3 Content

a) Confucius the Founder

Confucius began Confucianism. He was a great teacher. He was born as Chiu K'ung in the state at Lu about the year 551 BC. He died not far from his birthplace about the year 479 BC. The mother raised him in the absence of a father. He was born and raised in poverty at a time of great hopelessness and despair in China. As a young person he showed great interest in teaching and observing the traditional religious rites of the people. He felt a special desire to study how a just, honest and peaceful government might be attained.

b) Teachings in Confucianism

Confucius believed that the solution to the problem of poverty and oppression in the China of his day was through proper education. He said that if only the ignorance of the people could be eliminated then their problems would disappear. He devoted his life to education of the people, both poor and the noble. Confucius believed that constructive moral insight is a just and a sound political strategy and may be discovered in the meticulous study of the history of the Chinese people.

He worked on the revitalization of the ancient Chinese values, which he thought had been corrupted. Harmony between persons particularly between the family and the ruler and the ruled relationships, formed the central part of his moral teachings. He loved and practiced Chinese cultural traits e.g. sense of humor, love of music and accepting all persons and members of the family. He hated hypocrisy and insincerity and promoted the dignity of each person. He got married and had one son.

Religiously he showed very little concern in the supernatural aspects when someone asked about how to serve the spirit world he said.

„You have not learnt how to serve man well, how would I teach you how to serve the spirits.“

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c) The Scriptures

The sacred books include-

- ✂ The Analects
- ✂ The five k'ing of ching containing the basic teachings of Confucian ethics.

One important – writing the *Analects*. In these writings there are several mentions of heaven (T'ien). During the days of Confucius, there was a general belief in a divine power – T'ien. Confucius applied this belief to his approach to religion.

He seems to have understood Tien as a personal reality. He simply regarded it as universal spirit that inspired and directed him. He also acknowledged and included in his heart the presence of something greater than himself.

d) His Moral Philosophy

His central teaching is moral and not religious. In one of the four books of Confucianism, it is stated that he became one with heaven and earth. Confucian moral metaphysics reaches over into the religious quest for unity with the ground of being. He gave primary emphasis to the ethical meaning of relationships. It defined the ideal man or gentleman as-

- One governed by order and courtesy
- Serious in personal conduct
- Just to all people.
- Obedient to superiors.

He observed filial piety, which is the duty of sons to care for their parents, and the veneration of ancestors as prescribed by tradition.

He was the 1st to use the golden rule, which says,

„What I do not wish others to do to me that also I do not do to them.“

Note

The Chinese concept *Tao* meaning the way, was interpreted by Confucius to mean the way of action that is the practical morality and social living.

Confucianism came to grow further through the works of his later disciples.

- Mencius
- Itsun- and Tzu Meng tse

Mencius was successful in influencing the rulers of his day to administer the people according to the teachings of the master.

Aspects of a good ruler given by Mencius included following five contained virtues of Confucianism,

- ✂ Benevolence
- ✂ Righteousness
- ✂ Propriety
- ✂ Wisdom
- ✂ Sincerity

He traveled from province to province propagating the teaching of Confucianism.

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e) Growth and Development of Confucianism

After Mencius another notable Confucianist appeared – Hsun-Tzu (292-328 B.C). He emphasized the doctrine of ritual action. He provided a model for daily living, which supports the religious and ethical teachings of Confucius and Mencius. As the time passed by the word heaven Tien started to appear meaning a new idea of a supreme deity in Confucianism. However more Confucians continued to become more pantheistic they saw god in everything and the universe was seen as divine. Chang Tsai (1020-1072 AD) developed a mystical vision of the unity of the world expressing it as one perfect family. Other Confucian philosophers continued to provide life- models for those seeking Confucian sage hood. Teaching was based on the quest for human mind .He taught that through doing good, one would be transformed into the mind of heaven and attains the state of perfect excellence.

Since the communist revolution of Mao Tse Tung in 1949, Confucianism has been weakened in mainland China. Other crises include, the influence of Buddhism and Secularism. Hong Kong and Taiwan have however developed as centers of Confucianism and they have become centers of Chinese intellectualism and culture. Much of it is however still alive in universe morality, respect for family and state and belief in the way of heaven. A new Asian college has been founded as the headquarters of Confucianism.

15.4 Question

Discuss Confucius moral philosophy and give his regard to god and heavenly living.

15.5 Activity

Write an analysis of your understanding of Tao according to Confucius showing how it can help in running a government as a philosophy.

15.6 Summary

In today's lecture we learnt about Confucianism founded by Confucius, a religion that compares closely with Taoism and Shintoism. We have noted that it is a religion keen on moral living but has little to do with deity. It majors on human beings doing good so as to attain perfect excellence.

15.7 Further Readings

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LESSON : 16 TAOISM

16.1 Introduction

In our last lecture, we discussed Confucianism founded by Confucian, its teaching growth and development. In this lecture we shall study Taoism a religion founded in China but similar in some way to Confucianism and Shintoism It is one of the three oldest Chinese religions. It is based on Chinese philosophy.

16.2 Objectives

By the end of this lecture the learner should be able to

- ✂ Describe Taoism
- ✂ Discuss the teachings of Taoism
- ✂ Compare and contrast Taoism with Confucianism.
- ✂ Understand its philosophy growth and development.

16.3 Content

a) The Origins of Taoism

The founder (sage) is Lao-Tse. Traditional legends say that Lao Tse was born in 604 B. C and lived for over 160 years, although recent writers cast doubt on the legends about him and have it that he never existed. The legends say that he spent 60 years in his mother's womb. He was born with white hair and a beard and was named Lao Tse (The old master). A legend tells of how Lao Tse met Confucius and tried to tell him to abandon his arrogant ways and many desires, which were not worth of a sage. Confucius is said to have heard of this old master Lao Tse and described him as a dragon.

Lao Te Ching, the Taoism scripture was completed about the 3rd century BC by an anonymous author. The writer seems to be aware of the teaching of Confucius and may have been written to provide an alternative worldview to Confucianism.

There are about 50 million adherents of Taoism although this number cannot be confirmed because one who is a Taoist can also be a Confucian or Buddhist.

b) The basic teaching of Taoism

Tao means the way; it is the unchanging, indescribable nameless way and a mystery of darkness. It is the resource and the doorway from which all the creatures of the earth have come. It is a mysterious and quiet way yet powerful and eternal, symbolized by water because water is soft, does not scramble, settles at the lowest level yet it gives life to all creatures and finally overcomes all. All who follow it, who therefore become „quietist“, must reflect this quietness, naturalness and power of Tao. The sage –founder-teacher does not push himself to the front but like water, teaches by example rather than the word. In this manner he is able to control all things including him. By moving towards the void and holding fast to quietness one is in Tao and survive Taoism disregards morality ethics with their artificial rules and regulations and does not make anyone moral but only give rise to theft and profit making. If people stopped worrying about secular law and wisdom, they would be more compassionate and dutiful to ethics and their own nature. This applies to teachers and readers. The Tao opposes all warfare because it brings devastation and decay. Lao Tse argued that to delight in weapons means to delight in death that never achieves peace but suffering and misery. Tao is therefore the origin of all things. It is the unity behind all multiplicity and the basis of being from all that is. Tao like a drifting ship goes where it will cover all creatures without cutting.

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Note

The sage believed in doing all things in silence for those who know do not speak and those who speak do not know.

They emphasis quietness and inactivity so as to assist the religious minded people to a way by which they may transcend the limited conditions of human existence. This desire was to steal the secret of heaven and earth and unite themselves with the mystery of life itself in order to fulfill their desire for morality.

In many ways Taoism taught the opposite of Confucianism

Note

Taoism	Confucianism
Seeks to turn man away from society to the contemplation of the mysteries of the universe	Attempts to make people perfect and taught them how to live in harmony with the world and with each other.
Fulfillment is spontaneous and trans ethical	It started with man and his society.
It is not realized by following rules and regulations	The way refers to practical morality in social living
Requires that each person be placed within good conduct	The harmony puts a person in touch with the cosmic process of life and creativity.
It is the metaphysical absolute and offers an alternative to authoritarian Confucianism	Is more authoritative and Depend on moral law

Lao Tse taught that the ways of men are conditioned by those of heaven. Lao Tse has been associated with non-government but he was against bad government.

c) Sects in Taoism

There were two sects of Taoism that came up with the passage of time as people responded to Lao Tse teachings.

d) Chang Ching

He founded the way of perfect peace; he spread the use of charms and demanded their use as a means of inner power. He promised the remission of sin through good deeds. In A.D 184 there was a demonstration in the army and the people who led it were called - yellow Turbans. This set up a sequence of Tao uprisings. Taoism was not much of the religion of the majority.

It appealed more to the lower classes.

e) Neo Taoism

Wang P1 Ho Yan and Ko-hung are associated with neo Taoism. It had a paralytic outlook to

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human affairs and advocated views from an artistic expression.

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In it popularized magical Taoism by kop hung who was called the governor, the faithful adherent would attain peace by retention of breath, good deeds, being vegetarian by contemplation by controlling their sexual habits and by taking longevity drugs. They help them to result heat and gain immunity from illness. Is traceable to one known as KO – Tsuan but developed by T „ao Huang Ching who lived between 452-535 A.D. Huang Ching sent to Ko Tsuan the sect at Ling Pao and transcended treasure, through-yu-lo-hsiao meaning transcended being and primal unit. He also said that the supreme being (Huang Ching) sent him to be a master of the triple mystery doctrine. Mystic Taoists are people who have access to inner knowledge. They know what is real to them.

Note

A syncretic religious culture of Confucianism, Taoism – Buddhism has become a basic component of the Chinese mind and no modern mounts of change will ignore that very foundation of the Chinese personality. The three religious will continue to influence Chinese culture.

16.4 Question

Discuss the teaching of the way *taoism* and show the differences brought about by Chang Ching, Wang Pi and Ko-hung.

16.5 Activity

Compare and contrast the Taoism and Confucianism philosophy of the way which one do you find applicable to modern understanding of moral living.

16.6 Summary

In this lesson we have learnt about Taoism founded by Lao Tse. A religion with Chinese philosophy but has spread to Japan and some far East Islands. Lao Tse taught Tao as the quiet way and followers learn by observing. Other followers came and modified it. It continues to exist as sects as well.

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LESSON 17: SHINTOISM

17.1 Introduction

In our previous lecture we learnt about Taoism founded by Lao Tse .We noted that he was an old man who taught about quiet living and teaching by example. In this lecture we shall take pilgrim to Japan and meet Shintoism. Shintoism is the religion of 99% of people in Japan. As with Confucianism and Taoism it may be compared with other religions such as Buddhism or even Christianity. It may also be found in some parts of Asia. Globally the religion has a total number of about 30 million followers. The name Shinto is of Chinese origin. It means Shen-tao which means Tao or the way of the gods. The Japanese have an equivalent of this term; Kami no michi. Kami-gods in Japanese or any other divine power are manifested in great rocks, trees, and other natural phenomena. Unlike other religions, Shintoism is basically not a system of beliefs. The Japanese people love their land and believe the islands of Japan were the first divine creation. This is an old idea and is of divine origin of their land. It goes hand in hand with the beliefs of the Shinto. This national idealism, the love of their country is basically why Shinto has been limited to Japan.

17.2 Objectives

By the end of this lecture the learner should be able to:

- ✂ Understand the teachings of Shintoism as compared to Confucianism and Taoism.
- ✂ Describe the Shinto religion and emperor cult.
- ✂ Describe Shinto's belief and practices and influence on individual followers

17.3 Content

a) The Origins of Shintoism

The Japanese name for their country is Nippon, which means „sun Origin“. Until the end of the World War II, Japanese children were taught at school that the emperors were descendants of the sun-goddess, Amaterasu. Amaterasu had allegedly given the imperial house the divine right to rule. From that background Shintoism became a state religion.

b) Shintoism Development and Teachings

The stories of the Shinto gods are told in the Nihongi and Kojiki –chronicles of Japan. Shinto does not consider any one of volume as wholly inspired revelation on which its religion is based. Two books are considered sacred and have done much to influence the beliefs of the Japanese people. These books are KO-JI-KI records of ancient matters and Nihongi chronicles of Japan. They were both composed around 720 A.D. they report events occurring some 1300 years earlier in the history of Japan. The Ko-ji-ki is the oldest existing written record in Japan. It contains the myth, the works, legends and historical narratives in relating the story of Japan, the imperial ancestors and the imperial court. According to Ellwood.R. There are four basic affirmations, which are inherent in Shinto religion. They include;

- ✂ Affirmation of tradition, these are rituals performed and festivals celebrated.
- ✂ Affirmation of life in this world, it involves the high and happy moments of life.
- ✂ Affirmation of purity, involves distinction between purity and pollution.
- ✂ Affirmation of feastival, involves rites practices by members in a shrine.

Shinto worship follows a basic structure represented by letter „P“ for purification, presentation, prayer and purification.

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The stories carry the ancient names of deities and their roots in prehistoric Japan. The stories take the place of religious devotional writings in Japan. After many ancient deities with roots in pre-historic Japan two of these deities emerged.

☞ The male who invites

☞ The female who invites

These two gave birth to the islands of Japan. From the pair came the chief deity of Japan known as Amaterasu omi kami. The heaven illuminating goddess

She rules the light and the day wisely and kindly- she gives peace and order and protects the food supply. Susci-no-wo is her mother who belongs to the domain of the invisible, magic and exorcism. She is believed to be the cause of pestilence and disaster unless she is calmed through ritual in times of calamity. Amaterasu is the chief god and her shrine at Ise is the holiest of all shrines. Some special imperial symbol are believed to have been hers and kept there. They are;

- A Mirror
- A sword
- A bead

Amaterasu is believed to have sent her son Ni-M-gi to rule over the Japan land. He married the daughter of mount Fuji and their grandson Jimmu Ternro is said to have been the 1st emperor of Japan. The imperial line therefore maintains the supremacy of Amaterasu. The emperor of Japan is believed to be a descendant of Amaterasus and given divine quality. The Japanese believe that there is one supreme deity.

c) Amaterasu –omi-kami

The heaven shining August-goddess According to other myths, are other 800,000 spirits of ancestors. These are spirits of the wind, rain earthquake, sea, trees, healing, purification, family, other Japanese heroes are also deified and they may be referred to as Kami (the supernatural beings). From 1868-1945 the Shinto religion was tied up with the emperor cult and the shrine at Ise. After the humiliation of Japan at the end of the war, the emperor's semi divine status was officially denied and Shinto lost its dominant position. Since then, the observance of Shinto practices has become a voluntary matter. Imperial family however, still receives high and probably sacred esteem by many of the Japanese people. Leading Shinto shrines still remain important symbols of Japanese nationalism

d) Shinto Practices and Influence

The practices are widely restricted to individual observances at one of the many shrines in Japan. People visit the shrines to offer their own requests before a journey, an exam or any other challenging event. At times they may pass by a shrine and simply enter. Other people go to the shrine on December 31st during the visit they put feathered wooden arrows meant to drive evil away, protective charms and strips of paper bearing the name of the shrine visited. After the visit they take these items home and place them on family mini shrine or Kami shelf. With the practice of Shintoism the Japanese people have developed a culture that loves nature and beauty while emphasizing the virtues of family unit, diligence at work and a sense of duty. They have picked the love of learning from Confucianism and the spirit of self-sacrifice from Buddhism.

e) The way of Salvation

Firstly in worship the human beings are required to remember to celebrate the gods. The fire to cook the offerings may be started with traditional drill, which is taken to be pure. A ring of evergreen feature may be taken to symbolize purity and continuity of joyous life.

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The shintos are required to remain pure, sincere and enjoy life. This is confirmed in the affirmation of life in this world where the Shinto holds joyous festivals and bountiful harvest to celebrate the good things of this world. Purity is considered to be the most important feature in Shintoism as far as their salvation is concerned.

The shrines represent pure spaces in the midst of polluted world. When entering the shrine, one has to keep him pure by washing oneself and removing other impurities with a green branch. The shintos are also supposed to support the societies of which Kami are patrons. They contribute the offerings, which are mainly fruits, vegetables, rice, seafood, salt, water and water and rice.

Shintoism in Japan influences all religious sects. There has been considerable growth in Shinto sects such as

- ❖ Tnri-Kyo, the religion of heavenly wisdom.
- ❖ Konko-yo – the religion of the golden light
- ❖ These new sects are organized like churches, providing security and fellowship amid the changing social conditions of modern Japan.
- ❖ Shintoism therefore, continues to have significant influence on the Japanese people.
- ❖ It is the unifying factor in Japanese culture.
- ❖ Shintoism and Buddhism have fitted well in Japanese culture
- ❖ Western religions such as Christianity have also gained limited acceptance but Shintoism has the majority of the Japanese.

17.4 Question

Describe the history and development of state religion in Japan.

17.5 Activity

Compare and contrast the three religions in a table showing how the concept Tao is interpreted and practiced by each religion.

17.6 Summary

In this lecture we have covered the main religion in Japan, Shintoism. We noted that the religion began as emperor worship in the 17th century but lost its emperor recognition during the Second World War. The Shinto's way of salvation involves remembering and celebrating the gods, remaining pure and sincere, enjoying life and supporting the societies of which Kami are patrons.

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LESSON 18: ZOROASTRIANISM

18.1 Introduction

In our last lecture we discussed Shintoism beliefs and practices. We noted that it is a religion mainly in Japan and in parts with a history of Asia. It's a religion with a history of emperor worship and an individual is required to visit the shrine severally during various occasions. It is also a celebrative religion. In this lecture we shall look into one of the religions of the near east Zoroastrianism. It is the second oldest religion next to Judaism, Christianity and Islam. It originated in Iran or ancient Persia. The Aryan invaders of India had influenced the Persians. Is the religion basically founded on the teachings given by Zarathustra

18.2 Objectives

By the end of this lecture the learner should be able to

- ❖ Describe Zoroastrianism and the founder.
- ❖ Analyze the teachings
- ❖ Discuss the spread and growth of Zoroastrianism.

18.3 Content

a) The Founder OF Zoroastrianism

Zarathustra was born and worked in Iran. He was a great prophet sometimes referred to as the prophet of Iran. Born between 10th and 15th Century B.C. Died 547 B.C.

From early youth, Zarathustra showed great compassion and concern for others. He spent long periods in seclusion and meditation and he remained silent for seven years.

He received a prophetic call at around 30 years of age and the visions continued with six archangels who gave him instructions in the doctrines and duties of the true religion.

Ahura Mazda gave him several conferences from which he received and worshipped one true god; the supreme being and was sent to convert all living well to his true religion.

The teachings include,

b) Ethical Monotheism

Zarathustra did not teach a new religion. He taught a religion based on the old religion of his people. In opposition to the polytheism and ritualism of the old religion Zarathustra taught a unique ethical monotheism He declared Ahura Mazda as the one and only true god. Ahura Mazda was already known in the old religion and had a special allegiance by Zarathustra's own clan. In comparison to other deities he was regarded as highly ethical. Ahura Mazda is said to have called Zarathustra to his presence who revealed himself to him as the one true god and instructed him on the true religion, appointing him as prophet and sending him to teach men that true religion; Zoroastrianism. Ahura Mazda is the creator and sustainer of all things. He is supreme, omnipresent, omniscient, all seeing and most mighty, glorious, radiant, most firm, wisest, most perfect and most beautiful. He denounced all other gods of the old religion as devils and deceivers e.g. *Angra Mainyu* who seduces people to do evil and turn them away from worshipping Ahura Mazda alone. Ahura Mazda is also known as *Ormazd*. He has another divine being closely associated with him through whom he expresses and accomplishes his will and purposes known as *Spenta Mainyu*; Holy spirit

Other divine agents include:

- Amesha Spenta-Immortal Holy one
- Vohu Manah - Good thought

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- Asha- right

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- Kishathra- Power or dominion
- Hauyatat- Prosperity
- Armati- piety
- Ameretat – Immortality

The first two can be taken to be Ahura Mazda's attribute but in Zoroastrianism they seem to be personified and represented as divine forces, with the possibility of personal relationship with them. They have also been regarded as Ahura Mazda's archangels Vahu Manah for example is the archangel who appeared to Zarathustra in his initial revelation and guided him to Ahura Mazda's presence.

c) Zarathustra's Dualism

Besides this unique ethical Montheism, Zarathustra taught at the same time a dualism that is seen as more special characteristic feature of his teaching than his monotheism. He taught the existence of two powerful rival cosmic spiritual principles right from the beginning of the universe, one good the other evil.

Spenta Mainyu and Angra Mainyu (Evil spirit)

They are represented in outer Zoroastrian scriptures as having been twin spirits.

Zarathustra taught that the two had originated from Ahura Mazda. These differences originate in the exercise of their power of freedom of choice. Spenta mainyu chooses good, truth and right meaning that he acted according to Ahura Mazda's will. Angra Mainyu also called Ahriman choose evil, untruth and false. He acted in complete opposition to Ahura Mazda and his will. There is thus a spiritual ethical struggle between Ahura Mazda with this holy spirit and Angra Mainyu- (evil spirit). The cosmic conflict between good and evil, truth and lies, light and darkness is characteristic of nature and existence and especially significant in man's soul. The greatest emphasis is laid on freedom of choice both in the spiritual realm and in the human realm. Angra Mainyu is always busy seeking to seduce people to sin but they have the freedom to choose. His other divine agents like Vohu Manah guides them to know what is right good and true. The wise choose what is right and attach themselves to Ahura Mazda.

Note

Salvation of the human soul/spirit is seen in terms of liberation and escape from entanglement and domination by the material aspect of reality. Ascetism is one of the main ways achieving such liberation and salvation. In Zoroastrianism the material aspect of reality is not despised as evil and there is no asceticism. Instead the material aspect of reality is considered as Ahura Mazda's creation and is to be used and enjoyed wisely and responsibly.

d) Zoroastrian Scriptures

They are known as the Avesta –meaning knowledge. There are many different writings but the major ones are

- Yasna – a collection of liturgical writings
- The Gathas- most important and oldest of the Yasna collection
- Hymns and poems written in the 1st person in an ancient dialect. They are believed to have been spoken by Zarathustra himself. And contain his prophetic call
- The Visparad are invocations to the various lords used at festivals

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- The Yash or Yashts are a collection for sacrificial hymns of praise to specific spirits or divinities
- The vendidat, this is the law of ritual purification

e) Zoroastrians Teaching About Death

At first Zarathustra entertained a hope of the final victory of the forces of good over evil and the establishment of a kingdom of righteousness here on earth. Later he saw his final triumph of good over evil taking place in the next world, beyond death and at the end of the present world order. The survivors are mentioned as

- Austerdar
- Austerdar-Mah
- Soashyard

Each would be a supernatural descendant of Zarathustra and would like him, have miraculous birth with a 15 year old virgin mother Saoshyat would prepare a final victory over forces of evil at the resurrection of the dead which would then take place. The judgment of each individual is said to take place not long after death and one's fate is then fixed until the general resurrection at the end of the present world order. The judgment takes place at the bridge, which crosses over the abyss of hell to Ahura Mazda's paradise. At this bridge the soul's record is read and weighed against good or bad deeds. The soul whose evil outweighs the load is unable to cross the bridge and it falls over into hell below.

Note

Zoroastrianism has corresponding ideas with Judaism, Christianity and Islam.

f) Modern Zoroastrianism: The Parsley

Zoroastrianism has been weakened by Muslim conquest of Iran and its neighboring countries. It continues to be tolerated as the religion of the book like Christianity and Judaism. Most Zoroastrians have migrated to Bombay and Western India. Their total number is about 150,000. About 30,000 remain in Iran known as Gabars. In Kenya there were about 270 Parsis in 1972. The religion is not missionary founded. Their place of worship is called Mithra or fire temples. Worshippers bring offerings and receive ashes from the sacred fire. Prayers are also said at home early in the morning. Zoroastrians do not bury their dead, as this would defile the earth, which is holy. They put the corpses on top of circular towers where vultures lick them clean and drop the bones below. Parses are industrious, have a high ethical and social concern. The religion is also seeking to be modernized so as to cope with the world today.

18.4 Question

What do you understand by the term ethical monotheism?

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18.5 Activity

Write five points showing why Zoroastrianism has not spread out in numbers since it was founded.

18.6 Summary

In today's lecture we have discussed the religion founded by Zarathustra in Iran or ancient Iran. We noted his teaching of ethical monotheism contrary to previous religions, which were polytheistic. We also note the gradual disappearance of the religion in Iran and its poor performance in missionary activity.

18.7 Further Readings

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LESSON 19: JUDAISM

19.1 Introduction

In our last lecture we discussed Zoroastrianism a religion founded by Zarathustra from the near east. In this lecture we shall discuss Judaism a religion that shares its scripture with Christianity and Islam. The three religions have also a lot in common but also many differences. Judaism is the parent of Christianity and Islam. It is one of the three world religions considered as religions of the book.

19.2 Objectives

By the end of this lecture the learner should be able

- ✂ Understand the origin of Judaism.
- ✂ Understand the teaching of Judaism.
- ✂ Discuss the concept of the chosen people of Yahweh.

19.3 Content

a) Origin and Concept of God in Judaism

It's concept of God indicates belief in one true co- creator and ruler of the world. He is transcendent, all knowing, all seeing. He revealed his law (Torah) to all Jewish people chose all Jews to be an example and light to mankind. Judaism has no formal creed the essence of faith is found in the Shema. Shema are passages from Torah read in the morning and evening. The law of God is paramount to the Jews found in the 5 books of Moses which records what God revealed to Moses on Mt. Sinai 3000 years ago. It consists of 613 commandments on daily guidance about civil law, personal hygiene and diet. These commandments have proved to be the basis of all the subsequent legal codes all over the world. The Jewish God is believed to be one who speaks facts when he speaks things happen.

b) Belief in a Messiah

This is the Jewish hope that a messiah would be sent to liberate them from Romans occupation to set his people free and set them to a time of peace and fulfillment of promises. They however, rejected Jesus as the Messiah. God spoke to the Israelites through prophets and priests and wise men:

- 1 Abraham –God sent him out
- 2 Moses sent to deliver Israelites from Egypt
- 3 Wise men made God well known to Israel
- 4 Wisdom literature proves the authority in the words of the wise men
- 5 Mishnah is the earliest interpretation, explanation and codification of the Torah.
- 6 Talmund made of the Mishnah and commentary
- 7 The covenant God's unique relationship with the Jewish people
- 8 The covenant relationship between God and his chosen people is at the center of the Jewish religion
- 9 It is a relationship offered by one side the other allowing and inviting a free response

c) Ways of Access to God

There are three ways of accessing God among the Judaist's; these are prayer, sabbaths and keeping the torah law.

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Being a Jew by religion usually means to be a Jew by nationality but one can also be a Jew by being born of a Jewish mother or by conversion. On the 8th day every Jewish boy is to be circumcised that is, undergo a religious rite/ritual performed by a trained and registered circumciser. The boy is given a Hebrew name to be used during (*Bar mitsuah*) the adult initiation ceremony. During the initiation the boy may read from the Torah for the first time in public. It is also used at his wedding and at his tombstone. The Jewish mother is the principal teacher of religion. At age five the boy is sent to the Synagogue to attend religious classes. Later on he attends these classes after ordinary school hours and on Sunday mornings. At age 13, he may read for the first time the scroll at the synagogue. Parents prepare for him a party to introduce him as a responsible member of the community. At that age he is expected to fulfill all the duties of a Jew and counted as an adult. A girl at 12 years old becomes *Batmitzuah* meaning daughter of the ten commandments. Her main education hour to keep the house in a good traditional way. Nowadays the Jews hold a party for the girl at age 12 but earlier on, only the boy had a party set for her.

d) Prayer

A Jew should pray three times a day. This is either done at home or in the Synagogue.

Jews wear his prayer shawl (Tallit) to show symbolically his obedience to the commandments found in the Torah. An orthodox Jew covers his head when going out as a mark of reverence towards God. At the upper right hand corner of a door post is a fixed metal or wooden box containing the Shema of Deut 6:4-9 and 13-21. When passing it devout Jews give it a hand kiss.

e) Kosher food

This is one of the teachings, which is cultural with deep religious meaning for the Jews. Kosher food means ritually clean. All food eaten must be ritually clean. The meat and dairy products are not eaten together. They must not be cooked in the same pot not even washed in the same skin or basin. One cannot eat meat, butter or cheese and milk at the same time, or pour milk into coffee. Pork is considered unclean. Before each meal a blessing has to be recited by the father of the home.

f) Sabbath

The most important of all Jewish feasts commemorates the creation of the world and deliverance from Egypt. It begins at the onset of Friday evening. All working Jews hurry home and those self employed shut down their business. They pray the prayer of blessing to welcome Sabbath as a day of joy, peace and rest. The father and sons go for evening prayer. Upon return the man praises his children and wife (Prov. 31). The family then settles down to enjoy the Sabbath meal, which begins with bread and wine. No work is allowed on Sabbath or tiresome journeys. At times non-Jews are employed to do the work that must be done on Sabbath e.g. in hospitals. Sabbath day is a day of spiritual renewal and at the end of it, the family gathers again for a prayer of blessing hoped to carry them through the new week.

g) Important Jewish Feasts

- ❖ **Rosh Hashanah:** New year (10 days) –September, October- Celebrates creation
- ❖ **Yom Kippur:** The feast of Atonement concludes the 10-day celebration of the New Year. Holiest of all Jewish feasts.
- ❖ **Purim:** Joyful celebration commemorates the events in the book of Esther
- ❖ **Pesach:** Passover- A joyful family feast which celebrates the deliverance from Egypt

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- ❖ **Sukkot:** Harvest festival- Thanking god for his goodness during the journey through the desert
- ❖ **Shavout:** Pentecost another harvest festival seven weeks after Passover
- ❖ **Hankkah:** Feast of light celebrates the rededication at the temple in Jerusalem after the Maccabeans had expelled the Syrians in 164 B.C.
- ❖ **Smirchat torah:** Feast of rejoicing in the law – Thanking God for giving them the law

h) Beliefs in the resurrection after Death

At the moment of death the prayer „shema“ is said, all present cut a small portion of their clothes as a sign of sorrow. The Funeral takes place twenty-four hours after death and it is simple one. There are no prayers for the dead but the son of the dead at the funeral recites prayers of praise to God. Close relatives are mourned for seven days.

19.4 Question

What is the difference between Zoroastrianism philosophy and the Jewish Philosophy with regard to the concept of God?

19.5 Activity

Draw three columns and compare and contrast Judaism with Islam and Christianity showing points of similarities with regard to foundations, scripture spread and development.

19.6 Summary

In this lesson we have discussed Judaism. We note that Judaism shares its scripture with the Christians and Muslims but has no recognition of the messiah like the Christians or the last prophet like the Muslims. The religion majors on moral living and is keen on observing traditions set under the Mosaic law. We note that Jews are diligent workers in line with their scriptures.

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LESSON 20: CHISTIANITY

20.1 Introduction

In our last lecture we discussed Judaism and noted its emphasis on traditions as taught in the Mosaic Law. In this lecture we shall discuss Christianity a religion that shares part of its scripture with Judaism and Islam. It acknowledges the messiah a factor the Judaists have never come to terms with.

20.2 Objective

By the end of this lecture the learner should be able to:

- ❖ Understand the origin and growth of Christianity
- ❖ Describe the concept of God, the scriptures and the belief and practices of the four types of spirituality.
- ❖ Describe the spread and development of Christianity.

20.3 Content

a) The Origins of Christianity

Christianity is the religion that worships Jesus Christ, the Son of God as the unique self-revelation of God to man. Jesus is remembered as the real historical figure and not a myth. The Jews rejected Jesus as the messiah because he did not bring them the political deliverance they had long awaited. His teachings annoyed the Pharisees and they killed him like a criminal. Christ preached a life of repentance and forgiveness.

Note

He sacrificed his own life to bring salvation. To do this he instituted a new covenant, the covenant was sealed with his own blood and not the blood of animals.

Through his apostle the chosen 12, Christianity has been passed to all successive generations. His resurrection from the dead confirmed his uniqueness as the Saviour of the world.

b) Scriptures

Christians use the Bible as their only holy book. The essence of the Bible is sacred history. Gods intervened in man's life through Abraham then Moses and finally Jesus Christ. Through the new and old covenant God provides liberation of the people of God His (Chosen people). These are all acts of intervention of God for the whole world

c) Concept of God

Christianity teaches about god in three persons. This is human expression of divinity. In Christian trinity the spontaneous indication of Father, son and spirit towards one another restore alls things to unity. Love is part of the very structure of the divine being. Love is an eternal exchange of persons, which constitutes the basis of all existence.

Note

The understanding of god as a trinity sharply differentiate Christianity from Judaism and Islam.

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d) Ways of Access to God

People find their way to God through faith in Christianity. It is an adherence to revelation from the word of God. Faith introduces Christians to a participation in the life of God and the knowledge of God to which he alone can lead humans. Reconciliation with God and neighbors after one has sinned is the first step towards God. God offers forgiveness and a Christian should joyfully surrender his life to God. A Christian life is world affirming, accepting and enjoying the food of created things on the one hand, on the other hand a Christian takes seriously the sufferings and struggles in a world gone wrong through pride and greed. A Christian is recognized by a radical new life-style which takes serious the good work dimensions of prayer and worship and a common Christian life where care, love and respect for the poor and oppressed is the norm of life.

There are FOUR distinct approaches to God

- ❖ The Catholic way
- ❖ The Protestant Spirituality
- ❖ The orthodox spirituality
- ❖ The Evangelical/Pentecostal way

e) The Catholic Way

Involves the use of sacraments. The journey of a Christian begins at Baptism and Ends with a vision to God in heaven.

f) Orthodox Spirituality

Deeply rooted in the sacraments but its distinctiveness lies in the use of icons. Through this icons God is reached.

e) Protestant Spirituality

What sacraments and icons are to orthodox and Catholics the bible is to the Protestants. Through the reading of the word of God and through prayer they find their assurance of free access to God through Christ. They place great value on individual approach to God. In Christ, Christians become what God wants them to be.

h) Evangelical Spirituality

Similar to Protestant spirituality but are not legalistic in seeking manifestation of the Holy Spirit, through speaking in tongues, healing and recognizing the five fold ministry described in Ephesians 4:11.

i) Historical and Geographical Setting

After the ministry of Jesus Christ, Christianity spread through the Roman Empire. It survived the Roman persecution under Emperor Nero –64 AD. It got established under the Western empire in 476 AD. In the East it survived as the Christian state at Byzantium until it fell to the Islamic forces in 1433 AD. In 1054 Christianity became divided to

- ❖ Eastern Orthodox Church
- ❖ Western Catholic Church

It experienced problems with heresies in the middle ages. In the 5th century the reformation challenged papal authority and split the Western Church into Catholics and Protestants. Protestantism divided yet again in different denominations. Some of them continue being divided to date. The European expansion and missionary activity from the 16th c onwards spread to U.S.A, Africa, Asia and Latin America. Christianity in Europe today has greatly

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declined since the 20th C while in the developing countries it is flourishing. Christianity is

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claimed to be the largest world religion in many cases Christianity is identified with how culture and both have dominated recent world history.

Christianity peculiarity is the fact that over the centuries it has faced heavy persecution and oppression right from its start. It has survived because of the personal relationship adherent's develop with the Supreme Being and the trinity. Currently it has greatly expanded in the developing world.

20.4 Question

Describe Christianity as compared to Judaism do you think Jesus provides an answer to the Jews need for a messiah?

20.5 Activity

Visit a Church within your vicinity and observe their ways of access to God, their spirituality and understanding of the trinity.

20.6 Summary

In this lesson we have discussed Christianity, a religion founded after the teaching of Jesus Christ. We noted that Christians access God through prayer through the trinity and seek to live a holy life according to Christ's teaching. Judaism is indicated to have been a for-runner of Christianity with the provision of the teachings of the Old Testament.

20.7 Further Readings

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LESSON 21: ISLAM

21.1 Introduction

In our last lecture we discussed Christianity and noted that the believers follow Christ's teaching, believe in the trinity and the second coming of the messiah. In this lecture we shall discuss Islam as our last religion in the near East. It is difficult to speak of Islam uniquely as a religion for it is a religious, social, economic and political system at the same time. The teaching of Islam can only be fully understood when all these aspects are seen as an integral part of religion. The word Islam is Arabic and refers to confession, submission, surrender and obedience. It has another meaning of peace. The Muslim call God *Allah* and Islam is the peaceful submission to Allah. A Muslim is one who submits himself to the will of Allah. How did this faith come about?

21.2 Objectives

By the end of this lecture the learner should be able

- ❖ Understand the origin of Islam.
- ❖ Describe its ways of access to God.
- ❖ Explain its spread and development.

21.3 Content

a) The Founder Mohammed

Muhammad founded Islam. He was born in 50 CE (Christian Era) in Mecca among the Quraysh people. His father Abdullah died before he was born and the mother died when he was six years old. As an orphan his uncle Abu bakr brought him up. At his uncle's home Mohammed worked hard and his uncle loved him very much. He also looked after animals i.e. sheep, goat and camel. In his youth Mohammed traveled to Syria twice – 1st trip he was 12 years old. He did not go to school but he grew to be trustworthy and respectable and his uncle got him a job as a manager of a caravan of camels belonging to a wealthy widow Khadijah who later became his wife. The lady had two previous husbands. She was 40 while Mohammed was only 25 years old at the time of marriage.

During his trade journeys he began to go for meditation and prayer to the hills and caves near Mecca. During one of these nights he had a call from Allah asking him to recite the name Allah. Mohammed began proclaiming Allah's message 1st to his wife, his cousin, Ali Abu bakr Uthman and Talha his friends with these converts. He began preaching publicly denouncing Mecca, polytheism, corruption and warning of eternal punishment to all who would not purify their religion and submit to Allah.

b) Structure Of Islam-Ways of Access to God

The religion of Islam is like a house supported by three fundamental structures. The three structures are supported by pillars, **Arukan**. Each of the arukan must be fully upheld by the Muslims to make their faith strong and meaningful.

According to the Muslim, Islam is the complete way of life. The religion is not locked in the mosque but the Muslims go out with it in the government, families and school and it caters for all fields of life.

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The three structures are.

- ❖ Islam-submission
- ❖ Imani-faith
- ❖ Insan-Practice.

Note

Islam-Submission is composed of five pillars. It means to testify and bare witness that there is no god but Allah and that Mohammed is his messenger. Accessing God involves submission and worship as well as observing the five pillars

c) Submission to God

Islam understands itself as a religion where everything depends on God. Mankind has to be submissive to God in obedience to his creative and sustaining power and with the purpose of expressing adoration to God. The word Muslim means one who lives his life according to God's will. Islam means submission to God.

d) Worship to God (Ibada)

The purpose cannot be separated from the market place nor politics from praise. The Quran teaches that in worship, body and spirit should be inseparably combined in wholeness and harmony. Islam has no word for spirituality for it seeks to preserve equilibrium between the outward and inward expression of worship. A believer's external act depends on his internal intention and both should be for the pleasure of God according to their teaching.

e) Imani – Faith – 2nd structure

Imani can be explained as the belief in Allah and its stressed submission. The concept of Islam is also composed of believing in one God. This Allah has no partners he is neither man nor woman. He is the supreme creator of all angels. Angels are ever obedient to Allah and spiritual beings of Allah. They have no material bodies and do not eat nor drink nor sleep. They are a mode of light e.g. Gabriel- Jibril is responsible of bringing messages to all prophet. sratel- responsible of blowing the trumpet at the end of time Israel the soul puller ends the life of souls.

f) The Belief in the Last Day (Dryam)

This is called the Day of Judgment. The Muslims believe that life on earth will come to an end and everything will be no more. All human beings will be restored to life – (resurrection). They will be paraded before Allah for judgment. All the acts of human being will be questioned. Allah shall finally pass judgment. He will reward those who pleased him by taking them to Jonah a place of eternal bliss – heaven - has 7 gates. Those who disobeyed his rules and commands will be confined to Jehanam. Hell when they will be suffering, fire and misery.

g) The Belief In Allah's Power

The earth we call Quadar a Quatha or a atha meaning the timeless knowledge of Allah. Events on earth take place according to the exert knowledge of Allah. All hat has been on earth good or had is Allah's decree of will man has been given freedom at action good or bad. He has given mail the will to choose between good and evil. Main is therefore responsible for his action. There are no inherited sins. It may steals he does it under his will. They have no belief that man is born a sinner. A baby is born free and innocent. He acquires act at sin after growing up.

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h) Ihsan – Worshipping Allah

The Third fundamental structure of Islam. Unlike the first 2 structures of Islam. This one has only one pillar. A Muslim is commanded to worship Allah as if he is seeing him. Ihsan leads one to God's consciousness. This is the highest form of spiritual advancement.

i) Allah - God In Islam

Islam is strictly monotheistic. A Muslim must believe in one God. In Koran 28:22 Allah says and why not unto any other god along with Allah. There is no god except Him. The word Allah is Arabic meaning unique God who possesses the entire attribute of perfection and beauty. Islam makes it clear that God has no son, no father, wife, sisters or daughters. They believe that man is a servant of God. Abdul- To associate with any other being is to sin. Allah goes on sustaining all that he created by the command let it be and it came to be. He is not subjected to human weakness.

j) The Five Pillars

1st Pillar Confession of Faith (Shahada)

The Islamic code of conduct is founded upon the bedrock of the testimony of faith as;

„I bear witness that there is no god but Allah, and I bear witness that Mohammed is his prophet“. These are the first words breathed into a child's ear at birth and the last words uttered by a Muslim on his/her deathbed. They point to the one God who has spoken finally through the Quran and they point to Mohammed, the seal of the prophets. The words of the Shahada summons Muslims to worship throughout the world and the meaning of it is the heart of prayer and meditation. It centers on, One God –Allah and Mohammed his prophet.

2nd Pillar Prayer (salat)

Prayer is the expression where a Muslim put himself to the relational God in the deepest sense. Muslims are required to pray five times a day.

- (a) Fajr prayer - Morning before sunrise.
- (b) Dhuhr – Midday prayer
- (c) Apr Prayer – Mid -Afternoon
- (d) Sunset prayer.
- (e) Night prayer.

Before one prays he must have purified himself *Tahara* meaning cleaning off physically.

All have to turn in the direction of the Kaa'aba (the black stone) at Mecca. Thus all Muslims all over the world form a human circle of worshippers around their holy city. At a signal from the prayer the leader *Imam* all men and women assemble separately in rows at the mosque or in the home or at the work place, making sure that each person is close to the next to symbolize that they pray as one body under the leader. All bow their body together in ritual unison going down on their knees and touching the floor with their fore heads. The whole congregation is thus enacting their submission to Allah begging for his guidance and mercy. At the end of each prayer they turn to their neighbors right and left with the greeting „AS-SALAMU ALIKUM“. Peace be with you all.

3rd pillar Zakat – Alms giving

Prayer is closely linked with alms giving. This 3rd pillar is also called the social pillar of action Zakat (almsgiving) is the duty of sharing one's wealth with the poor, the needy the debtors, the prisoners and the way fares (travelers). It is an obligatory for every Muslim to

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give alms. Muslims teaching is less concerned with the quantity than with the quality of

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(Almsgiving). The sharia has simplified the amount of almsgiving and stipulated that it should be 2½% of one's cashing balance. Almsgiving is also seen as a part of purifying one's soul. It is a mercy. To the giver as well as the receiver. It can atone for sins, which were committed out of human selfishness and self-centeredness or by cheating someone. Special alms are given on Id al-Fitr or Bairam which mark the end of Ramadhan. The holy month of fasting. The poor Muslims have the right to benefit from the rich brothers good future. In the earlier days of Islam alms used to be collected for redistribution in the community but today they are given according to the wish of individual believers.

4th Pillar – Fasting – Saum/Sijam

This is the 4th pillar of Islam. Total abstinence from food and drink from sunrise to sunset, during daylight hours. This physical discipline means that the whole community has to change for the duration of the month. The pace of life slows down and there is time of reflection and turning inwards. It is time of reconciliation, encouragement and solidarity with the whole Islamic community. Fasting is done as a thanksgiving, to discipline the souls and to wait patiently for God's guidance and providence. Fasting is observed from the law at the Koran. They are prescribed to fast so as to release them from the evils. Mohammed had told his followers that of all acts of worship this fasting was most pleasing to God. During the month of Ramadhan, fasting is observed with strict abstinence of food, sexual relationship or drinking from dusk – dawn. Exempted from fasting are the young pregnant the sucking mothers the sick and distant travelers.

5th Pillar – Haj – Pilgrimage to Mecca

Every Muslims are required to go on pilgrimage to Mecca at least once in a lifetime. They are supposed to visit the house of Allah called Ka'bah built by Ibrahim and Ishmael. Although Haj nowadays is only possible for those who have the ability to undertake the journey, the pilgrimage is a means of maintaining the continuity between the Arabian religious heritage and Muslim. The pilgrims walk around the Kabah 7 times, kissing the black stone every time. Then they run 7 times between two nearby hills. On the 8th day they move to mount Arafat where they meditate for one day on the plain on their way back to Mecca they stop at Mina where they participate in the ceremony of stoning the devil. This is followed by sacrifice and meat is distributed among brethren.

Although there is festivity and during the pilgrimage fasting is practiced from dawn to dusk and sexual abstinence is observed. The pilgrims also to round the Kabah once more and they are not supposed to cut hair or trim their nails.

k) Belief in (Salalits) Scriptures

This is to belief that Allah has revealed his commandment and rules of religion to the prophets at various times of history for the peace of mankind.

Not all prophets were given divine books. God revealed his books to the prophets before Mohammed some of the books are:

The Suhut – Scrolls – Prophet Ibrahim.

The Taurat – Torah – Prophet Moses.

The Zabur – Psalms – Prophet Daudi

The Injil – Gospel – Prophet Isaiah

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1) The Quran – Mohammed

All the holy books originate from Allah and confirm each other. Mohammed is the last prophet according to the teaching of Islam. However there are as many as 124,000 prophets. Jesus is recognized as one of the prophets suppressed by Mohammed. The Quran is the final revelation confirming earlier scriptures. It clears up all uncertainties and confirms the truth. It is God's final word to mankind.

Some of the prophets mentioned in the Koran include:

Ishaq (Isaac), Sulaiman (Solomon), Yahya (John the Baptist), Ayub (Job), Ilyas (Elija), Nuhu (Noah), Ismael (Ishmael), Al-ya'sa (Elisha), Zakara (Zacharia), Ushlkitl (Ezekiel), Yunus (Jonah), Lut (Lot), Adam (Adam).

Some of the prophets performed miracles according to Allah's, which Mohammed was able to learn from Allah and write the Koran although he was illiterate.

21.4 Question

Describe the five pillars of faith in Islam.

21.5 Activity

In the last four religions covered, compare and contrast the concept of God showing points of departure and similarities.

21.6 Summary

In this lecture we discussed the Islamic faith and noted that Mohammed founded it in 622A.D. He focused on submission and worship to Allah. His teaching emphasized observation of the five pillars for every true Muslim. We also note that since it's birth Islam has spread to several parts of the world.

21.7 Further Readings

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PART THREE: DIMENSIONS OR THEMES OF RELIGION

Introductory Notes

The term comparative, as we have seen, indicates the discovering and comparing of data, and as such the data involved must have common elements or themes or dimension, which are to be compared. In any serious discussion of religion one would not escape the question whether or not there is an essence common to all religions of the world. Indeed all religions of the world appear to have some common themes or dimensions that concern the nature and function of these religions. These are:

1. **Philosophical and Doctrinal dimension:** a system of teaching that seeks to explain religious reality.
2. **Mythical dimension:** stories about religious people, things, realities etc.
3. **Ethical dimension:** values and codes that govern individual and collective behaviour.
4. **Ritual dimension:** worship, festivals, rites of passage, customs etc.
5. **Experiential and emotional dimension:** individuals' experience of religiosity, the relationship between the individual and deity, which in most cases is characterized by a sense of awe.
6. **Social dimension:** the institutional organization of believers to practice their relation.
7. **Material dimension:** this includes, places of worship e.g. buildings, natural features, instruments of worship e.g. books, art, vestments etc.

Part three of this module seeks to introduce the learner to the above mentioned seven dimension that cut across the major religions of the world.

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LESSON: 22 PHILOSOPHICAL AND DOCTRINAL DIMENSION

22.1 Introduction

In the previous Lesson we were introduced to all the major religions of the world. These include Christianity, Islam, Judaism, Jainism, Zoroastrianism, Buddhism, Hinduism, Taoism, Shintoism, Sikhism and Confucianism. In this lesson we are going to discuss the philosophical and doctrinal dimension of religion.

22.2 Objectives

At the end of the lesson the learner should be able to:

- Show the meaning and use of doctrines in religion.
- Identify some philosophical and doctrinal arguments in specific religions and go on to compare them.

22.3 Content

22.3.1 General Background

Almost all religions contain sacred books. Such books are believed to be revealed by god and contain sacred literature, and as such they can only be translated but cannot be edited. The sacred books also contain religious philosophy, which is usually expressed in **doctrines**. The doctrines seek to give system, clarity and intellectual meaning to religious faith, rituals and practices most of which are found in holy scriptures.

The word doctrine simply means teaching and as such doctrines are simply formal and authoritative statements that articulate a religious belief. It is the acceptance of such standard teachings that makes one a member of a religious group.

As religions struggle to understand and express their supernatural nature they develop religious statements that teach the most fundamental or central beliefs in that religion. Such doctrines, although they are drawn from scripture are shaped by traditions over a period of time. They may be modified from time to time by theologians who, in most cases formulate them after consulting the relevant sacred scripture.

Doctrines are expressed in **creeds**. The word creed is derived from a Latin word, **credo**, which means to believe. However the act of believing is not just intellectual, it has also an act of commitment. Hence creeds becomes a statement of faith to the individual or the congregation. Thus by means of a creed a religion defines and teaches its basic beliefs to the members. Such creeds are accepted by the believers without any questions. Although most religions have some basic doctrines different religions emphasize different doctrines as discussed below.

Note:

It should be noted that all religions have a philosophy which seek to give system, clarity and intellectual meaning to religious faith and experience.

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22.3.2 The Concept of Karma in Jainism

The concept of **Karma** is found in Hinduism, Jainism and Buddhism. For Hinduism, Karma means a deed or action and the effect of such a deed on the soul concerned. Jain believers view Karma as a very thin material substance, which attaches itself to a soul as a result of its activity, thus making it impure and heavy. The Karma, thus binds the soul to the material world and its concerns and attractions.

At the end of each existence, the soul raises or sinks in the scale of the hierarchical forms of life according to the amount of Karma - matter it has. Those with the least amount of Karma matter may rise to the level of the gods. Those with the great amounts of Karma – matter sink to the level of beasts or to hell. The souls, which are completely free from Karma – matter, rise to the summit of the universe, where they remain eternally with other liberated souls in perfect omniscience.

Jain philosophy teaches that the universe is uncreated and eternal. It has no beginning and no end. All things in the universe fall under two categories: **the Jiva or the living things and the Ajiva or lifeless matter**. The Jiva consists of many living souls. It is the spiritual realm. These souls are uncontaminated and when they are attached to the Ajiva, they become matter and hence impure. Therefore, they must finally be liberated from the flesh to become perfect again and then rise to the summit of the universe. The liberated soul is described as without body, without resurrection, without conduct, without matter and without sex. However, it perceives and knows but cannot be felt.

22.3.4 The Shahada (Moslems' Creed)

The Muslims have a creed called **Shahada**, which states that there is no god except Allah, that he is one and the only God, and that nothing equals him. The greatest sin, therefore, is to associate a partner with God. The **Koran** teaches that God is eternal, all knowing, all powerful, and that every thing exists by his will. He sees and hears everything. He is one, first and last, the living creator, King and giver of every thing. He is loving, merciful, and generous. The duty of every Muslim is thus, submit totally to Allah and to worship him alone.

22.3.5 The Doctrine of Anatta in Buddhism

The doctrine of **Anatta** denies the existence of the soul. It says that everything is subject to pain, death and decay. Thus nothing is permanent. It says that I is only a combination of ever changing forces which together make up a being. These forces include the sensations of sight, hearing, feeling, thinking, smelling etc, and the qualities of things as they are presented to us by the senses. The combination of these senses creates an illusion that there is a person, the I. This produces desires which lead to egoism, ill-will, hatred, conceit, pride, attachment, and other evils, leading to suffering. Therefore to eliminate evil and suffering one must get rid of the false idea of the self by realizing that the self is only a combination of the ever-changing mental and material elements, leading to the principle of cause and effect or what is called Karma and rebirth.

Buddhist worship begins reciting homage to the Buddha in these words. “Homage to Him the blessed one, the exalted one, the fully enlightened one”. After the homage, they recite three refuges as follows: (1) I go to the Buddha as my refuge; (2) I go to the doctrine as my refuge; (3) I go to the brotherhood of monks as my refuge. Worshipers repeat the **Five Precepts** as

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the monk recites them. The precepts forbid killing, stealing, sexual immorality, cheating and intoxicants.

22.3.6 The Doctrine of Karma in Hinduism and Buddhism

The Buddhists belief that everything is a result of a prior cause of itself. This principle cannot be changed either by prayer or sacrifice. It says that life comes back after death. The soul of a man may come back in form of anything and may therefore enjoy or suffer. The present life, therefore, is largely influenced by past events. The present will also impact on the future. The chain of existence will continue as long as there is desire /wish. But once the desire ceases one steps outside the chain of rebirth. This leads to nirvana, which means dying or extinction. It is the extinguishing of the fire of desire ending reincarnation. Life then comes to an end and so is lust, greed, selfishness, desires etc, leading to complete freedom from all evils.

According to Hinduism the aim of human life is to achieve oneness with the ultimate reality. Each soul hence, must go through many stages of rebirth until the soul is purified and ready to join the soul of the universe, which is its destiny. This process is called **Samara** and means going through. It is a series of births, deaths and rebirths till the soul is finally released into the universe. This final release is called **Moksha**. It is the exit of this world that liberates the soul from the material world and the entry into the real existence and absorption into God. This is the state of supreme blessedness, the life in God. The doctrine teaches no rewards and no punishments.

There is another doctrine known as **Avatar** that talks about the descending of God from heaven i.e. incarnation. It talks about 9 incarnations that have so far taken place. It presents God in three fold i.e. Brahman, the creator, Vishnu, the protector, and Shiva, the destroyer. The three form the **Trimurti**, the one God with three forms, similar to the Egyptian Triad and the Christian Trinity.

22.3.7 The Doctrine of the Trinity

The doctrine of the Trinity, which realized the Trinitarian creed was developed by the early Christians to defend the faith against false teachings referred to as **heresies**. The doctrine states that in the Godhead there are three persons; God the father, God the son and God the Holy Spirit. However the three form one true God, whose substance is indivisible. The creed opens that “I believe in God, the father almighty, creator of heaven and earth, I believe in Jesus Christ his only Son our Lord, I believe in the Holy Spirit...”

Besides the doctrine of the Trinity Christians have other doctrines that seek to give meaning to creation, grace, salvation, incarnation etc.

22.4 Question

What are the sources of philosophy and doctrine in African Religion?

22.5 Activity

Write brief points to show the purpose or role of philosophy and doctrine in religion. Give specific examples where possible.

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22.6 Summary

Doctrines are found in almost all religions. These give system, clarity and intellectual meaning to religions. They are formal statements that articulate religious beliefs. In most cases doctrines are shared by traditions over a period of time, and are expressed in creeds. Examples of the doctrines include the doctrine of Karma in Hinduism and Jainism, Rebirth and Anatta in Buddhism, the Trinity in Christianity and the Shahada in Islam among others.

22.7 Definition of key words

Doctrines: A religious teaching or belief which is taught and upheld within a particular religious community.

Creed. Derived from a Latin word, **credo**, which means to believe. It is a statement of faith or belief.

Nirvana: Described in Buddhism as a state of joy, the end of suffering and pain. It is an experience of bliss, which is attained by anyone either in the material world or after death.

Samara: Stages of rebirth in Hinduism through which each soul must go in order to be purified and ready to join the soul of the universe, which is its destiny.

Moksha: The exit of this world that liberates the soul from the material world and the entry into the real existence and absorption into God. This is the state of supreme blessedness in Hinduism, the life in God.

Shahada: The Moslem's creed, which states that there is no god except Allah, that he is one and the only God, and that nothing equals him.

Koran: Islamic holy book

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Definition of key words continued

Heresy: In Christianity it means false teaching or a doctrine contrary to the generally accepted faith or teaching.

Karma: Found in Hinduism, Jainism and Buddhism to mean a deed or action and the effect of such a deed on the soul concerned.

Jiva and the Ajiva: Terms used in Jainism to mean the living things and the lifeless matter respectively.

Anatta: Doctrine in Buddhism that denies the existence of the soul. It says that everything is subject to pain, death and decay and thus nothing is permanent.

Avatar: Hindu doctrine that talks about the descending of God from heaven i.e. incarnation. It presents God in three fold i.e. Brahman, the creator, Vishnu, the protector, and Shiva, the destroyer.

Trimurti: The one God in Hinduism with three forms, similar to the Egyptian Triad and the Christian Trinity.

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LESSON: 23 ETHICAL AND LEGAL DIMENSION OF RELIGION

23.1 Introduction

In the previous Lesson we discussed the philosophical and doctrinal dimension of religion, which seeks to give system, clarity and meaning to religious believes and practices. This lesson focuses on the ethical dimension, which simply denotes the law or the legal aspects within religion.

23.2 Appendix 9.2 Objectives

By the end of this lesson the learner should be able to:

- Describe the ethical dimension of religion and be able to give some examples.
- Be able to examine role of religion in reinforcing ethical and moral behaviour.

23.3 Content

23.3.1 General Background

The ethical dimension determines the right actions, behaviour and relationships among believers. This is what is referred to as ethical action, the means by which societies socialize the members into responsible people. Actions that conform to the moral or ethical code of a society are rewarded while the opposite would be punished.

Most religions usually incorporate a code of ethics. This code of ethics controls the behaviour of the individual as well as that of the group or community. Therefore, religions have been influential in molding the ethnical attitudes of the societies they are part of. Although it is not obvious that people always live up to the standards professed by their respective religions, it is a fact that religions shape greatly the behaviour of individuals in every human society.

As a way of reinforcing ethical and moral conduct among societies develop laws to be followed. These are found in all religions and teach the members the dos and don'ts. They therefore form a fundamental aspect of religion. It helps people to know what they should do, how to behave and what kind of persons they should be.

Religions provide norms and principles that guide ethical and moral actions. These are simply obligations that must be followed. Most people at one time or another experience ethical action in the form of a duty or responsibility. Although they may not be pleasing, religious duties and responsibilities must be met promptly. Religion therefore, provides a code of ethics, which the believers must follow, e.g. the Ten Commandments in the Bible, the Five Precepts in Buddhism, the Golden Rule in Zoroastrianism or the Sharia in Islam.

23.3.2 Buddhist Precepts

Buddhist, who were converted into the religion in its initial stages, formed an order of community of Buddhist monks called **Sangha**. Many of Gautama's own caste the **Kshatriya** joined the order. It was later made open to people of all castes. As the number, of monks grew, Buddha was busy organizing the life of the order. The monks lived in small monastic communities where they received instructions, practiced self-discipline and mutual service. The essential common marks of the Buddhist monk are:

1. A yellow robe (they wore)
2. A shaven head
3. A begging bowl (they carried)

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4. Daily meditations

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5. A short creed, which they recite this way: “I take refuge in the Buddha. I take refuge in the **Dharma** (the law or truth as taught by Buddha): I take refuge in the Sangha (order of monks).
6. The ten precepts which all pledge to observe.

Precepts are not commandments by God; they are norms made by the community for everyone to follow. The Precepts are as follows:

1. Do not destroy life
2. Do not take anything not given – (stealing)
3. Do not engage in any form of un chastity
4. Do not lie or deceive
5. Do not take any intoxicants
6. Eat moderately
7. Do not watch dirty dancing, singing or drama
8. Do not make use of ornaments or perfumes
9. Do not use high or broad beds
10. Do not accept gold or silver

Note:

The last 5 are to be observed by monks. These Percepts do not call for extreme asceticism as in Jainism. The Breach of any of the Percepts had to be confessed at an assembly of ones chapter (religious group).

Lay people could become associates of the monastic order. Such association would promote the ideals of the order. The monks begged for food which they ate communally in the monastery. This life provided an ideal condition for the prescribed regulations and meditation, leading to the middle path and enlightenment.

23.3.3 Sikh Ethical Teachings

Sikhism teaches that one must serve (others) physically, mentally and materially. It teaches that people must work hard to get the best out of the their physical work and later they should not only teach others about God, but also help those in need. They are to pray for one another and also give 10% of their income to charity (the poor, hospital or community work).

Commandments in Sikhism

Guru Nanak taught the following 11 commandments

1. Worship the one invisible God
2. Work hard and help others
3. Be honest and Truthful
4. All men are equal – no poor nor rich (white or black)
- 5 Men and women are equal before God
- 6 Love everyone and pray for their good
- 7 Be kind to all living things
- 8 Do not fear and do not be frighten anyone
- 9 Do not lie (always speak the truth)
- 10 Be simple in your food, dress and habits

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11 Appreciate what God has given you.

In addition to the eleven commandments there are laws written in the Sikh scriptures. These condemn idol worship, caste system, the belief in magic and ancestor worship. They also forbid intoxicants and stimulants such as alcohol, tobacco or drugs; gambling, stealing, adultery and cutting of hair.

23.3.4 Moral Philosophy in Confucianism

The focus in Confucianism is morality rather than a supernatural being. One of Confucius books, **Chung Yung**, was the basis of Confucian moral philosophy. In the book, Confucius emphasized the ethical meaning of relationships. He advocated order and harmony between persons of all social classes and ages. He developed the golden rule that “you should not do to others what you don’t wish them to do to you”. This rule is expanded in his Five Virtues as follows:

1. **Right attitude:** One should have good conduct to be in harmony with each other.
2. **Right procedure:** One should choose the right way to behave and relate with others.
3. **Right knowledge:** One should know and practice the right habits i.e. the correct moral principles.
4. **Right moral courage.** One should develop the right morals. He/she should remain royal and charitable towards his neighbours. He/she must contribute towards the social well being of other people. People should set good moral examples to others and be kind to every one.
5. **Right persistence:** One must know their duty and perform them as expected by the community. They must do the right thing at the right time and must be in harmony with each other and with the universe.

They believe that all these virtues are achievable because everyone has a seed of goodness in himself; and which he can develop to create total harmony in the universe. But people have to be self disciplined, kind to others, and do good things to others.

Confucius identified 10 basic relationships between:

- a) Husband and wife;
- b) Parents and children;
- c) Old and young;
- d) Ruler and subject and
- e) Friend and Friend.

If harmony is to exist, then all these people must be virtuous to each other and everyone should play their roles positively. There must be respect between parents and children, rulers and subjects, old and young and between friends. Confucius encouraged personal conduct, respect to superiors, justice and benevolent to all people. He taught that sons must care for their parents and that one cannot love everybody. In essence one should love and do good to his family members relatives, neighbours and friends.

23.3.5 The Ten Commandments in Judaism and Christianity

In Judaism are the Ten Commandments plus as many as over 600 other rules and regulations. These rules or laws, usually found in the Torah or Mosaic law, forms the framework for living for every Jew. It covers the entire aspects of Jewish life such as offering of sacrifices, keeping

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of feasts, matters of marriage, administration of justice, punishments and rewards among other issues.

The Ten Commandments which are also adopted word for word by Christianity forbid idol worship, killing, adultery, stealing, cheating, falsehood, and covetousness. The Christians are expected to worship on Sundays and respect parents. Besides these commandments Christianity has one major additional law which is based on love for God and ones neighbour.

23.3.6 The 4 Noble Truths in Buddhist

Buddhism advocate the **middle-path** i.e. avoiding pleasure and extreme ascetism. This middle path is summarized in what is called the **4 Noble Truths**, which call for doing the right things, justice and peace as shown below.

1. That suffering is a universal fact i.e. misery, distress, despair etc are part of human existence- common experience.
2. That suffering is caused by desire for self satisfaction i.e. the ceaseless striving for pleasures that give satisfaction for only a short while but leads to more desires. Out of ignorance and endless desires, people look for satisfaction in the wrong things, leading to more desires, evil and suffering.
3. That there is a state in which complete freedom from suffering and bondage is attained. This is a state of complete joy and peace, Nirvana.
4. The forth noble truth teaches the way that leads to Nirvana. This is called the **Eight Fold Path** or the middle path between the extremes of self indulgence in pleasure and self torture. The Noble Eight fold path has 3 categories i.e. morality, concentration and wisdom as shown below.

a) Morality

1. Right speech – avoidance of evil language.
2. Right action – abstainance from killing, stealing, sexual and other immoralities.
3. Right livelihood- avoidance of human exploitation/oppression.

b) Concentration (Mental)

4. Right efforts – avoid evil thoughts
5. Right mindfulness- paying attention to the right feelings and thoughts.
6. Right concentration- meditations to induce high levels of consciousness.

c) Wisdom

7. The right views- understanding of the 4 noble truths.
8. Right thoughts – Freedom from ill will, lust, cruelty and unfaithfulness.

The Eight Fold Noble Truth recommends personal efforts towards doing the right things. Such efforts would lead to serenity (peace), knowledge, and enlightenment that leads to Nirvana, a state of perfect peace and bliss (complete happiness).

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23.3.7 Moksha in Jainism

The Jain teachings reject any other method of salvation such as through priests or rituals or reading sacred scriptures. Salvation to them is reached by release or **Moksha**, from the cycle of rebirth. This is achieved through having three things referred to as **three Jewels**. These are:

- a) **Right faith:** Unshaken faith, which is a prerequisite for salvation.
- b) **Right knowledge:** True understanding of the principle and doctrines taught by the religion.
- c) **Right conduct:** Life must be lived in accordance with certain religious principles.

Right conduct involves strict observance of prescribed rules of conduct, which are summed up in four great vows taken by monks. These are as follows:

1. The first vow requires the believers to observe **Ahimsa**: This means renouncing killing or injuring of living beings. It pledges never to cause others to kill or injure, nor to consent to any killing or injury. One must hence avoid anything that would cause quarrels, pain or injury to others. They must also respect food before eating to avoid hunting, injury or killing one or any other thing. The second vow binds the Jain never to lie at all; nor to cause others to lie or to consent to another lying.
2. The third vow binds the Jain never to take, nor consent to taking of anything without permission. This condemns dishonest or unlawful acquisition of wealth stealing or greed.
3. The fourth vow renounces all sexual pleasure. The vow includes pledging not to cause others to engage in sexual moralities and not to consent to them.

Note

For this reason Jains avoid occupations which involve killing e.g. Agriculture, military, Butchery etc.

23.3.8 The Sharia in Islam

The Islamic law, the **Sharia**, meaning a path of conduct regulates personal, family and societal life of the Moslems. It stipulates duties to Allah, the state, neighbours, family and the entire Islamic society. It governs the life of every Moslem and spells out the kind of punishments to be given to offenders.

23.4 Questions

1. Compare the 10 commandments with either the Buddhist Precepts or the Sikh commandments.
2. Examine the contribution of the ethical dimension to social behaviour in any one religion.

23.5 Activity

Visit a church, mosque or temple on a day of worship to interview worshipers on how they safeguard ethics and morality.

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23.6 Summary

The ethical dimension determines the right action, behaviour and relations. It controls the behaviour of individuals and that of the group or community, which lead to what is referred to as ethical action. There is no religion without ethics and morality. Religions, therefore provide a code of ethics, which the believers must follow, e.g. the Ten Commandments, the Five Precepts, the Golden Rule, the Sharia, the Five Noble Truths etc.

23.7 Definition of key words

Sangha: A community of Buddhist monks.

Kshatriya: The royal and warriors caste, the second great caste in Hindu society.

Dharma ; The law or truth as taught by Buddha.

Middle path: Life between pleasure and extreme ascetism, which is advocated by Buddhism.

Moksha: In Hinduism, the general term for release or salvation.

Ahimsa: An Indian term referring to abstention from harming any living creature or vegetation.

23.8 Further Reading

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LESSON 24: MYTHICAL DIMENSION OF RELIGION

24.1 Introduction

In the previous Lesson we discussed the ethical dimension of religion. We found that almost all religions have a code of ethics that seeks to regulate human action or behaviour. Lesson 24 shall focus on the mythical dimension, which is simply the story side of religion.

24.2 Objectives

At the end of the lesson the learner should be able to:

- Examine the role of mythology in religion.
- Give examples of myths from the religions discussed in this module or from other sources.

24.3 Content

24.3.1 General Background

The term **myth** is used in religion simply to denote the story side of religion. Myth in this case does not mean that the content of the story is false. It is simply a story or a report of what is believed by followers of a religious faith. Myths seek to answer questions such as the origin of the universe, the meaning of life, the destiny of the world etc. As used in religion a myth is simply a narrative that builds a worldview. Myths help believers to make sense out of what otherwise would have been impossible to comprehend. They help individuals to create images about the spiritual world. They seek to promote certain religious and social values e.g. the floods in the Bible. Myths help to organize life e.g. the myth of original in Christianity. By them societies are able to know what to believe and how to act.

Myths express collective consciousness and the spiritual heritage of the human community which all individuals share. They express cultural attitudes towards life, death and the universe. Other myths play a spiritual and mystical function by evoking feelings of awe and gratitude, fascination and dread. They elicit experience of mystery and address significant questions e.g. what is the origin and destiny of humanity. Myths present societies with some order e.g. the creation stories in Judaism, Christianity, Shintoism, Islam, and African Religion among others.

Myths could be accounts of historical events e.g. the Exodus story, the Passover ritual and the Mt. Sinai experience in Judaism or about religious founders/figures such as Abraham, Moses, Gautama, Mohammed, Guru Nanak, Lao Tse, Zoroaster, Jesus Christ etc. Such myths surround the birth, life call and death and the after life of religious founders.

Some myths attempt to give meaning to the origin of evil, suffering and death or the separation between God and man e.g. the Garden of Eden, the Bantu myth of separation, the origin of evil in Zoroastrianism etc. Others try to give meaning to rituals e.g. the Lords supper, the Jewish Passover meal, baptism, and so on. There are also myths about the end and the future of the universe e.g. the Messianic hope in Judaism and the Second Advent in Christianity. A few examples are presented in the section below.

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24.3.2 Myths About Religious Figures

a) Gautama Buddha (Buddhism)

Buddha was born miraculously. He was in heaven before his time to be born had come. He then descended to the world and entered the womb of the **Queen Maya** and was born a human being about 563 B.C.E. He was born in a park and was received by gods in a golden net. The boy took seven steps across the world to survey it and cried in the voice of a lion, calling himself the chief of the world. He claimed that existence had come. He was brought up in great pleasure by his aunt after his mother's death.

Gautama was not to have access to or see any signs of suffering e.g. ill-health, old age, poverty and death. In his latter life, Gautama saw the signs of suffering and was greatly disturbed. God appeared to him as a very old man and on another occasion as a miserably sick person. God later appeared as a dead man and Gautama was greatly disturbed by the three instances. He started searching for a solution to these forms of suffering and misery.

Gautama was tempted by the evil spirit, **Mara**, but he overcame all the temptations. He continued searching for enlightenment and liberation for 6 years. It is said that while at the highest state of meditation under a sacred fig tree – called the tree of enlightenment, he attained a perfect heavenly eye, which enabled him to see the whole world. He saw the cause of all suffering and their solutions. He attained a desire-less state or Nirvana. At this point Gautama became a **Buddha**, meaning the enlightened one. He advocated the middle path, denouncing pleasure and extreme asceticism.

b) The Life of Lao Tse (Taoism)

Legend says that Lao Tse the founder of Taoism was born in 604 BC and lived for over 160 years. He spent over 80 years in his mother's womb after a miraculous conception. He was born with a white hair and beard. He was named Lao Tse meaning the old master. He wrote 5000 words about his belief and he disappeared never to be seen again. He never preached and never organized a religious group. Taoism arose from his book, **Dow Deh Jung**, meaning the way and its power or the book of the right way.

c) Jesus of Nazareth (Christianity)

The historical Christ is unknown, but there is no doubt that Christ lived. The date of his birth is not clear, but he is believed to have been born between 6-4BC. He was born miraculously by a virgin girl named Mary who by then was betrothed to Joseph of David's ancestry. The name **Christ** means Messiah in Jewish language while Jesus comes from the Hebrew name, Joshua.

Little is known about the childhood of Christ. But he grew up in Nazareth probably as a carpenter, his father's business. He could read Hebrew, Greek and Aramaic his mother tongue. He was baptized by John at the age of 30 years and soon he started to preach in the Jewish synagogues and in the country side. He performed many healing miracles, exorcised the sick and fed the hungry.

Christ appeared to be a popular teacher who within a short period had a very large following. He however chose a small number of men whom he prepared to take over the community. He was arrested in Jerusalem for what the Roman authorities thought was a demonstration and failure to pay respect to the authorities. He was crucified in public along with two criminals,

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but resurrected three days later after which he went up to heaven. The believers still wait for his second coming to judge the living and the dead.

d) Zoroaster's Prophetic call

He is a historical figure and lived around 6th century BCE. He is said to have received a vision at age 30. The angel of God (**Volm Manah**) appeared to him and took him to the presence of God (**Ahura Mazda**), who purified and appointed him a prophet. He was then given instructions about the doctrines and duties of the true religion. For the next eight years it is said that he continued to have meetings with angels who gave him further instructions. He had about 7 more conferences with Ahura Mazda and was divinely appointed and sent to convert all living men into this true religion about one true God. – Ahura Mazda. The legend continues to say that he was greatly tempted by the evil spirit called **Angry Mainyu**, who wanted him to give up the worship of Ahura Mazda, but he conquered the temptations.

24.3.3 Creation Myths

a) Shinto Myth of Origin

The Shinto stories about creation are found in the sacred scriptures called **Nihongi** (Chronicles of Japan) and **Kojik** (Records of ancient matters). They say that the world was originally divided into two parts heaven and earth. Two spirits, **Izanagi** (male) and **Izanami** (female) made the Island and landed on it. They peopled the Island with **Kami** (spirits of trees, herbs, winds etc). Izanagi, finally died and began to decay so Izanami divorced him. At Hades (the place of the dead), Izanagi washed himself in the sea and from his right eye came the good moon goddess. From his left eye came the sun goddess **Amaterasu** and from his nose came the storm god, **Susanowo**.

The story says that Amaterasu ruled wisely and kindly giving peace, order and protection to the world. Susanowo his brother destroyed her domains and polluted her shrines hence causing evil and suffering. It is also said that he insulted Amaterasu, who decided to withdraw to a heavenly cave leaving total darkness to cover the world. All other gods assembled outside the cave and danced for Amaterasu. She looked outside the cave and saw the reflection of her beautiful face in mirror placed outside the cave. While she tried to reach it, the gods pulled her out and light came back to the world. Hence day and night came to existence.

The gods then cursed Susanowo and threw him down in to a sanctuary on the North coast of Japan. He belongs to the invisible magic world and he is believed to cause pestilence, disaster and suffering. The story continues that Amaterasu later sent his son, **Nimigi** to rule over Japan. He married Mount Fuji and their grandson **Jimmu Teno** became the first emperor of Japan. (Leadership is given divine origin).

b) The Origin of Evil and Suffering in Zoroastrianism

The origin of good and evil in Zoroastrianism is mythically explained in which two rival powers i.e. **Spenta Mainyu** (good spirit) and **Angry Mainyu** (evil spirit) fought. Both spirit originated from Ahura Mazda but one chose to do evil and fell but the other did good and became the holy spirit.

Angry Mainyu is the cause of all evil and suffering. His spirits are busy turning men towards evil by persuading them to leave the true religion of Ahura Mazda. **Spenta Mainyu** on the other hand guides people into doing good. The story says that eventually three saviours will

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come. The last one will finally overcome evil and good will prevail. The dead will resurrect

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and the last judgment will take place on a bridge that separates the hell below for the evil doors and the paradise a place for the good people.

c) Creation Myth in Islam

According to the Koran the universe was created in an orderly manner by God alone. Man was the last to be created. He was created a special being with the faculties of learning, speaking, understanding and freedom to discern right from wrong and good from evil. God then created a mate both of who were to live in the garden that God had planted and to worship Him. Adam and Eve were tempted by Satan and hence sinned but sought forgiveness from God. Thus one is a sinner because he/she has sinned and hence the nature of human beings is to do good. Those who do good will end up in heaven while evil doors will suffer in hell.

The consequence of disobedience is eternal punishment. God will in the end judge the world. God's deeds will be weighed in the scales. The righteous will enter paradise and the evil will be sent to hell. Hell is presented as a place covered with fire, a place of eternal suffering for the wicked. Heaven on the other hand is a place of joy for the righteous. It is presented as a place of cool gardens with fruits and beautiful flowers. The righteous will dress beautifully and eat delicious food and drink wine there.

d) Hindu Myth of origin

The myth states that in the beginning the world was non existence but then it began in form of an egg, which broke open into two equal parts, the earth and the heavens. The thick membrane formed mountains, clouds, and mist while the veins formed rivers and the ocean. The sun the moon and the stars together with humanity and animals were then hatched.

e) Biblical Myth of Creation

The Biblical myth of creation cuts across origin and separation. The myth could be summarized that God spent 6 days creating the universe and everything on it. He also planted a garden which he gave Adam and Eve to care and use. They were to eat fruits from all the plants except fruits from the tree of knowledge of good and evil, a tree which was at the center of the garden.

Adam and Eve were tempted by **Satan**, in the form of a serpent or snake. They disobeyed God by eating fruits from the forbidden tree. Their eyes were opened and they realized their nakedness. They tried to hide away from God but it was not possible. God punished Adam, Eve and the Serpent. This was the beginning of suffering and death. The myth was used by the early Christian to develop the doctrine of the original sin.

24.4. Question

Examine the role of mythology in any one religion?

24.5 Activity

Collect stories about the your family as far back as possible. Find out the similarities and differences between the stories you have collected and the myths we have discussed in this module.

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24.6 Summary

We have noted that myths are common to all religions of the world. Myths are simply the story side of religion and do not imply falsehood. Myths help believers to understand what would have otherwise been difficult to comprehend. They express collective consciousness and the spiritual heritage of the community as well as cultural attitudes towards life death and the universe. Other myths elicit experience of mystery and address significant questions.

Some myths give accounts of historical events while others show the origin of the universe. Stories about the birth or religious founders are also classified as myths. Myths of origin are common to almost all religions , e.g. creation of the universe, origin of humanity, sin, death , suffering etc. Other myths are stories about the birth of religious founders and their call e.g. the birth of Jesus, Gautama Buddha etc. Other recount the life of religious men and women e.g. the stories about Mohammad in the Hadith.

24.7 Definition of key words

Mara: Evil spirit in Buddhism, believed to cause temptations.
Buddha: Name given to Gautama meaning the enlightened one.
Christ : Name given of Jesus, the founder of Christianity. It means Messiah in Jewish Language, while Jesus means Joshua in Hebrew.
Ahura Mazda: Name for God in Zoroastrianism
Mainyu: The name given to either bad or good spirits in Zoroastrianism
Hihongi: Shinto sacred writings.
Kami: Spirits in Shinto Religion.
Satan: The personification of evil and identified with the devil.

Appendix 10.8: Further Readings

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LESSON 25: PRACTICAL AND RITUAL DIMENSION

25.1 Introduction

In the previous lesson we looked at the mythological dimension of religion during which we were able to examine the role of mythology in religion. The mythical dimension as we have seen helps believers to understand the mystery of religion as well as other dimensions. In this Lesson we shall examine the practical and ritual dimension of religion, which is simply the action part of religion.

25.2 Objectives

At the end of the Lesson learners are expected to:

- Give examples of religious rituals and their meaning.
- Compare religious activities across the various religions that have been discussed in this module.

25.3 Content

25.3.1 General Background

Rituals could be defined as symbolic, routine and repetitive activities and actions through which we make connections with what we consider to be the most valuable dimensions of life. They are usually connected with the most important events in our lives. They commemorate significant events of our communities and provide a means for renewing the meaning of these events among us e.g. the Passover ritual celebrated by the Jews or the Eucharist celebration of the Christians. Some rituals express relationships e.g. greetings. Others remind societies about ancestral life e.g. sacrifices or offerings. Some express community life or solidarity e.g. celebrations.

A ritual can be seen as a set of practices through which the participants relate to the sacred. They may also mark social transition, and are called rites of passage. Their importance is not only in what they do to the people but more so in what they say. Religious rituals including forms of worship, prayers, meditation, offerings, singing, reciting creeds, communion, baptism, confession etc. Churches, temples, mosques, shrines and synagogues are the places where religious rituals or ceremonies are performed. These take different shapes as we shall see in the material dimension.

Note:

The ritual dimension is the practical or active aspect of religion. It is usually seen and felt and in most cases its meaning is usually very clear. Most rituals are celebrated.

A ritual has both an inner and an outer meaning/significance e.g. the closing of eyes, clapping of hands, knelling down, greetings etc. They express religious meaning and try to link the visible and the invisible world e.g. libation and meditation. However, the outer aspects of a ritual usually dominates the inner aspects.

Secular rituals such as greetings may also be integrated with religious rituals e.g. greetings such as “may God be with you” invokes God’s blessings upon someone else. In some rituals

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e.g. meditation in which the individual concentrates on a transcendent invisible world,

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individuals experience release from worldly existence to that of ultimate reality. Below are examples of the practical and ritual dimension of religion.

25.3.2 Rituals and Ceremonies

a) Hindu Rites of passage

The Hindu tradition has many customs and rituals connected with birth, marriage and death. They have a strong belief in Astrology e.g. there are specific days for buying and selling; sowing and reaping, marrying etc. In marriage for example, the horoscopes of the bride and bridegroom are carefully studied and the marriage is fixed only if these agree. The marriage may last for several days depending of the caste of the two families. The Hindu value male children more. This is partly attributed to their role in funerals. It is the eldest son who must light the funeral pyre of the dead parent.

Hindu life has 4 basic stages; the students stage, the household stage, the redefined stage and the spiritual stage as shown below.

1. The student stage:

Young men particularly from the upper and middle castes are expected to live for some years with religious tutors to be taught sacred books and the Hindu philosophy. Many questions about life and marriage are addressed during the student phase, and thus the stage is referred to as the second birth.

2. The householder stage:

After the student phase, one is expected to marry and undertake the responsibilities of parenthood. A girl must be over 15 years before she can marry while a boy must be over 18 years. Sex is not allowed before marriage. The girl is, however, chosen by the boy's parents and all other arrangements are done by them. The couple is expected to contribute socially and economically to the well being of the society.

3. The refined stage

After the first grandchild is born a man and his wife are expected to withdraw from daily business and direct family responsibilities. They are expected to go back to learning more about the Hindu religion and its values and also meditation. Family responsibilities are taken over by their children.

4. The spiritual stage

At this stage a man may decide to abandon family life and commit himself to a pilgrim life. He leaves his village and starts to wander from place to place begging food and other basic necessities from villagers. (Like the disciples of Christ). Such people leave behind all they have and start searching for the meaning of life through study, reflection and meditation. This is the highest level of human spirituality.

b) Baptism of the Sword in Sikhism

Baptism by the sword was introduced by a Guru called Govind. In this ritual water is put in a basin, it is then sweetened and stirred with a sword. Five palm-fuls are given to each individual to drink. The remnant is sprinkled on the participants while they recite that " the pure are of God and the victory is to God" These become the pure of the Lord or the elect and they are given the name **Singh** or Lion.

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Sighs are commanded to possess long hair on head and chin and a turban, a comb, short underpants, a steel bracelet and a steel dagger. The hair and the turban are outward signs of maturity and strength, the comb is for keeping the hair clean and tidy, the short underpants symbolizes chastity, the steel bracelet is a symbol of God's omnipresence and the steel dagger is a symbol of resistance to evil.

c) The Tower of Silence in Zoroastrianism

Zoroastrians have a unique way of disposing the dead. The corpses are not buried nor cremated as this would desecrate the earth, which to them is holy. They are, therefore, placed on high slabs called the **Tower of silence** from where vultures lick them clean and the bones drop down.

25.3.3 Pilgrimages

a) Hindu Pilgrimages

India has many pilgrimage centers some of which have mythical origins. They may be attributed to gods or goddesses, while others may be associated with sacred trees, rivers, or hills, e.g. the sources of river Gauges a famous center for pilgrimage. Some towns are considered to be holy and may become centers of pilgrimage. Pilgrimages are done all year round and people of all ages are expected to participate.

b) Pilgrimages in Buddhism

Buddhists are encouraged to make many pilgrimages to sacred places. The more the pilgrimages the greater the individual's merit. Buddhists have four main sacred places to be visited: viz. Buddha's birth place, the place of his enlightenment, the place he preached his first sermon, and the place he passed away into Nirvana. Whoever dies while wondering in pilgrimage in these places will in the end enter a peaceful world. This belief inspires millions of Buddhists to risk their lives, and to spend a lot of money and time traveling to worship in these sacred places.

In addition to the 4 sacred places, attributed to Buddha's (own) life, Buddhists have sacred hills such as Adams Peak in Sri Lanka, on which Buddha's footprint is seen. Thousands of Buddhists climb the mountain each pilgrimage season carrying various offerings. Hindus, Christians and Islam also go on pilgrimage in the same hill.

Pilgrimage in Islam

Muslims worship Allah through what they call **Five Pillars**. These include the Shahada or the Muslim creed, **salat** or prayer, fasting, sharing and pilgrimage. Pilgrimage brings together all Islamic sects, all classes of people and all races to the sacred shrines. The pilgrims are required to put off worldly concerns in order to commune with Allah. All Muslims are expected to visit Mecca at least once in a lifetime for 8 days each visit.

On the first day pilgrims walk seven times around the **Kabah**, in which the black stone is kept. The stone is venerated but not worshiped. In the neighbourhood of the Kabah is a well from where sacred water flows. Muslims drink water from the well and take some home. Pilgrims are required to abstain from sex among other acts. Animal sacrifice marks the end of the pilgrimage. Part of the meat is eaten by the pilgrims and the rest is given to the poor.

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Note

The role of abstaining from sex in preparation for prayers or worship is common to many religions of the world, perhaps implying that sex has an element of evil.. This led to celibate life in the early church

25.4 Question

Identify religious activities or practices that are common to most of the religions discussed in this module.

25.6 Activity

Visit a place of worship other than your own during worship to observe and record religious activities. Find their meaning from the worshipers.

25.7 Summary

We have noted that believers are the main actors in their religions, and that some of the religious acts have inner meaning and are referred to as rituals. Such practices help the believers to relate with the sacred or the divine. Some of the common religious activities include pilgrimages, worship, celebrations, prayers etc. Some of these are social while others could be private or both. Some practices are required while some others are opposed

25.7 Definition of key words

Ritual: Patterned behaviour, often communal, consisting of prescribed actions performed periodically and or repetitively.

Salat: Islamic ritual prayer which is carried out five times a day, facing Mecca and using ritual movements to accompany the words. It is one of the five pillars of Islam

Singh: The pure or elect in Sikh religion.

Kabah: The sanctuary in Mecca to which all Moslems turn in prayer and inside which is kept the black stone which is believed to have dropped from heaven and which is venerated by pilgrims.

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25.8 Further Readings

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LESSON 26: WAYS OF WORSHIP AND OFFERING

26.1 Introduction

In the previous lesson we looked at the practical and ritual dimension of religion. This Lesson will continue to discuss the same dimension, putting more attention to worship and offering.

26.2 Objective

At the end of this lesson learners are expected to be familiar with ways and places of worship and offering in various religions.

26.3 Content

26.3.1 Ways of Worship

a) Buddhist Worship

Buddhists worship the remains of Gautama Buddha and those of his disciples. The bones of these people are mould into huge figures called **stupas**, which are kept in temples. The stupas are worshipped as people enter the temple by squatting, kneeling or standing. The images of Gautama Buddha are placed in temples and homes for worship. These images are believed to be a source of blessing and magical protection to the worshippers.

The tree under which Gautama received enlightenment is also worshiped. This is called the cult of the **Bodhi tree**. It is believed that Gautama himself paid respect to the tree and he later commanded its worship. There is a myth that Gautama spent one week standing in front of the tree gazing with unblinking eyes full of respect and love. To some Buddhists, the tree is a god.

Prayers

Buddhists give offerings at all places of worship. They include flowers, Lamps candles, incense, food, drinks etc. They also offer prayers and invocations for human needs and material blessing. In prayers, they ask for rain, good harvest, long life, good leadership, prosperity and also wisdom. Some of the prayers are addressed directly to Buddha as the highest of all creatures. But most of the prayers are addressed to God particularly when they ask for forgiveness of sins.

Offerings

Buddhists make offerings for (both) the dead as well as the living relatives and friends. Such offering are usually accompanied by prayers e.g. may these gifts of mine be credited to my relatives, to my mother and father. The merit gained through offerings could also be transferred to the dead.

b) Hindu Worship

Hindu worship in homes and Temples. Most families, particularly the upper and middle classes, have a room in their houses set for worship. Each family has also a particular god or goddess and the image is placed in the room to be worshiped.

Worship is more individualistic than institutional. Prayers often consist in the recitation of **mantras** or sacred verses, some of which are made up of names of god and goddesses. They light lamps and burn incense. The family gods and goddesses seem closer to men than

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Brahman. The images of these gods and goddesses are fed, dressed and cared for. Rituals, hymns and prayers are conducted.

Temple worship is also popular with Hinduism. In India for example, magnificent temples are found in cities and villages. Each temple is dedicated to a particular deity and an image of the deity is usually displayed inside. Worship centers around the image of the god or goddess. The temple priest washes, dresses and feeds the image of the deity. Worshipers move silently about, saying prayers and making their offerings. They may at times process round the image of the god or goddess.

c) Sikh Worship

Worshipers take off their shoes and bow as they enter the temple. No candles, incense, statues, tobacco or alcohol are allowed inside. As they enter, worshipers give offerings in form of food, money or a piece of silk material for covering the **Granth**. Unless it is being used the Granth must remain covered and flies must be chased away from it. The Granth may be read either by a man or a woman. The reader must carry it on his/her head to the place of reading.

While worshipping, the holy congregation called **Sangat** sit cross-legged on the floor. Men sit on one side and women on the opposite. This practice is common to Islam and Judaism. The Sikh will sit behind the Granth facing the Sangat. Singing is part of worship and usually follows the sermon. A common prayer is said by a Sikh and has 3 main divisions. The first division concerns the remembrance of the 10 Gurus, the second one concerns the keeping of the Granth's teaching, and lastly asking God for blessing for all special cases e.g. wedding, the sick and the dead.

The Sikh have no priests, all are equal. At the end of the worship all share a common meal of flour, butter and sugar. It is consecrated by a prayer and signifies God's kindness to mankind. The meal brings them together and breaks down any differences. This practice is also common to Christians and goes back to the time of Christ.

d) Shinto Worship

A Shinto believer must first be cleansed before visiting a shrine. Troughs of water are erected in all public shrines from which worshipers wash their hands and mouth to symbolize (inner) purity. Shrines are also found in homes, they are the center of worship for the family. They have a god-shelf within which the tablet containing names of gods is kept, but no images are kept.

Public worship is done in shrines dedicated to various gods and goddesses. They wash their hands and mouths, remove shoes, and enter the shrine where they pray and offer money, rice and flowers and burn candles. Shinto priests live a normal life and usually lead official services on important religious days. They also protect (the) shrines. They have other occupations besides priesthood.

e) Ancestor Worship in Confucianism

Ancestor worship is a common phenomenon in Chinese religion. This is partly due to the respect given to elders and forefathers as well as the belief that ancestors continue to live in the community. Like in Shintoism, ancestor worship centers about the **tablet** within which the names of ancestors are written. Each family has its own tablet, which goes back for about 4 generations. Food is offered, incense and candles are burned and flowers are kept before the

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tablet. Worshipers bow before the tablet asking for blessing.

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Offerings are also made on the anniversary of the birth and death of ancestors and also on the first and last days of the year. The two days unite the living and the dead and, therefore, family members must gather together.

Note

Prayers and offerings for the dead are found in many religions e.g. Christianity, Sikhism and Buddhism. However, similar prayers in African Religion are usually condemned by Christianity.

f) Fire Worship in Zoroastrianism

Fire worship was, traditionally practiced by the Persian people to please their gods. The fire is lit ceremoniously. Usually grass is placed at the altar and sprinkled with juice. The animal to be sacrificed is purified using the same leaves. The sacrificial animal is then killed and burned in the fire for gods. The sacred fire is usually kept a light throughout the night. Worshipers must bring offerings to the place of worship called **Mithra** and receive ashes from the sacred fire to protect them from evil.

g) Jewish Worship

The Jewish worship either individually or communally. Collective prayers are usually held in the Synagogue. The Jews have particular times and days laid down in the Torah for worship e.g. the Sabbath, Passover etc. The Jews have two main services each week, on Friday evening and on Saturday morning or Sabbath.

Jewish worship is usually in a Synagogue within which is placed the Ark of the Covenant. Traditionally, women were never allowed inside the synagogue but today they have places reserved for them. They do not mix with the men. The Ark, which contains the Torah book, is draped by a curtain in front of which hangs an ever-lighting lamp. A reading desk is placed in front of the Ark.

A synagogue is usually headed by a Rabbi, who is both a leader and a lawyer. He may not be the only leader in the temple. Usually the leader is the chief officer at the synagogue worship service. In the synagogue, the reader, in a black robe and hat, opens by a prayer of praise to invoke God's blessing. All other prayers are said in Hebrew although an English translation may also be given.

The Ark of the covenant is opened and the Torah book is carried round the synagogue in procession. The people must bow while the Torah is carried (passed them) to the reading desk. The daily lesson is read, followed by another reading from the law and then a reading from the prophets. The Torah is then rolled up, veiled and returned into the Ark. A short teaching follows, then traditional hymns, prayers and blessings and the congregation may disperse. In some occasions, a cup of wine and some loaves of bread are blessed and eaten by the congregation.

At the Passover feast, candles are lit and wine is drunk. Some of the foods taken include unleavened cakes, eggs, mutton, nuts, and bitter herbs. This commemorates their bondage in

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Egypt. Hymns are sung and a special cup is set aside for Elijah incase he comes to announce the day of the Lord.

h) Christian Worship

Christians worship in Churches as congregations or a communion of believers although this is not a must. Most of them worship on Sunday and they are usually led by a priest or pastor. During worship they recite creeds, pray, sing, dance, give offerings and celebrate the Eucharist. Some Christian groups or denominations perform some of these rituals but not all. The style of worship also differs from denomination to denomination. Places of worship also differ according to shape, size, use and other aspects. Christians have many rituals, but the commonest of all is **baptism** during which believers take Christian names.

Preaching of the word of God from the Bible is common during worship. Christians are required to attend Sunday worship, which is normally held in a church building. Hymns are also sung, the Eucharist is celebrated by some denominations in form of bread and wine. The believers also give offerings in material things especially money.

26.3.2 Festivals

a) Christian Festival

Christians observe many festivals but again this varies from congregation to congregation. The common festivals are:

1. Christmas: This occurs on 25th of December to commemorate the birth of Jesus Christ, the founder of Christianity.
2. Easter : This marks the death and resurrection of Jesus Christ. It marks the beginning of Christianity or simply salvation history. Some of the believers start to prepare for the feast through fasting and prayer 40 days before.
3. Pentecost : A feast though not of same importance as the ones given above, which occurs 50 days after Easter. It marks the descending of the Holy Spirit upon the followers of Jesus, the Apostles and the beginning of the church.

Christians have many rituals but the common ones are referred to as **Sacraments**, which is derived from a Latin word, **Scramentum**, meaning a holy thing. The common sacraments include baptism, Eucharist, Marriage and ordination. As we have said Baptism marks the beginning of Christian life and as such, it is the most foundational sacraments without which one would not be regarded as a Christian. The Eucharist is celebrated during worship to commemorate the Lords supper, a story told in the Bible. The sacrament of matrimony makes marriage a permanent sacrament. It permits sexual union and procreation. Ordination dedicates men and women to the service of God. It is a very prestigious calling although it has some sacrifices. There are other sacraments that are not common to all denominations.

b) Hindu Festivals

The Hindu celebrate many festivals, some at home and others in the temple. They have no fixed day of the week for worship and other religious duties. Many of the annual festivals have to do with the worship of gods and goddesses. Others cerebrate mythical events while others are related to social life. Some festivals are connected with naming, marriage and funerals. Such festivals are referred to as rites of passage. Some are national festivals e.g. **Diwali** (festival of lights), which commemorates the destruction of a demon king by Krishna.

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Other festivals have to do with seasons e.g. harvest festivals. Some festivals mark or

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commemorate acts of liberation by gods and goddesses. All these festivals are marked by colourful processions and dances.

c) Buddhist Ceremonies and Festivals

Buddhists have many ceremonies and festivals. The most important ceremony is called **Pirit**, which is supposed to send away demons or evil spirits and call upon blessing and protection. In this ceremony, a thread is held by the worshipers while squatting. A new pot full of water is placed in their midst and the thread is tied round its neck. The congregation then chants selected sacred texts from the Buddhist scriptures. After this the thread is broken into pieces and tied round the wrist and neck of those assembled. The water is then sprinkled on all participants. This ceremony is also held on other occasions such as the inauguration of a new house, the starting of a journey or the opening of a new business.

Buddhists also celebrate another festival known as **Vesak**. This is the name given to the full moon day in the month of May. It is the most sacred day for Buddhists. It is believed to be the day Gautama was born and the day he attained enlightenment. He is also said to have died on this day. During the celebrations all temples, houses and streets are decorated and illuminated. Devotees, men, women and children alike crowd the temples and halls to perform religious rites. They observe the precepts, meditate and listen to teachings; and exchange greetings.

d) Jewish Festivals

The Jews have many festivals some of which are discussed below.

1. **The Sabbath:** The Sabbath begins on Friday evening. It is a day of worship and rest. On this day Jews assemble in the synagogues for worship. The climax is usually sharing a meal at their homes. The next day the whole family must attend service in the synagogue. Men sit on one side and women sit on a special gallery. The service usually includes chanting of portions of the Torah, and Psalms, prayers and a sermon by the Rabbi. Jews are allowed to do only the very necessary work after the service. This day of worship and rest has been taken up by other religions e.g. Christians and Muslims although different days have been chosen.
2. **The New Year (Rosh Hashonah)**
The date varies from September-October since the Jewish Calendar is based on the movement of the moon. The day is marked by the blowing of horns. It commemorates the day of the world's creation and is also the day of judgment. It marks the birthday of religious figures such as Adam, Abraham, Isaac and Jacob. For 10 days since the onset of the new year, Jews consider their failures during the past year and pray for forgiveness. This period is called Ten penitential days. (sorrowful days).
3. **The Day of Atonement: (Yom Kippur).**
This comes 10 days after the New Year. It is the holiest day of the New Year and all must fast except the sick and children below 13 years. It is a day of repentance and means "at-one-ment with God". Traditionally Jews neither ate nor drank during this day. They have a solemn service in the synagogue which has to be attended by every Jew. This is a day of reflection and prayer during which Jews re-examine their behaviour during the previous year, particularly their relationships with God and with each other. The horn called **Shofar** is sounded to mark the end of the day.

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4. The Feast of Tabernacles: (Sukkoth)

This comes at the time of every harvest and lasts for about 9 days. It is a thanks giving festival. It reminds the Jews of their liberation from the Egyptians bondage and the Exodus experience. It is also a day to mark God's generosity through out their history. It reminds them of the days they lived in poor shelters or huts called Sukkoth or tabernacles in wilderness. On the 9th day of the Sukkoth, there is a joyful ceremony in the synagogue. There are processions of joy songs and dances. Some verses of the Torah are read.

5. The Feast of Lights (Hanukkah)

This festival fall in December and lasts for 8 days. It commemorates the Jewish struggle for religious freedom. (Ref. Maccabees 4:36-59). Jews burn candles during this feast to signify joy. They praise the Lord for the freedom of worship accorded to them and their victory throughout history.

6. Feast of Esther (Purim)

This commemorates the deliverance of the Jews from the Parsian plan to exterminate them. The story is told in the book of Esther that the Jews were accused by Haman of being disloyal to the Parsian emperor. Esther, the Queen, exposed the plan to the king and Haman was punished.

7. The Passover (Pesach) or Unleavened Bread.

This is an eighth day spring-Festival to mark the deliverance of the Israelites from Egyptian Slavery. They are reminded of the mighty hand of the Lord that killed all the first born in Egypt both men and animals and spared the Jews.

During this feast all leaven is removed from the Jewish homes for eight days. They eat unleavened bread to remind themselves of the suffering of their ancestors in Egypt. They also eat bitter herbs and other symbolic food.

8. The feast of Pentecost (Shavuoth) or Feast of Weeks.

This is held seven weeks after the Passover feast and marks the giving of the 10 commandments and stresses the observance of the Law, moral and social order. Children who have complete instructions on the law are confirmed on this feast.

26. 4 Question

What are the common ways of worship found in the religions discussed in this module?

26.5 Activity

Visit a place of worship on a day of worship to observe ways of worship, participates, offerings and celebrations.

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26.6 Summary

We have noted in this lesson that worship is among the most important religious rite and, therefore, common to all religions. We noted that different religions emphasize different aspects of worship. Some religions worship in special buildings while others this is not necessary. Some will emphasize prayer while others underline offerings yet others will emphasize both. Prayers differ from religion to religion and so do offerings. However the intentions are more or less similar. We also observed that religions have ceremonies and festivals. These are times of celebration when the social dimension of religion is indeed realized. In most cases, worship, offerings and religious ceremonies and festivals are led by religious leaders who must have gone through certain rites of passage. Such men and women are not only respected but also revered by their respective congregations.

26.7 Definition of key words

Stupa: A dome or tumulus of masonry, erected for the preservation of Buddhist and Jain sacred relics.

Mantra: A mystical verse of Indian scripture, or one having some special significance e.g. during initiation. It could also mean an incantation, charm, spell or chant.

Granth: The holy scripture of the Sikh, which is treated as the spiritual leader and usually venerated.

Torah: The first five books of the Old Testament also referred to as the Pentateuch. The term is also used to refer to the Jewish law.

Ark of the Covenant : Israelite religious artifact made of wood but coated with gold , which was carried in the wonderland as evidence of the presence of God.

Sacraments: A holy ordinance that is an outward and visible sign of an inward and spiritual grace such as baptism, ordination, communion etc.

Divali: Hindu feast of lamps observed between September and October to honour goddesses.

Pirit: A Buddhist ceremony to sent away demons or evil spirits.

Vasek: Buddhist festival to celebrate the birth of Gautama.

Sabbath: The seventh day of the week, Saturday, on which Jews are required to worship and refrain from hard labour.

Rabbi: Jewish religious teacher and interpreter of the Torah or the law.

26.8 Further Readings

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LESSON 27: EXPERIENCIAL AND EMOTIONAL DIMENSION

27.1 Introduction

In the previous lesson we looked at worship and we were able to discover its importance. We found that almost all religions have some form of worship. Indeed worship appears to be the main focus in most religions. This lesson is going to introduce learners to the experiential and emotional dimension of religion, which is closely related to the practical dimension.

27.2 Objectives

By the end of this lesson learners should be able to:

- Give examples of the experiential and emotional dimension of religion.
- Establish or show the contribution of the experiential and emotional dimension of religion to human growth and development.

27.3 Content

General Discussion

Without the experiential dimension ritual may have little meaning since the essence of religion is hope for the realization of a better life here on earth and or in a future mystical world. The Buddhist, for example, hopes for Nirvana while the Christians hope to rest in heaven. The Hindu hope for the liberation of the soul from the material world, while Zoroastrianism teach of final victory which must be experienced in the material world as well as in the future world or reality.

There exists, therefore, in every heart the struggle between good and evil, truth and falsehood or corruption and justice. This struggle, whether physical, emotional or psychological, is motivated by fear of the unknown supernatural world, and it is usually addressed by religion.

The experiential dimension may be expressed in prayer, where the participants strongly believe that such prayers will research to the supernatural being and will, therefore, be answered. Through them believers express their personal and or collective needs such as the need for food, security, rains, health, life, children, peace etc. It is on the basis of this that sins are confessed. Faith healing is also practiced on the basis of this dimension.

The emotional dimension would also be found in conversion instances, for example in Christianity where Christ seems to be personalized. Here believers deny their human nature and want to be closer to Christ if not like him. This dimension motivates Rudolf Hotto to define religion as “a mysterious experience that draws one close to it and yet brings fear or awe or reverence” to the participant. This kind of experience can only be understood by the self alone.

If we consider the historical background in which the major religions were founded, the experiential dimension would come out clearly. For example in Judaism, Moses encounters God on Mt. Sinai where he receives the Ten Commandments. In Sikhism, Guru Nanak, its founder is said to have encountered God in a forest where he was fed with honey. Zoroaster, the founder of Zoroastrianism, was taken to God by angels for purification and appointment

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purposes. The baptism of Jesus tells more about his encounter with his father while the conversion of Paul just like that of Mohammad are also experiences of divine will.

The emotional dimension handles the most irrational human experiences which pure and social sciences are unable to deal with. It enable the believers to experience the presence of a strange, mysterious or occult power or force, e.g. the Pentecost experience in Christianity, or even magic in African Religion. The emotional and experiential dimension is usually handled by special people who are ordained, consecrated or appointed the believers or God himself as a link between the individual or the congregation and the supernatural power, e.g. prophets, diviners, priests, pastors, etc. Religions have also special places where believers receive religious experience.

27.4 Question

Show the practice and importance of the experiential dimension of religion.

27.5 Activity

Visit a place of worship to observe and record the experiential and emotional dimension of religion.

27.6 Summary

We have noted that almost all religions express some overwhelming experience the founders of religions and the believers claim to have about the supernatural reality. Such experiences are said to be full of awe (fear) and devotion and yet very crucial as far as the management of emotional and other needs are concerned. They express the supernatural reality of religion. The experiential and emotional dimension helps individuals to build hope during times of misery or hopelessness. It employs not only special people but also special Language, rituals, places, things etc. The dimension calls for renewal or rebirth, confession, forgiveness, love etc. It is the deepest level of religious experience, hence the foundation of religious life. It helps human beings to have an encounter with the supernatural reality and be able to manage crises.

27.7 Further Reading

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LESSON 28: SOCIAL AND INSTITUTIONAL DIMENSION

28.1 Introduction

In the previous lesson we discussed the experiential and emotional dimension, which we found to be the foundation of religious life and hence one of the most important dimensions of religion. This lesson will look at the social and institutional dimension of religion with a view to examining its contribution.

28.2 Objectives

By the end of this lesson the learners are expected to:

- Be able to identify the social and institutional dimension of religion.
- Show the contribution of the social and institution dimension of religion to society.

28.3 Content

General Discussion

Religions are not just rituals or doctrines or laws. They are also social organizations or communities of believers who adhere to certain common beliefs and practices and who are to some extent shaped or influenced by them. In other words every religion is embodied in a group of people who usually take the shape of a formal organization, such as church (Christians) or **Sangat** (Sikhism) or **Umma** (Islam). In some cases it would be difficult to draw a dividing line between what is religious and what is social. Religion in this case becomes a way of life or a social activity.

Like any other formal group, religions have leaders and subjects. Such leaders, who sometimes overshadow the laity, set up goals and organize the followers in such a way as to be able to meet the set goals. In most religions, roles are defined so as to facilitate harmonious relationships. Unlike in other formal organizations, a religious institution sees itself as a family where religious interaction is limited to the faithful of that religion and where each one becomes an inspiration to each other e.g. the Islamic Umma, or brethren in Christianity. Those who do not belong to ones religion are regarded as outsiders and sometimes as enemies, e.g. Christians call non believers pagans.

It should however be noted that the social dimension of religion is sometimes interfered with by religious divisions from within. However, as long as the dimension of worship will continue to be embraced by the adherents the social dimension of religion will remain and important one.

28.4 Question

Giving examples show the role of the Social and institutional dimension of religion.

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28.5 Activity

Visit a religious group to observe the social activities they are usually involved in. Interview the members to find out how their religion assists them to meet their needs.

28.6 Summary

We have found that religions are more than beliefs and rituals. They are also organizations, sects or groups of believers with specific targets or goals. As such they have social and communal significance and they influence the community just as they are influenced by the same. They have leaders who are appointed either officially or by God to lead the group.

28.7 Definition of key words

Sangat : A community of Buddhist monks whose origin is Buddha's first disciples.

Umma : The Moslem community, those who have received God's revelation through Mohammad.

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LESSON 29: MATERIAL DIMENSION OF RELIGION

29.1 Introduction

In the previous lesson we looked at the social and institutional dimension of religion and we were able to identify the social significance of religion particularly to the believers. However it should be noted that this dimension would have little meaning without the material dimension, which this lesson is going to explore.

29.2 Objectives

By the end of this lesson the learners are expected to:

- Be able to identify the material dimension of religion.
- Show the significance of the material dimension in religion.

29.3 Content

General Discussion

The social or institutional dimension becomes incarnate in material form as building, or work of art e.g. churches, mosques, temples, synagogues etc. These take different shapes and sizes, and are usually sacred. Some religions adore images of gods in form of sculpture, e.g. Hinduism, or in form of natural things e.g. trees, stones, mountains, animals etc. Others have portraits of ancestors e.g. Christianity, while in some other religions, e.g. Buddhism relics are adored.

Natural features are also used to express religiosity, e.g. rivers such as Jordan, Nile, or mountains such as Sinai, Fuji (Japan), Olives, etc. Trees, rocks, caves and above all the solar system have also been used to express religiosity especially in ancient religions.

Some places or towns are also given religious values, e.g. Mecca, Medina, Rome, Jerusalem, Alexandria etc. Such places are centers of religious pilgrimages and believers have to visit them every year e.g. Mecca. Other materials are used in worship and sacrifices, e.g. food, water, wine, beer, cloths, money, ornaments, animals, human beings, books, wood, stones etc. All these are part of the material dimension of religion. A few examples are discussed below.

a) Jain Temples

Jain temples are quite magnificent. Images of great saints are placed inside the temples. Worship is usually offered by priests and includes cleaning of these images and offering of food to them. Individuals repeat a **Mantra** (sacred text) and mention 5 saintly beings while telling prayer beads. These prayers are said early in the morning and in the evening before going to bed. The lay adherents assist in temple worship and in reading sacred Jain texts.

b) Sikh Temple

The Sikh worship in temples called **gurdwaras**. However, any building containing the Granth becomes a gurdwaras. The Granth is usually placed on a raised platform called **Takht**, literary meaning a throne. On top of a Sikh temple is a flag with two swords and a circle uniting the Sikh and God. The temple or gurdwaras is usually decorated with light. The most important temple is the Golden Temple in Punjab. Its upper part is covered with pure gold. A Sikh temple has 4 doors showing that it is open to everyone.

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c) Church Building

Church buildings take different shapes, sizes and designs. However, most of them take the shape of the crucifix, while others are cyclic, yet others assume a rectangular shape. In size they range from small buildings made of poor materials to magnificent large buildings made of stone, concrete and marble. Usually such buildings are decorated in all manner of ways. The inside of church buildings also differ according to sitting capacities, designs, painting, arrangement, ventilation etc. However they have some common features.

Churches are mainly used for worship and prayer. But they could also be used for other social functions such as wedding, baptism, ordination, burial, entertainment, singing etc. To some Christians, the church is the house of God, while to others it is a place of worship. In most cases therefore, the church is a holy place and believers are required to respect such places. The common signs used for marking churches is the crucifix, which is usually fixed on top of the roof or on the tower.

d) Mosque

Moslems usually worship in the mosque although they are also allowed to worship in any other clean place. Mosques, like churches, are of different sizes. They, however, have a cloister surrounding a central square, which is open to the sky. In the wall facing Mecca is the **Mihrab** or niche to show the worshipers which way to face while in prayer. Near the Mihrab is the pulpit from which Friday prayers are delivered by the religious leader. Some of the chief mosques are: the sacred mosque at Mecca, which contains the Kaaba and the prophet's mosque at Medina, which contains the prophet's tomb. Mosques do not contain pews as worship usually involves standing up, kneeling down and bowing.

e) Synagogues

This is a building used by the Jews for worship, common prayer and public instructions. The synagogue became popular after the destruction of the Temple of Jerusalem. Synagogues are built in such a way that the worshipers face Jerusalem. Inside is the Ark in which the scrolls are kept. It has also a pulpit, candle-stick, and reading desk among other things. Men have to wear hats while praying. Women do not participate fully in worship, they seat separated from the men. Collective worship is done on Friday evening and Saturday.

f) Temple

A temple is an edifice erected to a deity for religious purpose, particularly sacrifice e.g. the temple of Jerusalem or the temples of India believed to be the dwelling places for gods. Like churches, temples take different shapes and sizes depending on the religion and are also for various purposes.

29.4 Question

Outline the use of the material dimension of religion.

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29.5 Activity

Visit a religious building e.g. church, mosque or temple to identify the materials used in worship.

29.6 Summary

We have noted that the material dimension is common to most if not all religions. It is about the things and the places that are used in worship. As such it is almost impossible to have religion, which does not have the material dimension as the worshipers must use things such as sacred books, buildings, offerings, vestments etc. The material dimension enables people to participate in religious events, and without it the social and ritual dimension might be impossible. The dimension provides religions with the materials necessary for worship and prayer.

29.7 Definition of key words

Mantra: Portion of the vedic literature or Hindu scripture; a hymn of praise or a text used as an incantation.

Guardwara: Sikh temple and meeting place, consisting of a worship area.

Takhti: A seat of temporal authority in Sikhism.

Mihrab: Semi circular recess in the wall of a mosque which indicates the direction of the holy city, Mecca.

29.8 Further Reading

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LESSON 30: INTERFAITH DIALOGUE

30.1 Introduction

In the previous lesson we have discussed the material dimension of religion. This lesson will discuss interfaith dialogue with a view to examining how religions could commune.

30.2 Objectives

By the end of this lesson learners are expected to:

- Show the meaning and approaches used in dialogue.
- Identify difficulties faced in the promotion of interfaith dialogue.

30.3 Content

a) Meaning and Approaches to Dialogue

According to Knitter, dialogue urges people of different faiths to seek to understand and speak with each other on the basis of a common commitment to human and ecological well-being. It assumes that religions have a global responsibility towards each other and therefore, cannot function in isolation of each other. Dialogue creates awareness that religions pursue the same or similar goals differently and therefore the success/ effectiveness of a religion is not to be measured on the basis of other religions.

Due to the plurality of religious experience, Knitter recommends a correlation model towards dialogue. Such model seeks to promote authentic, truly mutual dialogical relationships among the religious communities of the world. In such relationships persons are encouraged to speak honestly with each other and listen with an open mind and with sincerity. The model assumes that every religion is self-fulfilling and therefore, forced conversion is totally rejected.

Dialogue acknowledges the diversity of religious experience at the same time underlining the impossibility of a unified world religion. It is hence, erroneous for some religions to assume some superiority and as such claim to be the only legitimate/authentic religions in total disregard of others.

b) Authentic Dialogue

Authentic dialogue is a mutual back and forth co-relationship of speaking and listening, teaching and learning witnessing and being witnessed to. Those engaged therefore, must not use their own religious experiences to measure the success or failures of others. It would be like measuring distance by use of kilograms, which is erroneous. An authentic dialogue cannot be realized if some religions insist on conversion or claim superiority and authenticity and hence not willing to learn from others. It should be noted that in authentic dialogue there are no winners and no losers and any attempts to convert would definitely paralyze the initiative. It calls for respect and genuine /open discussion capitalizing on the strength of each other rather than on the weaknesses.

30.4 Question

Examine meaning of interfaith dialogue and go on to show the principles that are required if dialogue has to be successful.

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30.5 Activity

Visit a religious institution to find out the possibilities of interfaith dialogue and the difficulties that are likely to be faced.

30.6 Summary

We found that dialogue require the treatment of each other with fairness and dignity as we would like to be treated by others. The need, for forgiveness and reconciliation is emphasized as well as respect and recognition of each others role in the creation of a more humane society. The willingness to teach and to be taught by others is indeed paramount and so is the need for communion with others. At this point pride and superiority complex must be swallowed for the sake of dialogue and reconciliation. This calls believers not just to live for themselves but also for others. The emphasis here is that at no time should anyone condemn other religious culture but should in stead find the strengths in each of the religious cultures.

30.7 Further Reading

Kung, H. 1986. *Christianity and the World Religions*. New York; Doubleday & Company.

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Karecki, M. 2001. *Dynamics of Inter-religious Encounter*. Pretoria, South Africa.